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Final Hit To CSE Mains 2026

GOVERNANCE

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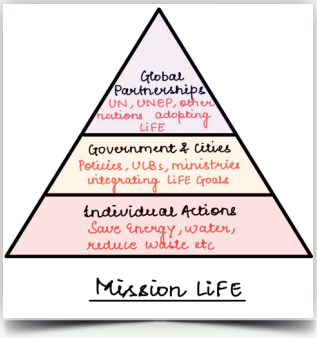
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SRIJAN ENROLLMENT

Replicable Diagrams

HUB-AND-SPOKE DIAGRAM

- **Details:** A central idea with branches leading to sub-themes or dimensions.
- **Used For:** Components of Citizen Charter etc.



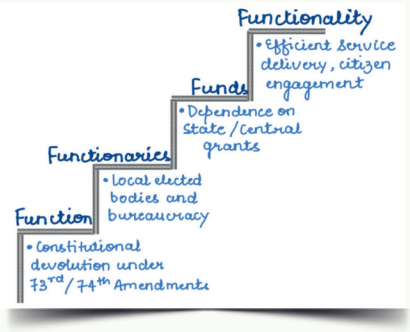


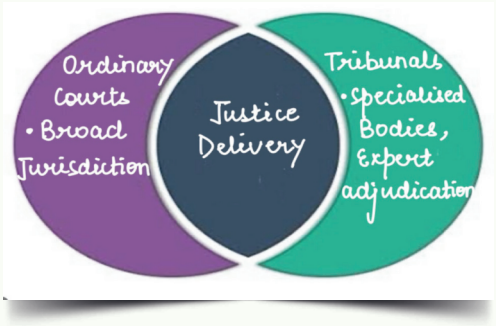
PYRAMID/HIERARCHY

- **Details:** A hierarchical diagram with levels from base to top.
- **Used For:** Constitutional Morality in Practice etc.

LADDER DIAGRAM

- **Details:** Step-by-step hierarchical diagram showing progression over stages.
- **Used For:** 4 F's of Local Governance etc.





VENN DIAGRAM

- **Details:** Showing overlap between two or three ideas.
- **Used For:** Justice delivery, , Trickle down effect, Food chain, etc.

INPUT-PROCESS-OUTPUT (IPO) MODEL

- **Details:** A three-part diagram showing what goes into a system, how it's processed, and the result.
- **Used For:** Cash tranfers under Government Schemes etc.



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HARSHITA GOYAL

2024



RAJ KRISHNA JHA

2024



PAKSHAL SECRETRY

2025

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1 Government Policies and Interventions for Development

A **policy** is a plan of action designed to achieve specific goals. **Public Policies** are governmental decisions about what gets done, who benefits, and how things are accomplished. These policies are often a mix of clear-cut rules, procedures, and considerations of fairness, effectiveness, and political realities.

MAJOR TYPES OF PUBLIC POLICY

Type of Public Policy	Purpose	Examples (Global)	Examples (India)
Distributive Policy	Provide services and benefits to citizens	Infrastructure development, education grants	PM Awas Yojana (housing), PM Gram Sadak Yojana (rural roads)
Regulatory Policy	Regulate behavior for public welfare	Environmental laws, food safety standards	Environment Protection Act, Motor Vehicles Act
Redistributive Policy	Reallocate resources for equity	Welfare schemes, progressive taxation	MGNREGA (employment guarantee), Food Security Act
Constituent Policy	Structure or reorganize government institutions	Formation of new commissions, constitutional reforms	Formation of NITI Aayog, 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments
Social Welfare Policy	Ensure basic well-being of citizens	Health insurance programs, pension schemes	Ayushman Bharat, National Social Assistance Programme
Foreign Policy	Manage international relations	Trade agreements, defense pacts	Act East Policy, Neighbourhood First Policy
Economic Policy	Stabilize and grow the economy	Budget allocations, monetary policy changes	Union Budget announcements, Monetary Policy of RBI

Characteristics of Public Policy

- **Public Interest:** The guiding principle is the **well-being of the citizens**. **Example:** The **National Policy on Persons with Disability (PwD)** by the MoSJ&E.
- **Goal-Oriented:** Policies are crafted to achieve specific **objectives set by the government**. **Example: Swachh Bharat Mission (Clean India Mission)** for improved sanitation across the country.
- **Collective Action:** Policymaking involves **collaboration between government officials and various stakeholders**. **Example: Under Swachh Bharat Mission,** the government nudges both citizens and institutions towards cleanliness.
- **Participatory and Consultative: Stakeholders have a voice** in shaping policies. Public consultations are increasingly used to gather citizen feedback on draft policies, promoting a more inclusive approach.
- **Dynamic and Evolving:** Policies adapt to **changing circumstances and societal needs**. **Example: National Education Policy (NEP) 2020**.
- **Government's Commitment:** Policies reflect the **government's response to critical issues** and are backed by **legal authority**. **Example:** Policies like **minimum wage regulations**, **Motor Vehicles Act** address societal concerns and are enforced through legal frameworks.

PUBLIC POLICY IN INDIA

India's public policy landscape is shaped by its diverse demographic, cultural, and economic characteristics, reflecting the nation's democratic ideals and aspirations for **inclusive growth**, **sustainable development**, and **social justice**.

Historical Evolution

- **Post-Independence (1947):**
  - **Focus on Nation-Building:** The Constitution provided the framework for policy, emphasizing equality, justice, and fundamental rights.
  - **Planned Development:** Five-Year Plans guided economic development, with a focus on industrial and agricultural growth.
  - **Era of Economic Reforms (1991):** India opened its economy to globalization and liberalization, shifting towards a market-oriented approach while prioritizing social welfare.
- **Public Policy Experience in India:**
  - **Structural Intervention:** Land reforms aimed to change the socio-economic structure but faced challenges in implementation due to lack of political will, weak bureaucracy, and limited public participation.
  - **Technological Intervention:** The Green Revolution boosted agricultural production but also led to regional disparities. This highlights the need for balanced development strategies.
  - **Anti-Poverty Intervention:** Programs like the National Rural Employment Programme aimed at poverty reduction but faced issues like inadequate coverage, corruption, and weak monitoring.

IMPACT OF PUBLIC POLICY ON PERSONAL CHOICES AND SOCIAL TIES

Positive Impacts

- **Promoting Gender Equality:** Eg: Beti Bachao Beti Padhao encourages female education and empowerment.
- **Supporting LGBTQ+ Rights:** Eg: Decriminalization of Section 377 allowed more open expression of identity.
- **Strengthening Family and Community Welfare:** Eg: Maternity Benefit (PMMVY) enhances maternal health and family support.

Negative Impacts

- **Reinforcement of Traditional Roles:** Some welfare schemes target only women as caregivers, reinforcing stereotypes. Eg: LPG connection under PMUY often registered in women's name but usage is still male-dominated.
- **Economic Dependence:** Conditional cash transfers may increase short-term dependence without building longterm autonomy.
- **Limited Awareness or Misuse:** Poorly communicated or complex policies often lead to confusion, limiting their intended behavioral change (e.g., GST implementation confusion among small traders).

Data-Based Policymaking in India: Challenges and Recommendations

Data-Based Policymaking included, using factual, reliable, and timely data to guide government decisions for effective policy outcomes.

Challenges

- **Political Influence on Data:** Data may be suppressed or delayed for political reasons. *Eg: Delay in release of NSSO consumption data (2017–18).*
- **Poor Use Despite Data Availability:** Large datasets often go under-utilized due to weak analytics capacity. *Eg: SECC 2011 data used inconsistently across schemes.*
- **Mismatch Between Official Data and Ground Reality:** Government figures may not reflect lived experiences. *Eg: High account coverage under Jan Dhan Yojana, but many accounts dormant.*
- **Limited Public Access and Transparency:** Lack of open data restricts civil society's ability to participate or hold institutions accountable.

Recommendations

- **Data Democratization:** Ensure public access to government data via open platforms. Eg: **Open Government Data (OGD) Platform** – Hosts datasets from various ministries for public use.
- **Civil Society Participation:** Involve local organizations in data collection and validation. Eg: *Pratham's Annual Status of Education Report (ASER)* providing grassroots educational data that fills gaps left by official surveys.
- **Use of New Technologies:** Integrate AI, big data, and real-time dashboards. *Eg: CoWIN portal for vaccination tracking.*
- **Strengthen State-Level Data Ecosystems:** As per **Dholakia Committee**, build capacity in state statistical agencies for real-time decision-making. Eg: *Andhra Pradesh's Real-Time Governance Society (RTGS*) uses real-time data analytics from citizen feedback, weather stations, and biometric attendance to improve service delivery.

TECHNOCRATIC SHIFT IN WELFARE

- Technocratic welfare refers to a shift from a rights-based approach to a data-driven and efficiency-focused model of welfare delivery.

- This model relies on technology, data algorithms, and centralized digital systems for distribution of benefits.
- A rights-based approach treats welfare services like food, education, and healthcare as legal entitlements, not charity. It empowers citizens to claim their rights and hold the state accountable..
  - **Example:** The RTI Act enables citizens to demand transparency from the government.

Key Challenges and Criticism of Technocratic Welfare

- **Loss of Citizen Agency:** Data-driven systems reduce citizens to data points instead of rights-holders, and rising RTI pendency shows declining public participation.
- **Exclusion of Vulnerable Groups:** Algorithmic systems exclude marginalised groups lacking digital access or literacy, and DBT errors may ignore genuinely excluded individuals.
- **Weakened Accountability:** Centralized grievance systems reduce local political responsibility, and technical resolution does not address root causes.
- **Efficiency over Human Welfare:** Efficiency-focused delivery may ignore dignity, and Aadhaar-related concerns highlight lack of safeguards.
- **Technological Dependence:** Over-reliance on technology leads to system failures, data breaches, and biometric errors causing exclusion.

Way Forward

- **Empowering States:** States should design context-specific welfare models to strengthen federalism and flexibility.
- **Community Impact Audits:** Social audits through Panchayats and SHGs (e.g., Kudumbashree) should be strengthened.
- **Rights-Based Framework:** Welfare must remain a legal entitlement to ensure accountability and citizen empowerment.
- **Strengthening Local Governance:** Local bodies should have greater control for context-sensitive delivery.
- **Human-Centric Technology:** Ensure data privacy, inclusivity, offline alternatives, and safeguards like bias audits and right to appeal.

POLICY CYCLE IN INDIA

Steps under Policy Cycle

- **Problem Identification:** Policymakers recognize issues needing government action, often triggered by societal demands or crises. *Example:* Farmers' protests highlighting the need for Minimum Support Price (MSP) reforms.
- **Agenda Setting:** Issues are prioritized using media attention and political engagement to push them onto the government's agenda. *Example:* Nationwide campaigns leading to Swachh Bharat Mission being prioritized.
- **Policy Formulation:** Executive offices, legislative committees, and interest groups draft proposals, define goals, weigh costs, and involve stakeholders. *Example:* Drafting of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 through public consultations.
- **Adoption/Legitimation:** Authorities formally approve the chosen policy, ensuring its legal and political acceptance. *Example:* Passing of the Goods and Services Tax (GST) Act by Parliament and state legislatures.



Fig. 1.1: Policy Life Cycle

- **Implementation:** Bureaucracies and agencies execute the policies, needing strong coordination and accountability. *Example:* Implementation of the Ayushman Bharat health scheme across states.
- **Evaluation:** Agencies assess outcomes to measure policy effectiveness and suggest changes. *Example:* NITI Aayog's evaluations of government schemes like Aspirational Districts Programme.
- **Policy Maintenance, Succession, or Termination:** Based on performance, policies are continued, modified, or discontinued. *Example:* Replacement of the Planning Commission with NITI Aayog for better policy planning.

ISSUES AND REFORMS IN INDIAN PUBLIC POLICY

Problem (with Example)	Solution/Measure
Over-centralization hampers local responsiveness – For instance, the uniform rollout of GST caused disruption for small businesses.	**Promote decentralization** and involve local bodies in planning (e.g., Gram Sabha participation in MGNREGS).

❖ **Data disconnect leads to poorly grounded policies** – During the COVID-19 lockdown in 2020, the absence of real-time data on migrants left millions stranded.	❖ **Enable data-driven policymaking** using real-time databases (e.g., SECC data for welfare targeting).
❖ **Political sway prioritizes short-term gains** – Frequent farm loan waivers compromise fiscal discipline and long-term reforms.	❖ **Ensure policy continuity** through judicial activism and transparency tools (e.g., RTI Act).
❖ **Limited public participation weakens policy relevance** – Policies often lack community input, making them less effective.	❖ **Foster collaboration** with academic and civil society groups (e.g., NITI Aayog expert panels).
❖ **Weak administration leads to corruption and leakage** – Welfare benefits are often cornered by elites due to weak local oversight.	❖ **Improve service delivery** with community monitoring (e.g., MGNREGA under Gram Sabha supervision).
❖ **Skill gaps in implementation affect outcomes** – Early issues in PM Ujjwala Yojana emerged due to untrained LPG distributors.	❖ **Focus on capacity building** and staff training (e.g., training modules in PMAY-Urban).
❖ **Faulty targeting excludes genuine beneficiaries** – Errors in identifying beneficiaries in PDS and LPG subsidies have been reported.	❖ **Use convergence of schemes** and integrated databases (e.g., Poshan Abhiyaan's multi-sectoral targeting).
❖ **Lack of public awareness reduces scheme uptake** – Many beneficiaries are unaware of their entitlements.	❖ **Empower communities** through awareness drives and social audits (e.g., Swachh Bharat's IEC campaigns).

BUREAUCRATS ROLE IN PUBLIC POLICY

Bureaucrats in India play a crucial role in both the formulation and implementation of policies. For instance, in the implementation of the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA), bureaucrats at various levels ensured the effective execution of the program, monitoring its progress and addressing challenges. They also provide technical expertise in policy-making, such as in the formulation of GST laws, and serve as intermediaries between the government and the public, ensuring transparency and accountability.

Challenges Faced by Bureaucrats and Suggestions

Challenges	Way Forward
❖ **Balancing Objectivity and Advocacy**: Ministries may face difficulty in balancing evidence-based policy making with advocacy.	❖ Institutionalize **independent advisory bodies** within ministries, such as NITI Aayog, which provides evidence-based policy suggestions independent of ministries.
❖ **Balancing Political Will and Expertise**: Political pressures may overshadow expert advice, leading to suboptimal decisions.	❖ Create formal platforms for **expert-bureaucratic collaboration,** like Ayushman Bharat's design, which involved both healthcare experts and bureaucratic leadership.
❖ **Resource Constraints in Implementation:** Lack of timely budget allocation and staff recruitment hinders policy execution.	❖ Ensure **timely budget allocations and staff recruitment** aligned with policy needs. For example, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Gram Jyoti Yojana improved resource flow for rural electrification.
❖ **Ministerial Control during Implementation**: Centralized control by ministries can hamper transparent implementation.	❖ **Maintain transparent reporting and performance audits;** for instance, the implementation of PMGSY is monitored through independent audits and geo-tagging.
❖ **Accountability for Policy Failures:** Lack of accountability systems can lead to individual blame for collective failures.	❖ **Build collective accountability** systems across agencies, as seen in the Aspirational Districts Programme, which reduces blame on individuals.
❖ **Clarity and Measurability of Goals:** Poorly defined or unmeasurable goals hinder effective policy implementation.	❖ **Mandate SMART** (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound) **goals** during formulation, as done in the National Skill Development Mission.

PLANNING

Planning is the process of setting goals, determining the best course of action to achieve those goals, and allocating resources accordingly. In governance and development, planning refers to a systematic, organized, and future-oriented approach undertaken by governments or institutions to promote economic growth, social welfare, and balanced regional development through targeted policies and programs.

Features of Indian Planning

- **Comprehensive Planning:** Aimed at economic growth and social progress. *Example:* Early focus on heavy industries; later, initiatives like Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan for education.
- **Prospective and Perspective Planning:** Combined short-term and long-term goals. **Example:** NITI Aayog's *"Strategy for New India @75"* (perspective plan) set targets till 2022-23, while the *Three-Year Action Agenda (2017–20)* and *Aspirational Districts Programme* served as prospective plans to achieve those goals.
- **Financial Planning:** Prioritized resource allocation. *Example:* Budgetary support for sectors like health (e.g., Ayushman Bharat).
- **Inclusive Growth:** Sought to bridge disparities. *Example:* Poverty declined post-1990s.
  - According to NITI Aayog's *National Multidimensional Poverty Index,* **135 million people** escaped multidimensional poverty between 2015–16 and 2019–21.
  - India has experienced a significant reduction in multidimensional poverty from 29.17% in 2013-14 to 11.28% in 2022-23, achieving the Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) target of halving poverty well ahead of the 2030 deadline.
- **Democratic Planning:** Stressed public participation. *Example:* Panchayati Raj institutions involved in plan implementation, For example: People's Plan Campaign
- **Public Sector Focus with Market Regulation:** State-led industrial development dominated early planning. *Example:* Mahalanobis Model in the Second Five-Year Plan.
- **Regulation of Private Sector:** Controlled private monopolies. *Example:* MRTP Act aimed at promoting fair competition.
- **Shift Towards Private Participation:** Expanded role for private sector post-1990s. *Example:* Rise in FDI inflows reflects openness to private investment.

MULTI-LEVEL PLANNING IN THE NEO-LIBERAL DEVELOPMENT PARADIGM (UPSC 2019)

Multi-level planning involves coordinated planning across different levels of government—central, state, and local. In the neo-liberal model, which promotes decentralization, market reforms, and private participation, this approach is vital for cost-effective and efficient development.

Features of Neo-Liberal Development Paradigm

- **Decentralization:** Transfers planning and decision-making to local levels.
- **Market-Oriented Reforms:** Emphasizes private sector efficiency and competition.
- **Public-Private Partnerships (PPP):** Encourages private investment in public services and infrastructure.

How Multi-Level Planning Helps

- **Better Local Participation:** Ensures plans align with community needs, reducing wastage.
- **More Responsive Governance:** Local bodies can quickly adapt to changing local conditions.
- **Improved Accountability:** Involvement of local stakeholders increases transparency and ownership.
- **Efficient Resource Use:** Decentralized planning avoids duplication and delays.

Examples

- **Panchayati Raj Institutions (India):** Grassroots planning through 73rd/74th Amendments improves responsiveness.
- **EU Cohesion Policy:** Multi-level coordination improves regional development through local participation.

Direct Benefit Transfer Scheme: Progress and Limitations (UPSC 2022)

Progress of the DBT Scheme:

- **Elimination of Middlemen & Leakages:** Aadhaar-linked transfers prevent fraud and ensure funds reach beneficiaries. *Example:* PAHAL removed 4.23 crore fake LPG connections, saving ₹59,599 crore.
- **Enhanced Transparency & Accountability:** Real-time tracking reduces fund diversion and improves monitoring. *Example:* PM-KISAN transfers ₹6,000/year directly to farmers' accounts.

- **Targeted Welfare Delivery:** Duplicate claims reduced through Aadhaar-linked bank accounts. *Example:* PM Ujjwala Yojana used DBT to provide 8 crore LPG connections.
- **Efficient Crisis Relief:** Swift fund transfers during emergencies reduce bureaucratic delays. *Example:* COVID-19 relief under PMGKY reached crores within days.

Limitations of the DBT Scheme:

- **Digital Divide:** Limited internet access and digital literacy in rural areas exclude vulnerable groups like the elderly and disabled. Example: Only **24% of rural households** have internet access, compared to **66% in urban areas**, hindering DBT effectiveness in rural regions.
  - Women are **33% less likely** to use mobile internet services than men, leading to gender disparities in accessing DBT benefits
- **Weak Banking Infrastructure:** Poor banking facilities in remote areas delay access to benefits.
- **Errors in Identification:** Wrong or missed identification of beneficiaries leads to exclusion. For instance, in Jharkhand, a woman reportedly died of starvation after her ration card was canceled due to Aadhaar-related issue
- **Limited Administrative Capacity:** Delays in disbursement and grievance redressal affect scheme efficiency.

NITI AAYOG

- Niti Aayog established on January 1, 2015, replaced the Planning Commission to promote cooperative and competitive federalism. Over 10 years, it has driven key initiatives like the Aspirational Districts Programme, Atal Innovation Mission, and data-driven governance through indices like the SDG India Index. It plays a crucial role in aligning India's policies with Sustainable Development Goals, fostering inclusive and sustainable growth.

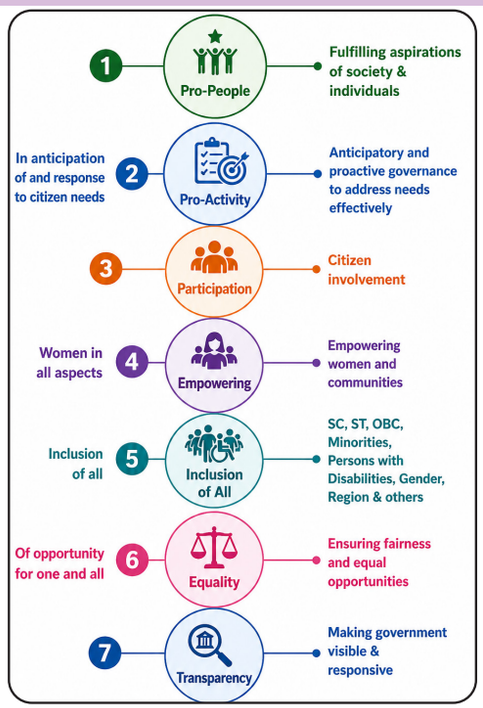


Fig. 1.2: NITI Aayog's Pillars of Effective Governance

What Makes NITI Aayog Successful

- **Decentralized Planning**: **NITI Aayog engages state governments** closely, exemplified by the Aspirational Districts Program (ADP), fostering collaboration for development in lagging districts.
- **Evidence-Based Policymaking**: **NITI Aayog prioritizes data-driven decisions**, evident through its Knowledge and Innovation Hub, providing insights like the "Sustainable Development Goals - India Index."
- **Long-Term Vision**: **NITI Aayog focuses on future needs**, as seen in initiatives like the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT), aiming to enhance urban infrastructure in 500 cities by 2022.
- **Cooperative and Competitive Federalism**: **NITI Aayog promotes collaboration and competition among states**, Initiatives like the Aspirational Districts Program and NITI Aayog's Team India Hub promote Centre-State collaboration for regional development.
- **Expert-Driven Approach**: **NITI Aayog taps into diverse expertise**, forming task forces like the one on Artificial Intelligence, including prominent figures for informed policymaking.
- **Monitoring and Evaluation**: **NITI Aayog actively tracks program impact**, employing tools like the "Real-Time Monitoring System" for efficient implementation and corrections.
- **Drive Innovation:** Initiatives like the **Atal Innovation Mission** aim to create a vibrant innovation ecosystem across India.

NITI Aayog: Challenges, Solutions, and Contemporary Examples

Limitation	Solution with Example
Limited Influence – NITI Aayog's advisory role limits enforcement, as seen during demonetization and GST rollout.	Strengthen mandate by giving NITI Aayog a greater role in implementation and monitoring. E.g., It had raised concerns over the weakening of the RTI Act but had no power to intervene.

Financial Constraints – Lacks autonomy to directly fund states, limiting program impact.	Create a dedicated financial pool for strategic interventions. E.g., Aspirational Districts Programme relies on scheme convergence due to funding limitations.
Socioeconomic Concerns – Inequality and poverty persist despite policy efforts.	Promote inclusive growth models with better outcome monitoring. E.g., Oxfam reports continue to highlight wealth inequality in India.
Questionable Neutrality – Political bias in appointments affects credibility.	Ensure merit-based, transparent appointments and institutional autonomy
Data Transparency Issues – Restricted data sharing weakens public trust.	Adopt open data policies and publish methodologies. E.g., Concerns raised on Digital Personal Data Protection Act impacting transparency and access.

Major Initiatives/Steps by Niti Aayog

Economic Development and Planning

- **Vision India@2047**: NITI Aayog's long-term plan to make India a global leader in innovation, human development, and sustainability.
  - It targets a **$30 trillion economy** with **$18,000–20,000 per capita income** by 2047.
- **Fiscal Health Index 2025:** NITI Aayog ranked 18 states on fiscal management. Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Goa, and Jharkhand topped the list for strong GDP growth and public spending.

Social Development and Welfare

- **Aspirational Districts Programme**: Launched to uplift districts lagging in key social indicators, fostering comprehensive development.
- **National Health Stack**: A digital platform revolutionizing healthcare delivery, enhancing efficiency, and improving accessibility of health services.

Innovation and Technology

- **Reimagining India's R&D Strategy:** In April 2025, NITI Aayog released a paper stressing the need to overhaul India's R&D system. India's R&D spending remains below $100 billion, far behind China's $496 billion.
- **Atal Innovation Mission (AIM)**: Fostering innovation and entrepreneurship through various programs, empowering startups, and driving innovation-led growth.
- **National Strategy on Artificial Intelligence (AI)**: Formulated to leverage AI for socio-economic growth, addressing challenges and maximizing opportunities in various sectors.
- **National Data and Analytics Platform (NDAP)**: A centralized platform facilitating access to diverse datasets for evidence-based policymaking and decision-making.

Environment and Sustainability

- **Boosting Domestic Coking Coal:** In November 2024, NITI Aayog recommended adding coking coal to India's critical minerals list.India imports 85% of its coking coal, essential for steel making. The push aims to reduce imports and support Net Zero goals by 2070.
- **National Strategy for Clean Air**: Developed to address air pollution challenges, promoting clean technologies and sustainable practices to improve air quality nationwide.
- **Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy Framework**: Drafted to promote adoption of electric vehicles, reduce pollution, and enhance energy security.
- **Blue Economy Policy Framework**: Drafted to harness the potential of maritime resources and promote sustainable development of coastal and marine sectors, including fisheries, aquaculture, and tourism.

Education and Youth Empowerment

- **Atal Tinkering Labs (ATLs)**: Established in schools to nurture creativity, innovation, and problem-solving skills among students through hands-on learning.
- **AIM-PRIME (Program for Researchers on Innovations, Market-Readiness & Entrepreneurship)**: Bridging the gap between research and commercialization, providing support to researchers and innovators.
- **India-ASEAN Youth Summit**: Fostering cultural exchange, collaboration, and mutual understanding among youth from India and ASEAN countries, promoting regional cooperation and connectivity.

- **National Education Policy (NEP) Implementation**: Supporting the effective implementation of the National Education Policy 2020, aimed at transforming the education landscape and promoting holistic development.

Urban Development and Infrastructure

- **Smart Cities Mission**: Collaborating with state governments to develop and implement smart city projects aimed at enhancing urban infrastructure, services, and sustainability.

ASPIRATIONAL DISTRICT PROGRAMME

Aspirational Districts Programme	Aspirational Blocks Programme
Launched in **January 2018** by Hon'ble Prime Minister	Launched in **January 2023** by Hon'ble Prime Minister
It covers 112 Districts to ensure the speedy development of the relatively backward and remote areas of the country. It impacts on improving key indicators that uplift the lives of its citizens.	It was aimed for the saturation of essential government services in 500 Blocks across the country in multiple domains such as health, nutrition etc.
Focuses on five themes: ❖ Health & Nutrition (30% weightage, 13 indicators) ❖ Education (30%, 8 indicators) ❖ Agriculture & Water Resources (20% through 10 indicator) ❖ Financial Inclusion & Skill Development (10% through 10 indicators) ❖ Infrastructure (10% through 7 indicators)	**Focuses on five themes:** ❖ Health & Nutrition ❖ Education ❖ Agriculture and Allied Services ❖ Basic Infrastructure ❖ Social Development
Progress in measured on **81 indicators** of development	Progress is measured on **40 indicators** of development

Challenges under Aspirational District and Block Program

- **Resource Gaps:** Lack of trained staff and infrastructure delayed real-time data updates. *Eg: Slow reporting of school learning outcomes in remote districts.*
- **Fragmented Data Systems:** Poor coordination between departments led to duplication. *Eg: Overlap between health and nutrition data from NHM and ICDS.*
- **Inconsistent Data Quality:** Data collection lacked standard tools, reducing reliability. *Eg: Variation in learning achievement scores across surveys.*
- **Target-Focused Approach:** Emphasis on hitting numbers ignores quality of services. *Eg: Rise in institutional deliveries, but maternal health outcomes didn't improve proportionately.*

Way Forward for Aspirational District and Block Program

- **Refining Indicators**: Regularly update indicators, including renewable energy access, to stay relevant. Eg: **Himachal Pradesh**'s renewable energy projects can serve as an example for integrating sustainability.
- **Targeted Support**: Provide additional resources to underperforming districts. Eg: **Kalahandi (Odisha)** improved health and education with targeted interventions from central support (NITI Aayog, 2019).
- **Building Capacity**: Deploy dedicated personnel like **Aspirational District Fellows** (e.g., **Nandurbar, Maharashtra**) to ensure focused efforts. Partnerships with technical institutions.
- Eg: **IIT Hyderabad** in **Andhra Pradesh** showcases the importance of expert collaborations for rural development (Ministry of Rural Development, 2020).

Sampoornata Abhiyan

NITI Aayog launched the **'Sampoornata Abhiyan'** from **4th July – 30th September 2024**, aimed to achieve saturation of key health, agriculture, and education indicators in **112 Aspirational Districts** and **500 Aspirational Blocks**.

Best Practices From India's Aspirational Districts Programme

- **Health and Nutrition**
  - **Model Anganwadis (Ramgarh, Jharkhand):** Promote best practices in childcare and community outreach.
  - **'Hamar Swasthya' App (Rajnandangaon, Chhattisgarh):** Enables early detection of chronic diseases.
  - **Hostels for Pregnant Women (Vizianagaram, Andhra Pradesh):** Offer prenatal care and support.

- **Education**
  - **Bal Sansad (Shrawasti and Bahraich, Uttar Pradesh):** Empowers students through mock parliaments.
  - **BALA - Building as Learning Aid (Shrawasti, Uttar Pradesh):** Creates child-friendly learning environments.
  - **Project Second Innings (Dahod, Gujarat):** Recruits retired teachers to boost attendance and learning outcomes.
- **Agriculture and Water Resources**
  - **Agriculture Entrepreneur Scheme (Ramgarh, Jharkhand):** Trains farmers in sustainable and profitable practices.
  - **Horticulture Price Agreement Initiative (Chhatarpur, Madhya Pradesh):** Guarantees fair prices and market access for farmers.
  - **'Taanka' rainwater harvesting (Sonbhadra, Uttar Pradesh):** Conserves water for dry seasons.
- **Financial Inclusion and Skill Development**
  - **Solar MAMAs (Gumla, Jharkhand):** Trains women to manufacture solar lights for unelectrified villages.
  - **Khawa cluster concept (Osmanabad, Maharashtra):** Helps farmers increase income by processing milk into a shelf-stable product.
- **Basic Infrastructure**
  - **Green technologies in Road Construction (Goalpara, Assam):** Uses recycled materials and reduces dependence on natural resources.
  - **'Liter of Light' Portable Lights (Ranchi, Jharkhand):** Provides low-cost lighting solutions using recycled plastic bottles.
  - **Swajal Water Testing (Barpeta, Assam):** Empowers communities to test their drinking water quality.
- **Governance**
  - **BDO Scorecards (Hazaribagh, Jharkhand):** Transparently assesses the performance of block development officers.
  - **Lok Sewak App (Khandwa, Madhya Pradesh):** Uses geotagging to monitor attendance of government officials.
  - **Infrastructure Snapshot App (Goalpara, Assam):** Allows citizens to report infrastructure issues using their smartphones.

Key Words

Citizen-Focused Development Policy, Strict Regulation to Facilitative Approach, Government-Centric to Citizen-Centric, Short-Term to Sustainable Growth, Proactive, Innovative, and Adaptive Government, Results-Driven Attitude, Modern Local Governance, Multiple Crises to Cross-Sector Progress

Previous Year Questions	Year
1. The Gati-Shakti Yojana needs meticulous coordination between the government and the private sector to achieve the goal of connectivity. Discuss.	2022
2. Reforming the government delivery system through the Direct Benefit Transfer Scheme is a progressive step, but it has its limitations too. Comment.	2022
3. In the context of the neo-liberal paradigm of developmental planning, multi-level planning is expected to make operations cost-effective and remove many implementation blockages – Discuss.	2019
4. Policy contradictions among various competing sectors and stakeholders have resulted in inadequate protection and prevention of degradation to the environment. Comment with relevant illustrations.	2018

2 Development Processes and the Role of NGOs, SHGs, and Other Stakeholders

DEVELOPMENT

The United Nations defines development as a comprehensive economic, social, and political process aimed at improving the well-being and quality of life of people. It encompasses multiple dimensions, including economic growth, social inclusion, environmental sustainability, and the promotion of human rights and freedoms.

Development Process: Key Elements

- **Planned and Phased Implementation**: Development follows structured planning, often through strategic frameworks and missions. **Example**: The **Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY)** was launched with clear phases and targets to ensure "Housing for All" by 2022, demonstrating phased delivery through central-state collaboration.
- **Participatory Governance**: Involves citizens, civil society, and local bodies in decision-making to ensure development reflects real needs. **Example**: The **Gram Sabha under the Panchayati Raj Act** allows villagers to discuss and approve plans under **MGNREGA**, empowering bottom-up planning.
- **Dynamic and Contextual**: Development adapts to changing socio-economic and political realities. **Example**: The **shift from the Planning Commission to NITI Aayog** reflects India's evolving governance needs, focusing more on cooperative federalism and real-time policy formulation.

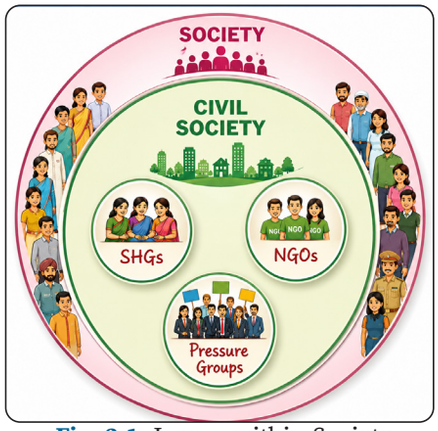


Fig. 2.1: Layers within Society

- **Institutional Collaboration**: Requires coordinated efforts of government bodies, private sector, and global institutions. **Example**: The **National Health Mission** brings together central and state governments, NGOs, and development partners like **WHO** to improve healthcare access.
- **Monitoring and Evaluation**: Ongoing assessment ensures accountability and helps fine-tune implementation. **Example**: The **Aspirational Districts Programme** uses real-time dashboards and ranking mechanisms to monitor progress in lagging districts and adjust strategies accordingly.

HUMAN RESOURCE DEVELOPMENT (UPSC 2023)

Human Resource Development (HRD) refers to the systematic approach to nurturing and fostering the talents, competencies, and skills of individuals, thereby contributing to national development.

Approaches to Human Development

- **Income Approach:** The level of income reflects the level of freedom an individual enjoys.
- **Welfare Approach:** People are not participants in development but only passive recipients. The government is responsible for increasing levels of human development by maximizing expenditure on welfare.
- **Basic Needs Approach:** The question of human choices is ignored, and the emphasis is on the provision of basic needs of defined sections;
- **Six Basic Needs:** Health, education, food, water supply, sanitation, and housing.
- **Capability Approach:** Associated with Prof. Amartya Sen; Building human capabilities in the areas of health, education and access to resources is the key to increasing human development.

Challenges in Human Resource Development

- **Poor learning outcomes:** ASER reports show weak comprehension and lack of infrastructure in schools.
- **Skill mismatch:** 30% of graduates are unemployable due to lack of job-ready skills.
- **Teacher quality issues:** Training gaps and scams in B.Ed highlight weak regulation.
- **Weak healthcare access:** NFHS shows rural areas lack primary health services.
- **Limited vocational training:** Despite Skill India, access to skill programs remains poor.

Measures to Improve Human Resource Development

- Promote **project-based learning** in schools to boost critical thinking.
- Strengthen **industry-academia links** for job-relevant education.
- Ensure **continuous teacher training** based on Singapore's model.
- Expand **telemedicine** services to improve rural healthcare.
- Encourage **innovation through incubation centres** in colleges.

Human Development Report 2025 – Key Highlights

Global Position:

- **Stalled Progress:** Slowest HDI rise since 1990 (excluding COVID years); very high HDI for most nations now delayed by decades.
- **Top & Bottom:** Iceland (1st, HDI 0.972), South Sudan (193rd, HDI 0.388).
- **Inequality:** Rich nations advance, poorer ones stagnate.
- **AI Impact:** 1 in 5 people use AI; 60% hopeful for jobs, 50% fear displacement; calls for human-centric AI policies.

India Position:

- **Rank:** 130th (HDI: 0.685); improved from 133rd (2022).
- **Category:** Medium HDI; nearing high HDI (≥0.700).
- **Life Expectancy:** 72 years (up from 58.6 in 1990).
- **Education:** 13 years expected schooling (up from 8.2 in 1990).
- **GNI per capita:** USD 9,046 (up from USD 2,167 in 1990).
- **Poverty:** 135 million exited multidimensional poverty (2015–21).
- **AI Skills:** World's highest AI skills growth; 20% AI researchers stay in India

SKILL DEVELOPMENT (UPSC 2023)

Skill development acts as a crucial bridge between education and employment by transforming academic knowledge into practical abilities. In today's competitive economy, it equips individuals with industry-relevant skills, enhancing their employability and productivity.

Success of Skill Development Programmes in India

- **Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL):** Helps informal workers get formal certification.
- **Sector Skill Councils (SSCs):** Ensure training matches industry needs.
- **International Collaborations:** Ties with countries like Germany and Japan help improve training quality and open foreign job markets.
- **Skill Universities:** Institutions like Delhi Skill and Entrepreneurship University mix academics with practical skills.
- **Women-Centric Schemes:** Programs like "Nari Shakti" promote skill training for women.
- **Minority Schemes:** Nai Manzil, USTAAD, and MANAS support traditional skills and economic inclusion.

Linkages between Education and Skill Development

- **Basic Knowledge:** Subjects like maths and science form the base for technical skills.
- **Literacy & Numeracy:** Needed for further training and daily job functions.
- **Soft Skills:** Education helps build communication and teamwork skills.
- **Research & Innovation:** Higher education (e.g., IITs) supports innovation and advanced skills.

Linkages between Skill Development and Employment

- **Job Readiness:** Short courses (e.g., Google Career Certificates) help get jobs.
- **Entrepreneurship:** Skill training supports self-employment (e.g., Startup India).
- **Upskilling:** Online platforms help professionals stay updated (e.g., LinkedIn courses).
- **Remote Work Skills:** Courses teach tools needed for online jobs (e.g., Coursera, Udemy).

COLLABORATIVE GOVERNANCE: ROLE OF GOVERNMENT AND PRIVATE SECTOR (UPSC 2022)

Government–private coordination refers to collaborative efforts between the public sector and private enterprises in planning, financing, and executing development projects. Such coordination ensures efficient resource use, faster implementation, and improved service delivery, especially in large-scale initiatives like infrastructure development. Eg: Gati Shakti Yojana a step in that direction.

Why Government–Private Coordination is Essential

- **Policy Support:** Govt. must simplify procedures and provide a clear regulatory framework.
- **Public-Private Partnerships (PPP):** Private investment can support limited public funds. EG. : Noida Yamuna Expressway – a successful PPP project.
- **Technology & Innovation:** Private sector brings modern technology, global practices, and efficient project execution.
- **Skill Development:** Joint training programs can ensure a skilled workforce for large-scale infrastructure projects.
- **Monitoring & Evaluation:** Joint oversight ensures transparency, accountability, and timely project delivery.

COOPERATION AND PARTNERSHIP IN DEVELOPMENT (UPSC 2019)

- Cooperation and partnership among various service sectors are essential components of development discourse. These partnerships bridge gaps among sectors, fostering a culture of collaboration and team spirit that contributes to more effective development outcomes.
- In India, cooperation among sectors has played a key role in development. Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs) have helped build important infrastructure like roads and airports by combining government support with private expertise. In the health and education sectors, programs like school health initiatives and National Deworming Day show how working together can improve children's well-being.
- Similarly, rural development has seen success through the combined efforts of schemes like MGNREGA, NRLM, and IWMP, which together aim to improve employment, livelihoods, and water management in villages.
- Cooperation brings many benefits. It leads to innovation by encouraging new ideas and better solutions. Sharing resources saves money and avoids repeating efforts. It also ensures that services reach everyone, making development more inclusive

CHALLENGES ASSOCIATED WITH DEVELOPMENT PROCESS IN INDIA

- **Economic Inequality:** The top 1% of Indians own 40.1% of national wealth, highlighting widening income and wealth disparities.
- **Environmental Degradation:** Rapid industrialisation has increased pollution, deforestation, and resource depletion; India has 14 of the world's 20 most polluted cities.
- **Jobless Growth:** High GDP growth has not translated into proportional employment generation, leading to rising unemployment and underemployment.
- **Bureaucratic Red Tape:** Excessive regulations and administrative delays slow infrastructure projects and reduce ease of doing business.
- **Corruption and Resource Leakage:** Corruption in welfare delivery systems causes diversion of public resources and weakens the impact of development schemes.
- **Low Investment in Education and Health:** Inadequate public spending on education and healthcare limits human capital development and reduces workforce productivity.
- **Gender Inequality:** Women continue to face disparities in employment, wages, education, healthcare, and political representation.
- **Regional Imbalances:** Uneven development across states has widened disparities in income, infrastructure, and access to opportunities.
- **Agrarian Distress:** Rising input costs, low farm incomes, indebtedness, and climate uncertainties continue to affect farmers' livelihoods.

Way Forward

- **Policy Formulation and Planning: Define clear, measurable goals** based on needs assessments. **Example:** The 2015 **Smart Cities Mission** aimed to develop **100 cities** with advanced urban planning and technology.
- **Stakeholder Engagement: Involve all relevant stakeholders** to ensure support and gather insights. **Example:** The **Swachh Bharat Mission** engaged communities to tailor local sanitation strategies.
- **Legislation and Regulation: Create legal frameworks** to support and enforce policy implementation. **Example:** The **Goods and Services Tax (GST)** was established through new laws to unify the tax system across India.
- **Resource Allocation: Provide sufficient funding** for policy execution. **Example: MGNREGA** was funded to guarantee rural employment for **100 days per household annually**.
- **Monitoring and Evaluation: Set and assess performance metrics** to track policy success. **Example:** The **Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana** used monitoring to track new bank accounts, assessing financial inclusion efforts.

CIVIL SOCIETY

- Civil society encompasses a wide range of entities such as organisations, community groups, NGOs, labour unions, indigenous groups, charitable organisations, faith-based organisations, professional associations, and foundations, as defined by the World Bank.
- Civil society organisations (CSOs) are characterised by voluntary participation, non-profit motivation, pluralism, and accountability. They operate independently from the government and business sectors, advocating for the rights of marginalised groups and promoting social good.
- Prominent examples of CSOs include the World Wide Fund for Nature (WWF), Greenpeace, the Danish Refugee Council (DRC), and Reporters Without Borders.

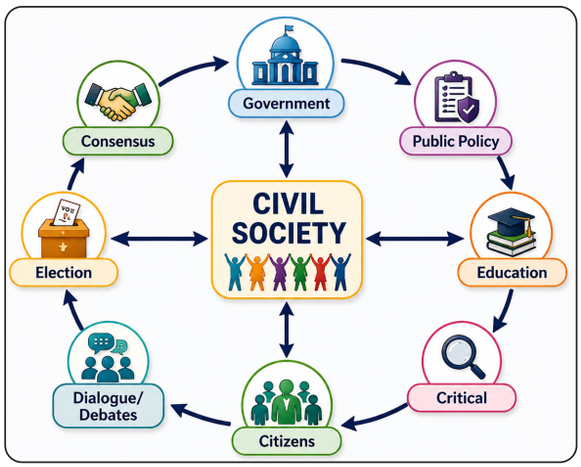


Fig. 2.2: Civil Society

Significance of Civil Society as Non State Actor in Governance (UPSC 2016)

- **Promoting Transparency and Accountability** Social audits are organized to monitor government schemes like MGNREGA, ensuring transparency. Additionally, people are empowered to file RTI applications, promoting access to public information and enhancing accountability.
- **Promotes Decentralisation:** Civil society promotes decentralization by supporting local decision-making. It strengthens PRIs and Urban Local Bodies ULBs, encouraging active participation in Gram Sabhas and ward committees.
- **Acts as a Watchdog:** Civil society keeps an eye on government actions and exposes corruption or delays. Through campaigns, media, and legal action, it brings important issues to public attention and demands accountability.
  - NGOs such as the Centre for Science and Environment (CSE) act as watchdogs, ensuring that environmental policies are not only formulated but also properly implemented.

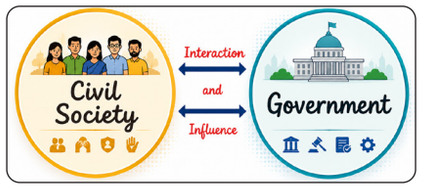


Fig. 2.3: Civil Society and Government

- **Encourages Innovation and Partnerships:** Civil society fosters innovation and partnerships by collaborating with the government and private sector to improve service delivery. Examples include health camps, school improvement programs, and sanitation drives.
- **Investing in Capacity Building**: Institutions like Azim Premji University offer specialized courses for NGO professionals, helping build their capabilities to manage and lead organisations effectively.
- **Enhancing Communication and Collaboration**: The NGO Darpan portal, created by NITI Aayog, facilitates better interaction and collaboration between the government, NGOs, and the private sector.
- **Encouraging Volunteerism**: Platforms like the National Service Scheme (NSS) provide opportunities for young Indians to engage in public services, thereby strengthening civic engagement.
- **Facilitating Citizen Participation:** Organisations like the Janaagraha Centre for Citizenship and Democracy engage citizens in urban governance projects, making cities more livable and promoting more interactive and participatory governance.



Fig. 2.4: Types of Civil Society Oragnisation (CSO)

CSOs Perceived as Anti-State Actors [UPSC 2025]

- **Policy Criticism:** CSOs' opposition to state actions on land, environment, or rights makes them appear obstructive to development.

- **Foreign Funding Concerns:** Allegations of external influence through foreign funding under laws like FCRA create suspicion about their intentions and loyalty.

  Example: Amnesty International India faced restrictions under FCRA over alleged violations.
- **Confrontational Tactics:** Use of protests, PILs, and campaigns challenging government decisions makes them appear adversarial.

  Example: Kudankulam anti-nuclear protests were seen as delaying a national energy project.
- **Transparency Issues:** Weak internal accountability and opaque functioning in some CSOs raise concerns about credibility and motives.
- **Narrative Conflict:** Exposure of corruption, policy failures, or misuse of power leads to clashes with state narratives, resulting in branding as anti-establishment.

Contribution of Civil Society in Women's Political Representation in State Legislatures (UPSC 2023)

- **Sensitization:** Groups like *Jagori* and *Swayam* run awareness campaigns on women's rights and promote political participation at community levels.
- **Leadership Training:** The *Women's Political Empowerment Program* by the Institute of Social Sciences has trained over 15,000 women in Panchayati Raj, preparing them for leadership roles in state legislatures. Organizations like *Swayam* also train women in political rights and campaigning skills.
- **Policy Advocacy:** The *Centre for Social Research* has been active in pushing for reforms like the Women's Reservation Bill to ensure more seats for women in legislatures.
- **Research and Documentation:** *PRIDE India* and similar groups gather data and publish research to support evidence-based advocacy for women's representation.
- **Grassroots Mobilization:** SEWA (Self Employed Women's Association) works to organize and empower rural women, creating a strong base for future women leaders.

NON-GOVERNMENTAL ORGANIZATIONS (NGO)

- An NGO (Non-Governmental Organization) is defined by the World Bank as "a not-for-profit organization that pursues activities to relieve suffering, promote the interests of the poor, protect the environment, provide basic social services, or undertake community development."
- In India, NGOs are legally classified into three main types:
  - **Societies** (registered under the Societies Registration Act, 1860), **Trusts** (governed by the Indian Trusts Act, 1882 or respective state acts), and **Section 8 Companies** (registered under the Companies Act, 2013 for promoting charitable objectives).
- As per a 2019 report by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, India houses approximately 3.2 million NGOs, outnumbering schools and health centers, underlining their significant role.

Constitutional Provisions Related to NGO

- Article 19(1)(c): Allows the right to form associations.
- Article 43 to promote cooperatives in rural areas.
- The Concurrent List mentions charitable institutions, charitable and religious institutions.

Role of NGOs

- **Implementers of Welfare Schemes:** NGOs act as a bridge between the government and beneficiaries, often helping with outreach, last-mile delivery, and real-time feedback. Eg: SEWA (Self-Employed Women's Association) in Gujarat helps implement women-centric schemes.
- **Catalysts and Collaborators:** They work with governments to design, pilot, and improve welfare programs by offering ground-level insights and innovation.
- **Advocates for Social Justice:** NGOs raise issues that the state may ignore or under-prioritize—like caste discrimination, gender injustice, and LGBTQ+ rights. Eg: Naz Foundation's role in the decriminalization of homosexuality.
- **Environmental Protectors:** NGOs conduct advocacy, legal interventions, and community mobilization to protect ecosystems and biodiversity. Eg: WWF-India and Vanashakti work on biodiversity and wetland protection. (UPSC 2015)
- **Awareness Builders:** They disseminate information on laws, rights, and welfare schemes—empowering citizens, especially the marginalized, to claim their entitlements.

Impact of NGOs

- **Improved Scheme Effectiveness:** Their grassroots presence enhances targeting, transparency, and accountability in public service delivery.
- **Policy Changes and Legal Reforms:** NGO efforts have led to the formulation and enforcement of critical laws. Eg: Centre for Social Research's advocacy contributed to strengthening the PCPNDT Act against female feticide.
- **Socio-Economic Development:** NGOs contribute to poverty alleviation, health access, and sustainable development. Eg: Goonj recycles urban waste into usable products for rural communities, addressing rural development and urban sustainability.
- **Environmental Outcomes:** Their work leads to conservation of flora and fauna, reduced pollution, and legal action against ecological violations.
- **Human Rights Protection:** NGOs protect vulnerable groups from abuse, ensuring dignity, legal support, and access to justice.

Case Studies of Various NGO's Working In India

- **Imparting Education:** The Kerala Sastra Sahitya Parishad (KSSP) played a pivotal role in achieving near 100% literacy in Kerala through grassroots campaigns, literacy drives, and social mobilization, making education **accessible statewide.**
- **Securing the Interests of the Poor:** In Mumbai, NGOs like **YUVA and SPARC** resisted forced slum demolitions and worked on improving living conditions by providing housing projects, basic services, and policy advocacy for slum dwellers.
- **Role in Disaster Management: NGOs like Rapid Response** have provided critical disaster relief, including in Assam and Bihar during the 2024 floods, setting up emergency kitchens, health camps, and shelters for displaced families.

Challenges Associated with NGOs (UPSC 2021, 2015)

- **Concerns related to their Legitimacy and Accountability:** According to the CBI (2015), there is one NGO for every 600 Indian people.
  - However, there is a lack of transparency among NGOs in India and just 10% of NGOs filed annual income and expenditure statements.
  - Thousands of nonprofits and volunteer groups receive government grants but fail to specify how they use them.
  - In a study, the Intelligence Bureau accused "foreign-funded" NGOs of funding anti-nuclear and anti-coal-fired power plant protests as well as anti-GMO protests across the world, accusing them of "acting as instruments for foreign policy interests of Western governments." The NGOs are said to be collaborating with a network of local organizations to reduce GDP growth by 2–3%.
- **Fund Misuse:** Allegations of misappropriation of government and foreign funds affect credibility.

  Eg: Cases reported against Association of Moral Guide and Service to Poor (Odisha) and Asha Bal Mandir Shiksha Samiti (Jaipur).
- **Regulatory Constraints:** FCRA restrictions limit foreign funding and operational flexibility.

  Eg: Mandatory single bank account and reduced administrative expenditure under recent amendments.
- **Urban Bias:** NGOs concentrated in urban areas; rural NGOs remain weak due to low awareness and poor infrastructure.
- **Declining Volunteerism:** Youth prefer professional careers over voluntary social work.
- **Funding Shortage:** Limited grants and delays in approvals restrict NGO functioning.

NGOs and Civil Society (UPSC 2021)

NGOs and Civil Society play a crucial role in public service delivery, especially in reaching marginalized communities. Through initiatives like Goonj's "Cloth for Work," they provide essential services to remote areas. Their ability to introduce innovative solutions, such as Barefoot College training rural women as solar engineers, addresses local needs effectively. By involving communities in decision-making, as seen with Pratham's educational programs, these organizations ensure services are tailored to specific needs.

Government Measures to Regulate NGOs

- **Enhanced FCRA Compliance Requirements**: The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has mandated that NGOs registered under the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) must now provide detailed disclosures of both movable and immovable assets created using foreign funds.

- **Imposition of Time Limits on Foreign Fund Utilization**: As of April 7, 2025, the government has set a three-year limit for NGOs to receive foreign funds after obtaining prior permission under the FCRA, with a four-year timeframe for utilizing these funds.
- **Cancellation of FCRA Licenses for Non-Compliance**: Over the past five years, the MHA has canceled the FCRA registrations of more than 6,600 NGOs due to violations of the law. Notably, in 2024, the registrations of five NGOs, including the Centre for Policy Research, were revoked for alleged FCRA violations.
- **Rejection of FCRA Renewal Applications**: In 2025, the government rejected the FCRA renewal applications of 466 NGOs for failing to meet eligibility criteria as per the FCRA, 2010, and its rules.
- **Designation of NITI Aayog as Nodal Agency**: NITI Aayog continues to serve as the nodal agency for the registration and accreditation of NGOs seeking government funding, facilitating better coordination and oversight.
  - **NGO DARPAN Portal:** NGO-DARPAN is an e-governance platform by NITI Aayog that facilitates interaction between NGOs/VOs and key government bodies. It helps maintain a transparent, digital database of registered NGOs, enabling streamlined collaboration and access to government schemes. Initially managed by the Planning Commission, it has been under NITI Aayog's purview since January 1, 2015.
- **Vijay Kumar Committee:** Recommended that information related to NGOs should be available in the form of a searchable database to promote transparency and ease of access for stakeholders.
  - It also suggested that **NITI Aayog** be designated as the nodal agency to oversee various interactions between NGOs and the Government, ensuring better coordination and regulatory oversight.

How to Strengthen NGOs' Role (UPSC 2015)

- **Policy Involvement:** Include NGOs in making environmental policies using their grassroots experience.
- **Capacity Building:** Train NGOs and provide tools and knowledge for better work.
- **Funding Support:** Improve access to domestic and foreign funds, give tax benefits.
- **Collaboration:** Promote joint efforts between NGOs, government, and private sector.
- **Public Awareness:** Encourage NGOs to involve people and create environmental awareness.

RTI and NGO

In a landmark judgment (*D.A.V. College Trust and Management Society vs. Director of Public Instructions,* 2019), the **Supreme Court ruled that NGOs receiving substantial government funding fall under the ambit of the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005**.

- **Public Authority Under RTI Act**: According to **Section 2(h) of the RTI Act**, a "public authority" includes any authority, body, or institution of self-government established or constituted by: the Constitution, any law made by Parliament or State Legislature, or notification issued by the appropriate government.
  - It also includes **any non-government organization substantially financed, directly or indirectly, by funds provided by the government**.
- The Court clarified that **"substantial funding" does not necessarily mean majority funding**. Even partial but critical financial support that enables an NGO to perform its functions can bring it under the purview of the RTI Act.

FCRA Amendment 2020: Stricter Regulations on Foreign Funding of NGO (UPSC 2015)

- **Mandatory SBI Branch for Foreign Funds:** All foreign contributions must be received in a specific branch of the State Bank of India (SBI), New Delhi.
  - ***Implication:*** Reflects the government's intent to closely monitor and regulate the source and flow of foreign donations.
- **Ban on Re-Transfer of Foreign Funds:** NGOs are prohibited from transferring received FCRA funds to any other individual or organization.
  - ***Implication:*** Indicates a lack of trust in intermediary NGOs and concerns about fund diversion.
- **Reduced Administrative Expense Cap:** The cap on administrative expenditure from foreign funds has been reduced from 50% to 20%
  - ***Implication:*** Limits operational flexibility, especially for smaller NGOs relying heavily on such funding.
- **Government Power to Freeze Accounts:** The amendment empowers the government to stop the utilization of foreign funds by placing an NGO's account under "summary inquiry."
  - ***Implication:*** Grants discretionary authority, potentially affecting the autonomy of NGOs during investigations.
- **Mandatory Identification of Office Bearers:** Office bearers of NGOs must provide Aadhaar details (or passport for foreigners).
  - ***Implication:*** Creates a centralized database for tracking individuals associated with foreign-funded NGOs, enhancing surveillance and accountability.

DEPENDENCE ON DONOR AGENCIES FOR DEVELOPMENT PROCESS (UPSC 2022)

In recent years, donor agencies have played an increasing role in financing development projects in India. While their support brings valuable resources and expertise, it also raises concerns about reducing community ownership and participation in the development process.

Arguments Against Donor Dependence

- **Reduced Ownership:** Communities may feel projects are imposed, not self-driven (e.g., Narmada Dam protests).
- **Top-down Approach:** Donors may prioritize global agendas over local needs (e.g., World Bank's ICDS support didn't suit local conditions).
- **Bureaucratic Hurdles:** Donor rules can delay work and complicate local efforts (e.g., MNREGA reporting issues due to donor involvement).
- **Questionable Accountability:** Projects led by external agencies may bypass national systems, reducing accountability to local populations and elected governments.

Arguments Supporting Donor Involvement

- **Capacity Building:** Donors offer training and tools (e.g., UNDP helped communities manage water better).
- **Inclusive Strategies:** Some donors involve locals in project design and monitoring (e.g., ADB's Urban Climate Fund in cities).
- **Using Local Knowledge:** Effective partnerships built on community experience (e.g., Sweden's support to SEWA enhanced women's livelihoods.
- **Promotion of Global Standards:** Aid often brings with it standards for transparency, gender equality, and environmental safeguard.

PRESSURE GROUP

Pressure groups are individuals voluntarily organising to advocate for and safeguard their shared interests. Their objective is to influence public opinion and government policies in favour of their members by applying external pressure. These groups employ legal and legitimate methods, including lobbying, correspondence, petitioning, public debates, and discussions with legislators, to impact government policy-making and implementation.

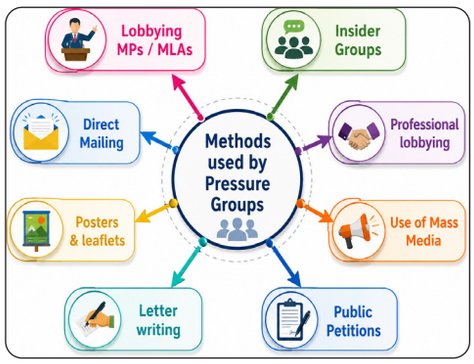


Fig. 2.5: Methods used by Pressure Groups

Types of Pressure Group

Type	Description	Examples
Institutional Interest Groups	Formal groups within government machinery that express interests through constitutional and official channels.	IAS Association, Armed Forces (OROP demand), Parliamentary Standing Committees
Associational Interest Groups	Organized groups formed to promote specific interests like business, labour, or students.	FICCI, AITUC, NSUI
Anomic Interest Groups	Spontaneous groups that emerge during crises and express demands through protests, riots, or demonstrations.	Anti-CAA protests (2019–20), Farmers' protest (2020–21), Delhi riots (2020)
Non-Associational Interest Groups	Informal groups based on caste, ethnicity, region, or community with loose organization.	Jat & Patidar agitations, Lingayat movement, Gorkhaland movement

Why informal groups are becoming powerful? **(UPSC 2017)**

- **Social media reach**: Easy to spread messages and gather support.
- **Media coverage**: Gains public attention and pressures leaders.
- **Quick action**: More flexible and faster in reacting to events.

Eg., **India Against Corruption (2011)** – led by Anna Hazare, led to Jan Lokpal Bill debates and AAP's formation.

Role of Pressure Groups in Public Policy Making (UPSC 2021, 2017)

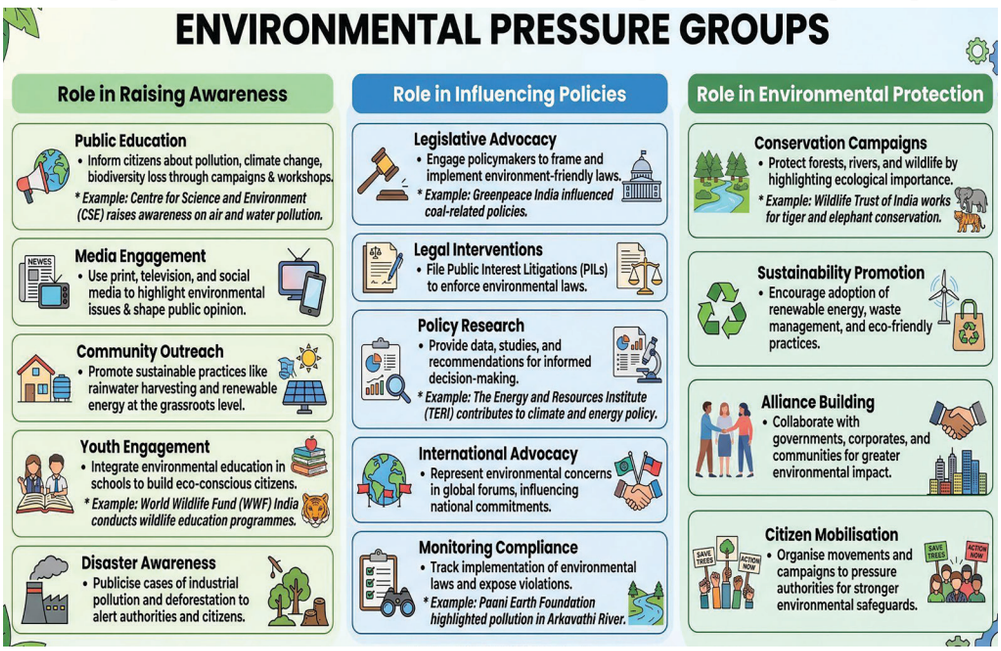
- **Advocacy for Public Demands:** Pressure groups effectively articulate the demands and needs of their constituents, especially when these issues lack political significance. For instance, farmer unions like the Bharatiya Kisan Union and Punjab Kisan Union, during the 2024 farmers' protests, demanded a legal guarantee for MSP and pensions for farmers.
- **Advisory Function:** Governments often seek advice from pressure groups on significant policy matters of a commercial and economic nature. Acting as a two-way communication channel, groups like the Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT) and Resident Welfare Associations such as URJA (United Residents Joint Action) in 2024 advised government bodies on issues like pollution control measures and environmental policies.
- **Legislative Influence:** In the legislative process, pressure groups actively engage in lobbying with legislators to shape desired laws or amendments. Student organizations like the National Students' Union of India (NSUI), through protests and marches in 2024, influenced parliamentary debates around employment guarantees and reforms in education policies like the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.
- **Policy Evaluation:** Pressure groups critically evaluate laws, rules, decisions, and policies that directly or indirectly impact the interests they represent. The protests by farmer unions and farmer producer organisations against the three farm laws in 2021 resulted in the government repealing those laws.
- **Public Opinion Formation:** Pressure groups play a leading role in shaping public opinion by influencing the government through tools like op-eds, mass meetings, slogans, and protests. The United Residents Joint Action (URJA) used public petitions, media campaigns, and direct appeals to the Prime Minister's Office in December 2024 to rally public support for stricter pollution control measures in Delhi-NCR.

How Business Associations/Farmers' Organisations Influence Policies (UPSC 2021, 2019)

- **Lobbying**: Groups like CII and FICCI lobby for business-friendly laws and tax reforms.
- **Expert Advice:** NASSCOM gives technical input on IT and digital policies.
- **Research:** ASSOCHAM funds studies to support policy changes.
- **Public Campaigns:** Run awareness drives, e.g., FICCI promoting "Make in India."
- **Protests:** Rallies, sit-ins, hunger strikes (e.g., 2020–21 farm law protests).
- **Electoral politics:** Support or field candidates in elections.
- **Policy advocacy:** Write reports, articles, and research to influence opinion.

Environmental Pressure Groups [UPSC 2025]

- Environmental pressure groups are non-state or civil society organisations that **mobilise public opinion, influence policy, and advocate sustainable development**.
- They act as watchdogs to ensure **environmental concerns are not ignored in development processes**.



Limitations of Pressure Group

- **Silencing Majority:** Powerful and articulate groups may dominate policy discourse, sidelining the silent majority. **Example:** Farm Laws repeal debate where vocal minority influence was highlighted (SC observation).
- **Internal Conflicts:** Power struggles and vested interests within groups may weaken their credibility and distort representation.

  Example: National Students' Union of India protests over alleged NEET-UG 2024 irregularities.
- **Protectionism:** Interest groups, especially trade unions, may resist reforms to protect narrow interests, affecting economic progress.

  Example: Withdrawal of Broadcast Bill (2024) after opposition from content creators and civil groups.
- **Foreign Influence:** External funding or influence may compromise national interests and policy autonomy.

  Example: Concerns raised by lawyers (2024) about foreign-influenced groups pressuring judiciary.

Way Forward for Strengthening Role of Pressure Groups in India

- **Legal Recognition and Regulation** - Pressure groups in India currently lack formal legal status, which affects their accountability and effectiveness. A framework should be developed to formally recognize and regulate these groups, similar to how lobbying is regulated in the **US and UK**, ensuring transparency in their operations.
- **Code of Conduct and Transparency** - Pressure groups should follow a code of conduct and be required to disclose their sources of funding and lobbying activities. For instance, corporate lobbying in sectors like telecom and pharmaceuticals often influences policy behind the scenes — transparency can improve public trust.
- **Institutional Space in Policy-Making** - Pressure groups should be given a formal consultative role in parliamentary committees and policy forums. For example, farmers' associations could have a say during the formulation of agricultural policies or MSP-related decisions.
- **Use of Digital Platforms for Engagement** - Governments can use digital platforms to collect feedback from interest groups and civil society organizations. The MyGov platform is a step in this direction, but broader usage and integration with ministries is needed.

SELF-HELP GROUPS (SHG)

As per the National Rural Livelihoods Mission, a Self-Help Group is a group of people who pool their savings into a common fund, meet regularly, and use the fund for mutual benefit, fostering financial inclusion and collective action

Origin of SHGS in India

- Self Help Groups (SHGs) originated in India as a **grassroots approach to addressing poverty and empowering marginalized communities, particularly women**.
- The concept gained momentum in the **1980s** with the establishment of the **National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD),** which later launched the SHG-Bank Linkage Programme (SHG-BLP) in 1992.
- Organizations like **MYRADA (Mysore Resettlement and Development Agency)** and **Pradan (Professional Assistance for Development Action)** played a significant role in popularizing the SHG model, recognizing the potential of collective action and self-help.
  - As per **NABARD's 2023 Status Report**, over **12 million SHGs** are now part of the progr am, covering **over 130 million households**. (*NABARD SHG-BLP Report 2023)*
- **Government Recognition (1990s–Present):** The government boosted the SHG movement through schemes like Swarn Jayanti Gram Swarozgar Yojana (**SGSY)** and **DAY-NRLM**, expanding their reach and impact.
  - **Mission for Financial Inclusion:** Ensures financial services reach rural poor through SHGs.

Knowledge Nuggets

Lakhpati Didi Initiative

- It was launched by the Government of India, this initiative aims to empower SHG women to earn a sustainable income of ₹1 lakh annually (₹10,000/month).
  - As of August 2024, over **1 crore women** have become Lakhpati Didis, with a target of reaching **3 crore**. It ensures convergence of government schemes, financial access, and market linkages for diversified livelihoods.

Namo Drone Didi

- The **Namo Drone Didi** scheme, announced in the Union Budget 2024–25, empowers women-led SHGs by integrating drones in agriculture, with ₹1,261 crore allocated for 15,000 SHGs by 2025. It is a collaborative effort across several government departments.
  - Haryana is training 5,000 women from 500 SHGs, and IIT Mandi and IIT Guwahati have set up drone pilot training centers to support this initiative.

Role of SHGs in Developmental Activities (UPSC 2017, 2015, 2020)

- **Financial inclusion:** SHGs offer easy access to credit and savings for the rural poor, especially women. For instance, under the *DAY–NRLM*, over 10 crore women have been mobilized into SHGs.
- **Women's empowerment:** SHG participation boosts confidence and decision-making among women.
  - The *Lakhpati Didi* initiative aims to empower 2 crore rural women to earn ₹1 lakh annually.
  - SHGs like SEWA in Gujarat have shown how women become more active in their homes and communities.
- **Livelihood generation:** SHGs support skill training and promote micro-enterprises. For example, many SHGs under *DAY-NRLM* have started agri-businesses and handicrafts.
- **Social cohesion:** SHGs build unity and local leadership, encouraging collective problem-solving. During COVID-19, SHGs stitched masks and ran community kitchens across states like Odisha and Bihar.
- **Rural Development**: SHGs help reduce rural poverty by supporting small businesses, improving money management skills, and including more people in economic activities.
- **Poverty Reduction:** SHGs help lift families out of poverty. **Eg.,** Bihar's JEEViKA improved lives of 6 lakh households.
- **Asset Creation and Income Security:** SHGs help members save money and access small loans. This enables them to buy things like cows, poultry, or farming tools.
- **Skill Development:** SHGs give training in money management, record-keeping, and decision-making. **Eg., NRLM** trains SHG women to run small businesses well.

Measures Taken by Government of India to Promote SHGs (UPSC 2017)

- The government launched the SHG–Bank Linkage Programme to provide microfinance through banks.
  - Microfinancing helps women SHGs start small businesses like farming, tailoring, or shops, leading to better income and financial independence. Programs such as **Tamil Nadu's *Mahalir Thittam*** also train women in health and nutrition, helping them make better choices for their families.
  - With improved income, women invest more in their children's education and healthcare. Microfinancing of women SHGs is a strong solution to **tackle poverty, malnutrition,** and gender inequality.

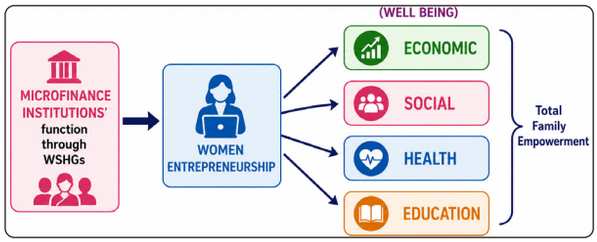


Fig. 2.6: Women Empowerment through SHGs

  - Self-Help Group (SHG) Bank Linkage Programme (SBLP)started in 1992 by NABARD, connects women's SHGs with banks to provide loans and savings services.
- NABARD supports SHGs with training, capacity building, and skill development.It also implements the Women SHG Scheme in backward and LWE-affected districts. A ₹500 crore Women SHGs Development Fund has also been created and is managed by NABARD.
- Rashtriya Mahila Kosh offers loans to agencies that further lend to SHGs.

Challenges of SHGs

- **Poor Infrastructure**: The majority of these SHGs are in rural and remote areas with no road or rail access. Electricity continues to be an issue. Eg: In **Bihar and Uttar Pradesh**, the lack of connectivity has hindered SHGs' ability to expand and reach markets efficiently..
- **Lack of training and capacity building:** The majority of SHGs operate on their own, with no assistance from the government in terms of professional development or capacity building. Eg: The **National Rural Livelihoods Mission (NRLM)** has attempted to address this but implementation remains uneven, particularly in less-developed states.
- **Politicization:** In SHGs, political affiliation and intervention have become major issues.
- **No security:** The SHGs depend on the members' shared trust and confidence. Due to the informal nature of the groups, members' deposits are not insured, and there is no mechanism to protect them from financial risks.
- **Socio-cultural Hurdles**: SHGs in rural India face many socio-cultural barriers such as gender inequality, caste discrimination, illiteracy, and traditional beliefs that limit women's participation. In Uttar Pradesh, women initially faced resistance but broke barriers through awareness drives.
  - SHGs in Tamil Nadu have faced challenges due to caste discrimination
  - Illiteracy was a significant challenge for SHGs in Rajasthan.

Measures to Make SHGs Effective

- **State as Enabler:** Create a supportive ecosystem for SHGs.Eg: Grameen Bank model shows state-supported microfinance growth.

- **Regional Expansion:** Increase SHGs in credit-deficit regions (MP, Rajasthan, NE). Eg: Kenya's "chamas" improve rural women's access to credit and savings.
- **Infra & Monitoring:** Strengthen banking, IT, and create SHG monitoring cell. Eg: Society for Elimination of Rural Poverty uses ICT systems to track SHG performance and credit linkages.
- **Digital Tracking:** Use ICT for credit history, grading, and performance monitoring.
- **Urban Inclusion:** Expand SHGs to urban/peri-urban poor. Eg: Brazil's Bolsa Família model integrates SHGs for urban financial inclusion.

e-Shakti Project of NABARD

- eShakti, or SHG Digitisation, is a project of NABARD's Micro Credit and Innovations Department.
- The project aims at the digitization of all the Self-Help Group (SHG) accounts. This initiative seeks to bring SHG members under the umbrella of financial inclusion, enabling them to access a broader range of financial services. Additionally, it aims to enhance bankers' comfort in credit appraisal and linkage by ensuring proper digital documentation and record-keeping.

Successful Examples of Self-Help Groups (SHGs) in India

- **Kudumbashree (Kerala) -**One of the largest SHG networks in the world, focusing on poverty eradication and women empowerment through microfinance and livelihood activities.
- **Mahila Arthik Vikas Mahamandal (MAVIM) (Maharashtra) -** A state-run initiative that has formed over 65,000 SHGs, helping rural women access credit, training, and entrepreneurship opportunities.
- **SEWA Bank (Self-Employed Women's Association) (Gujarat) -** Started by self-employed women, SEWA runs successful SHGs that provide microloans, health insurance, and skill development, enhancing women's financial independence.
- **Dharmapuri SHGs (Tamil Nadu) -** SHGs in Dharmapuri district helped thousands of rural women move from subsistence farming to small businesses like dairy farming and garment-making.
- **Jeevika (Bihar Rural Livelihoods Promotion Society) -** Supported by the World Bank, Jeevika has organized millions of women into SHGs, improving access to health, education, and sustainable livelihoods in one of India's poorest states.

COOPERATIVES IN INDIA

As per International Cooperative Alliance, a cooperative is an autonomous association of persons united voluntarily to meet their common economic, social, and cultural needs and aspirations through a jointly owned and democratically controlled enterprise.

Historical Evolution of Cooperatives in India

The cooperative movement in India has its roots in agriculture and rural sectors, emerging as a solution to the persistent problems faced by farmers, such as indebtedness and limited access to credit.

- **Historical Background:** Toward the end of the nineteenth century, the problems of rural indebtedness and the resulting conditions of farmers provided an atmosphere for chit funds and cooperative societies.
  - Farmers considered cooperative movement as a tool for pooling their limited resources to solve common problems such as credit, input supplies, and agricultural product marketing.
- **Legislative Framework:** The **Cooperative Credit Societies Act of 1904 and 1912, the Constitutional Reforms in 1919** and the recommendations of various committees such as the **Royal Commission on Agriculture (1928),** and **Committee on Cooperative Planning (1945),** during the British regime contributed a lot in shaping the organizational structure of cooperatives in India.
- **National Policy on Co-operatives, 2002: The National Policy on Cooperatives, 2002** aims to promote voluntary, democratic, and professional cooperatives to strengthen rural development and empower weaker sections. Its aim include the following:
  - **Promotion of Cooperatives as People's Institutions**: It aims to promote autonomous and democratic cooperatives as people-based institutions that serve as instruments of economic and social development.
  - **Greater Autonomy and Reduced Government Control**: It emphasizes minimizing government interference in the functioning of cooperatives and strengthening their democratic management and professionalism.
  - **Inclusive Development**: It encourages cooperatives to focus on weaker sections of society, including women and marginalized groups, to ensure their participation and benefit from cooperative activities.

Cooperatives: Constitutional Provisions

- Article 19 states that the Right to form cooperative societies is a fundamental right.
- **The Constitution (97th Amendment) Act, 2011**
  - In Part III of the constitution, after the words "or unions" the words "Cooperative Societies" was added.

- In Part IVA, a new Article 43B was inserted, which says: "The state shall endeavor to promote voluntary formation, autonomous functioning, democratic control and professional management of the co-operative societies".
- Part IXA of the constitution, a Part IXB was inserted to accommodate state vs center roles.

Contribution of the Cooperatives Sector to India's Growth Story

- **Boost to the rural economy:** Cooperatives cover around 97% of Indian villages and around 19% of the agricultural credit is disbursed by the cooperatives.
- **Economies of scale:** The cooperative sector has been able to foster economies of scale. India's cooperative network, the largest in the world, represents nearly nearly 30 per cent of the 30 lakh cooperative societies globally. E.g., In the dairy sector, there are more than 45,000 cooperatives with nearly 60 lakh members.
- **Inclusive growth:** The cooperative sector has been instrumental in the prevention of economic power accumulation and provided for a wider dispersal of ownership of productive capital. E.g. India's cooperative sector has the potential to generate up to 5.5 crore direct jobs and 5.6 crore self-employment opportunities by 2030 (Primus Partner)
- **Fertilizer sector:** Indian Farmers Fertiliser Cooperative Ltd. is a cooperative of more than 40,000 cooperatives. With its vast network, it has been able to reach more than 5.5 crore farmers.
- **Promotion of Organic Farming: Sittilingi Organic Farmers Association** is a cooperative engaged in organic farming and promotion of Ragi, bajra etc. It has been improving the incomes of farmers engaged with payment of Rs. 2 to 3 per kg more than the market price for produce.

Challenges in the Cooperatives Sector

- **Regional imbalance:** The cooperative sector is more developed in the western and southern parts of the country as compared to eastern such as West Bengal, Odisha, Bihar and north-eastern areas. **Eg:** Gujarat's AMUL model contrasts starkly with the underdeveloped dairy cooperatives in Odisha and Bihar.
- **Absence of timely elections:** The cooperatives face the issue of lack of timely elections to the governing bodies and often these elections are affected by the money power of the candidates. Eg: In 2013, the **Supreme Court (Thalappalam Service Cooperative Bank Ltd. vs. State of Kerala)** emphasized the need for regular elections post-97th Constitutional Amendment.
- **Dual regulation of cooperative banks:** Cooperative banks are under dual regulation of RBI and the State government which reduces their accountability. E.g. The **PMC Bank crisis (2019)** exposed the flaws of dual regulation, where poor coordination between the **RBI and Maharashtra Registrar of Cooperative Societies** delayed action.
- **Defective management:** The cooperative credit system has been chastised because it is mostly controlled by landlords and large farmers. As a result, small and medium-sized farmers and marginalized sections do not receive their fair share. They are also denied help from cooperative societies.
- **Political interference:** According to sociologists like **Sujata Patel and Daniel Thorner**, political intervention is a formidable barrier to the growth of cooperative movements. In rural India, cooperative societies have become a hotbed of politics. Beneficiaries are often chosen based on political reasons.

Issues in Agricultural Cooperatives

- **Neglect of Demand Aspect:** Cooperatives prioritize supply of credit, overlooking real farmer demand.
- **Limited to credit:** Most Primary Agricultural Cooperative Societies offer only credit services, failing to become true multipurpose bodies.
- **Limited Market Access:** Many cooperatives face difficulties in accessing larger markets, often because of inadequate infrastructure, poor negotiation power, or limited marketing skills.
- **Free Rider Problem:** Some members may take advantage of the benefits without contributing adequately, which can strain the cooperative's resources and decision-making processes.

Do you know?

- India hosted the International Cooperative Alliance's Global Cooperative Conference for the first time in November 2024.
- During the conference, PM Modi launched the UN's International Year of Cooperatives 2025.

Success Stories of Cooperative Societies in India

Amul Dairy Cooperative Movement

- Amul began the dairy cooperative movement in India by the formation of an apex cooperative organisation Gujarat Co-operative Milk Marketing Federation Ltd. (GCMMF) which is jointly owned by some 2.2 million milk producers in Gujarat.
- Dr. Verghese Kurien, founder chairman of GCMMF is the man behind the success of AMUL. Amul has spurred the White Revolution of India, which has made India one of the largest milk producers in the world.

Shri Mahila Griha Udyog (Lijjat Papad)

- Shri Mahila Griha Udyog Lijjat Papad, founded in 1959 in Mumbai by seven women with an initial capital of just ₹80, stands as a remarkable example of women's empowerment through self-employment.
  - The cooperative has grown to include over 45,000 women members across India.
- Its key strategies include collective ownership, where every member is a co-owner; cost-plus pricing to ensure affordability for middle and lower-income groups.
  - Strict focus on quality control and transparency.
- The enterprise has also diversified its product line beyond papads to include khakhra, masala, and detergents. Over the decades, Lijjat has played a transformative role in promoting rural employment and empowering women by providing them with stable livelihoods and a sense of dignity.

Steps Taken by the Government

- **Draft National Cooperation Policy 2025 Introduced :**The Ministry of Cooperation formulated a draft of the National Cooperation Policy 2025, aiming to facilitate the systematic and holistic development of the cooperative sector. The policy focuses on accelerating rural economic development, with an emphasis on women and youth participation.
- **Ministry of cooperation:** The ministry was established in 2021 to realize the vision of '**Sahakar se Samriddhi**' (prosperity through cooperation).
- **Banking Regulation (Amendment) Act, 2020:** It gives RBI powers to supersede boards of the Cooperative banks and allows cooperative banks to raise money via public issue and private placement, of equity or preference shares.
- **NAFED:** The National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation has been established to assist the marketing cooperatives in the States to develop their marketing business and to help them render better services to their members.
- **NCDC:** The National Cooperative Development Cooperation has been set up to aid schemes of marketing, processing, storage and practicing in the share capital of cooperative sugar, cooperative spinning and weaving mills, in the form of loans and subsidies.
- **Computerisation of PACS:** The Cabinet had approved the Computerisation of 63,000 functional Primary Agriculture Credit Societies to bring transparency, and efficiency, improve trustworthiness and help PACS to become the nodal delivery service at the point at the Panchayat level.
- **Cooperative societies on the GeM Platform:** The cabinet has approved the registration of cooperative societies as 'Buyers' on Government e-Marketplace.
- **Multi-State Cooperative Societies (Amendment) Bill, 2022:** The Bill has been introduced in the Parliament to amend MSCS Act, 2002 with a view to strengthening governance, enhancing transparency, increasing accountability and reforming the electoral process, etc. in the Multi-State Cooperative Societies.
- **The Union Budget 2025–26 strengthens India's cooperative sector through key initiatives:**
  - **PM Dhan-Dhaanya Krishi Yojana** targets 100 low-yield districts to boost crop diversity, storage, credit, and irrigation, benefiting 1.7 crore farmers.
  - **Rural Prosperity Program** supports skilling, tech, and rural enterprises, focusing on women, youth, and small farmers.
  - **Pulses Mission** aims for self-sufficiency in Tur, Urad, Masoor via procurement by NAFED/NCCF.
  - **KCC Loan Limit** raised to ₹5 lakh.
  - **MSME Support** includes loans for 5 lakh SC/ST/women entrepreneurs.

Nandini Sahakar Yojana

- The **Nandini Sahakar Yojana** aims to support **women cooperatives** by providing financial assistance, project formulation, and capacity development under the **National Cooperative Development Corporation (NCDC)**.
- **Key Features:** The scheme offers financial assistance with 2% interest subsidy for new activities and 1% for all others, with eligibility for cooperatives operating for at least three months, including those with 50% women members.
- **Significance:** It aims to improve women's socio-economic status by enhancing entrepreneurial activities through women-led cooperatives, offering support for business plans, credit, subsidies, and capacity building.

Way Forward for Revitalizing Cooperatives

- **Enlarge credit portfolio:** To enroll the younger generation, cooperatives must provide financial services for the construction of houses and the purchase of consumer durables in the digital form.
- **Digitalisation:** Cooperatives need to adopt digital technologies and computerisation in a big way to attract youth as well as reach out to marginalized and needy people.

- **Improve Governance and professionalism:** Red-tapism, political interference, administrative bottlenecks etc. must be done away with. The officials should not succumb to local pressure, political or otherwise. Powerful village lobbies should not be allowed to interfere unnecessarily in the functioning of cooperative societies.
- **Visionary leadership:** Leaders such as Tribhuvandas Patel (Amul), Vithalrao Vikhe Patil and Thathya Sahib Kore had the ability to convert a crisis into an opportunity. The cooperative sector is again in need of such leadership.
- The **weak and inefficient cooperative societies should either be abolished or merged** with strong and efficient ones.
- **Institutional credit should be earmarked** not only for small farmers, tenants and sharecroppers but also for landless workers and artisans.

Knowledge Nuggets

Supreme Court on Cooperatives

- The Supreme Court struck down parts of the 97th Constitutional Amendment related to cooperative societies, stating it bypassed required ratification by states.
  - It ruled that cooperatives are a State Subject, and Part IXB applies only to Multi-State Cooperative Societies.
  - The verdict reaffirmed that state legislatures have exclusive power over cooperatives.

Multi-State Cooperative Societies (Amendment) Bill, 2022, Key Provisions

- **Election Authority**: An independent authority will be created to ensure free and fair elections in Multi-State Cooperative Societies (MSCSs).
- **Cooperative Ombudsman**: A redressal mechanism will be established to resolve complaints and disputes in assigned regions.
- **Revival Fund**: A special fund will support financially sick MSCSs, contributed by profit-making societies.
- **Board Inclusivity**: It will be mandatory to include at least one SC/ST member and two women in the Board of Directors of every MSCS.
- **Stricter Penalties**: Heavier fines (up to ₹1 lakh) will be imposed for failing to submit returns or comply with regulations.

Voluntary and Charitable Institutions in Development

1. Societies

- A society is **a group of seven or more people who have come together to promote literature, fine arts, science, and other things.**
- The **Societies Registration Act of 1860** governs their registration. It allows for the establishment of a Society for any literary, science, or charitable cause, as well as any other purpose specified in Section 20 of the Act.

2. Trust

- Trust is a unique type of organization that arises from a will. The creator of a will passes exclusive possession of a property to be used for a specific reason.
- The **Indian Trusts Act of 1882** was the initial legislation in India that primarily focused on regulating private trusts, which are established with the aim of assisting specific individuals. On the other hand, when the objective is to benefit the general public or society as a whole, it is known as a public trust.

Public Charitable Trusts: Role and Limitations [UPSC 2024]

Public charitable trusts operate under laws like the **Indian Trusts Act, 1882**, focusing on philanthropy in education, healthcare, and social justice.

Role in Inclusive Development

- **Educational Enhancement:** Trusts improve access and quality of education in underserved areas. *Eg:* Azim Premji Foundation supports universal elementary education alongside Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan.
- **Healthcare Access:** Trusts provide healthcare services to marginalized groups, supporting **Article 47 (public health)**. *Eg:* Tata Trusts supports cancer care hospitals and mobile medical units aligned with Ayushman Bharat.
- **Skill Development:** Trusts promote women empowerment through skills and microfinance, advancing equality under **Articles 14 and 15**. *Eg:* Self Employed Women's Association provides training and financial support to rural women.
- **Legal Assistance:** Trusts offer legal aid to protect fundamental rights of marginalized communities. *Eg:* Bachpan Bachao Andolan provides legal support to trafficked children.
- **Environmental Conservation:** Trusts work on biodiversity and sustainability, supporting India's commitments under global frameworks like the Paris Agreement.

Limitations of Public Charitable Trusts

- **Funding Constraints:** Dependence on donations, grants, and CSR funds leads to **financial instability**.
- **Regulatory Constraints:** Laws like FCRA 2010 restrict foreign funding and delay approvals, affecting operations.
- **Limited Scope:** Many trusts work in niche areas and face difficulty in expanding beyond their mandate.
- **Volunteer Dependence:** Heavy reliance on volunteers affects continuity when participation declines. *Eg:* Teach For India faces consistency issues due to high fellow turnover.
- **Scalability Issues:** Expansion requires significant funding and infrastructure, which many trusts lack.
- **Urban Bias:** Many trusts operate in urban areas, leaving rural regions underserved.

3. Religious Endowments

- Religious Endowments and Waqfs are **religious trusts established for religious purposes**, such as supporting Hindu and Muslim deities, charities, and religions.
  - Religious endowments are created when property is dedicated to religious purposes.
- Unlike Public Trusts, they are not required to be registered, and they do not place a strong emphasis on a triangular relationship between the donor, trustee, and beneficiary.
- **Waqfs** are formed as a result of the Muslim community's coordinated action.
  - Waqfs bind the land and give the usufruct to the people. The Religious Endowments Act of 1863 was essentially a private endowment law that put a property under the care of a Trustee/Trustees under a will for a group of predetermined beneficiaries.



- Waqf boards in India are the third-largest landowners, following the Armed Forces and Indian Railways.
- There are 8.72 lakh waqf properties, covering an area of more than 38 lakh acres.

WAQF (AMENDMENT) ACT, 2025 (UMEED ACT)

The SC passed an interim order staying select provisions of the Waqf (Amendment) Act 2025, while refusing to impose a blanket stay on the entire Waqf (Amendment) Act, 2025.

Key Provisions

- **Trust–Waqf Separation:** Trusts created by Muslims are excluded from Waqf if governed under other public charity laws, ensuring **clear legal distinction**.
- **Board Composition:** State Waqf Boards and Central Council must include **at least two non-Muslim members** and **two Muslim women members**, along with representation from **Shia, Sunni, Bohra, Aghakhani, and OBC Muslim communities**.
- **Eligibility for Dedication:** Only **practicing Muslims (minimum 5 years)** can dedicate property to Waqf.
- **Abolition of Waqf by User:** The provision allowing Waqf status based on long-term use is removed; however, **existing registered waqf-by-user properties remain valid**, except those under dispute.
- **Property Survey Mechanism:** Survey Commissioner is replaced by **District Collector (or higher authority)** for verification; if declared Waqf, **ownership may revert to the government after inquiry**.
- **Dispute Resolution Reform:** Tribunal composition changed to **judicial officer + government officer**; decisions are now **appealable in High Courts within 90 days**, removing finality.
- **Transparency Measures:** Mandatory **registration of Waqf properties within 6 months**; institutions earning above ₹1 lakh annually must undergo **state-appointed audits**.
- **Applicability of Limitation Act:** The earlier exemption is removed; Waqf claims against encroachment must now be made **within prescribed time limits**.

Issue	2025 Amendment (Challenged Provisions)	Supreme Court Interim Order (Sept 2025)
District Collector's Powers (Section 3C)	Empowered District Collectors to inquire into Waqf properties and declare them as government land. Waqf status ceased during inquiry, and officers could alter revenue and Waqf Board records.	Powers stayed as arbitrary and against separation of powers. Property will retain Waqf status during inquiry, and no dispossession or third-party rights allowed until Tribunal decision.
Non-Muslim Membership in Waqf Bodies	Allowed significant non-Muslim representation, raising concerns of non-Muslim majority in Waqf Boards and Central Council.	SC capped representation: maximum 4 non-Muslims in the Central Council (22 members) and 3 in State Boards (11 members), ensuring Muslim majority.

Five-Year Muslim Practice Rule	Restricted Waqf creation to individuals practising Islam for at least 5 years, potentially excluding converts and minority sects.	Rule stayed. Suspended until government frames clear rules and verification mechanism for religious practice.

Need for reforms in the Waqf Provisions

- **Irrevocability of Waqf Properties**: The principle "once a Waqf, always a Waqf" has led to complex ownership disputes, such as the **Bet Dwarka** islands, where courts struggle with ownership claims.
- **Lack of Judicial Oversight**: The Waqf Tribunal's decisions, under the 1995 Act, are not subject to appeal, limiting judicial review and transparency.
- **Misuse of Powers**: Section 40 of the Waqf Act has been misused to declare private properties as Waqf, causing legal disputes, such as the **Kerala case** where 600 Christian families contested their ancestral lands being claimed by the Waqf Board.

ROLE OF NON-STATE ACTORS IN INDIAN GOVERNANCE – A CRITICAL LOOK (UPSC 2016)

After independence, India's closed, state-controlled economy left little room for non-state actors, with governance dominated by bureaucracy and planning under the "License Raj." Post-1991 LPG reforms, their role expanded as the government began engaging NGOs, SHGs, and private players to enhance policy delivery and development.

Examples of Growing Role

- **Common Service Centres** deliver digital services in rural areas.
- **Private firms** manage key services like **Passport Seva Kendra (TCS)** and **GSTN network**.
- **PPP models** are used for infrastructure projects and airport management.
- **NGOs and civil society** act as watchdogs—e.g., **Greenpeace**, **Narmada Bachao Andolan**.
- **Policy Influence and Advocacy:** Non-state actors like NGOs and civil society organizations influence policymaking. *Example:* PRS Legislative Research aids MPs in informed lawmaking.
- **Service Delivery and Welfare:** They fill governance gaps in health, education, and disaster relief. *Example:* SEWA (Self-Employed Women's Association) empowers women through livelihood support.
- **Concerns of Accountability:** Some actors may lack transparency or push foreign agendas. *Example:* Crackdown on certain NGOs under FCRA for alleged misuse of foreign funds.

Still, India's governance is heavily state-controlled, with a strong bureaucratic system. While non-state actors now contribute more than before, their role remains somewhat limited and often faces regulatory and political challenges.

Key Words

People-Centered Development, Population Stagnation, Government as a Facilitator, Pillar of Development, Collaborative Economic Development, Sahakar-se-Samriddhi (Prosperity through Cooperation), From Opportunity to Future Assurance

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	Civil Society Organizations are often perceived as being anti-State actors than non-State actors. Do you agree? Justify.	2025
2.	What are environmental pressure groups? Discuss their role in raising awareness, influencing policies and advocating for environmental protection in India.	2025
3.	Public charitable trusts have the potential to make India's development more inclusive as they relate to certain vital public issues. Comment.	2024
4.	Skill development programmes have succeeded in increasing human resources supply to various sectors. In the context of the statement analyse the linkages between education, skill and employment.	2023
5.	Discuss the contribution of civil society groups for women's effective and meaningful participation and representation in state legislatures in India.	2023
6.	The crucial aspect of the development process has been the inadequate attention paid to Human Resource Development in India. Suggest measures that can address this inadequacy.	2023
7.	Do you agree with the view that increasing dependence on donor agencies for development reduces the importance of community participation in the development process?	2022
8.	Can Civil Society and NGOs present an alternative model of public service delivery? Discuss the challenges of this model.	2021
9.	Pressure groups influence policymaking. Explain how business associations contribute to policy.	2021

10.	Can the vicious cycle of gender inequality, poverty and malnutrition be broken through microfinancing of women SHGs? Explain with examples.	2021
11.	Micro-Finance as an anti-poverty vaccine, is aimed at asset creation and income security of the rural poor in India". Evaluate the role of the Self Help Groups in achieving the twin objectives along with empowering women in rural India.	2020
12.	What are the methods used by the farmers' organisation to influence the policy-makers in India and how effective are these methods?	2019
13.	The need for cooperation among various services sectors has been an inherent component of development discourse. Partnership bridges the gap among the sectors. It also sets in motion a culture of 'collaboration' and 'team spirit'. In the light of statements above examine India's development process.	2019
14.	How do pressure groups influence the Indian political process? Do you agree with this view that informal pressure groups have emerged as powerful as formal pressure groups in recent years?	2017
15.	The emergence of Self Help Groups (SHGs) in contemporary times points to the slow but steady withdrawal of the state from developmental activities. Examine the role of SHGs and measures taken by the Government of India to promote them.	2017
16.	In the Indian governance system, the role of non-state actors has been only marginal. Critically Examine.	2016
17.	Effectiveness of the government system at various levels and people's participation in the governance system are inter-dependent" Discuss their relationship in the context of India.	2016
18.	Discuss the inter-dependent relationship between the effectiveness of the government system and people's participation in the governance system in India.	2016
19.	How can the role of NGOs be strengthened in India for development works relating to protection of the environment? Discuss throwing light on the major constraints.	2015
20.	Examine critically the recent changes in the rule governing foreign funding of NGOs under the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), 1976.	2015
21.	The Self-Help Group (SHG) Bank Linkage Programme (SBLP), which is India's own innovation, has proved to be one of the most effective poverty alleviation and women empowerment programmes. Elucidate.	2015
22.	The penetration of Self Help Groups (SHGs) in rural areas in promoting participation in development programmes is facing socio-cultural hurdles. Examine.	2014

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3 Governance to Good Governance

The United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), 1997, defined governance as "the exercise of economic, political and administrative authority to manage a country's affairs at all levels. It comprises the mechanisms, processes and institutions, through which citizens and groups articulate their interests, exercise their legal rights, meet their obligations and mediate their differences."

RELATION BETWEEN GOVERNMENT AND GOVERNANCE

- Government refers to the formal institutions like the legislature, executive, and judiciary that create and enforce laws—for example, when the **Indian Parliament** enacts the National Food Security Act to ensure access to subsidized food.
- In contrast, governance is the broader process through which decisions are made and implemented with accountability, transparency, and public participation—for instance, when citizens use the RTI Act to check irregularities in ration distribution, ensuring effective implementation of the law or local communities help monitor service delivery under social audit mechanisms.

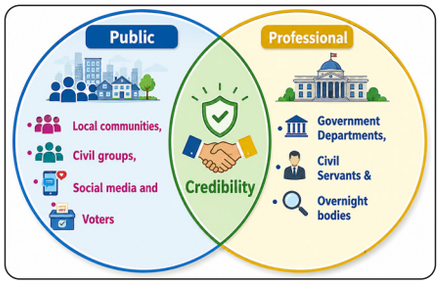


Fig. 3.1: Sources of Credibility in Governance

DIMENSIONS OF GOVERNANCE IN INDIA

The **Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG)** has developed a framework for assessing governance in India. This framework categorizes governance into **five** key dimensions, providing a comprehensive view of the country's governing system.

Dimension	Description	Focus	Example
Political	Assesses the quality of political participation, conduct of political actors, and citizen trust.	The role of the state alongside civil society in the governance process.	Decentralization of power to local bodies.
Legal & Judicial	Evaluates adherence to the rule of law, law and order, human rights protection, and access to justice.	Upholding the rule of law and ensuring justice for all.	Initiatives to improve police accountability and fast-track court cases.
Administrative	Measures efficiency in service delivery, resource management, and transparency.	Efficient and transparent delivery of government services.	E-governance initiatives and Right to Information Act (RTI).
Economic	Ensures macro-economic stability, fosters economic activity, and supports primary sectors.	Creating a stable and enabling environment for economic growth.	Initiatives like the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code for ease of doing business.
Social & Environmental	Focuses on welfare of vulnerable sections, role of civil society, and environmental management.	Promoting social equity and environmental sustainability.	Schemes like Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (education) and Mid-Day Meal scheme, declaration of Ecologically Sensitive Zones (ESZs).

GOOD GOVERNANCE

The World Bank described good governance in its study "Governance and Development" published in 1992 as **"the way power is exercised in the development management of a country's economic and social resources."**

Alternatively, **Mahatma Gandhi** advocated the concept **'Ram Rajya'** for India based upon the principles of good governance which necessarily meant dreaming of India as a welfare state where the necessities of the down-trodden, the welfare of the commoner and their progress through indigenous industries would become the hallmark.

Quote for UPSC

"We cannot be mere consumers of good governance; we must be participants; we must be co-creators." —**Rohini Nilekani**

Historical Perspective on Good Governance

- **Kautilya** (Arthashastra): Advocated a strong ruler focused on public welfare, efficient taxation, intelligence-based security, and transparency to curb corruption.
- **Plato**: Proposed rule by philosopher-kings guided by wisdom and justice, ensuring governance for the common good.
- **Aristotle**: Favoured a *polity*—a balanced mix of democracy and oligarchy—led by the middle class, governed by law and aimed at collective welfare.

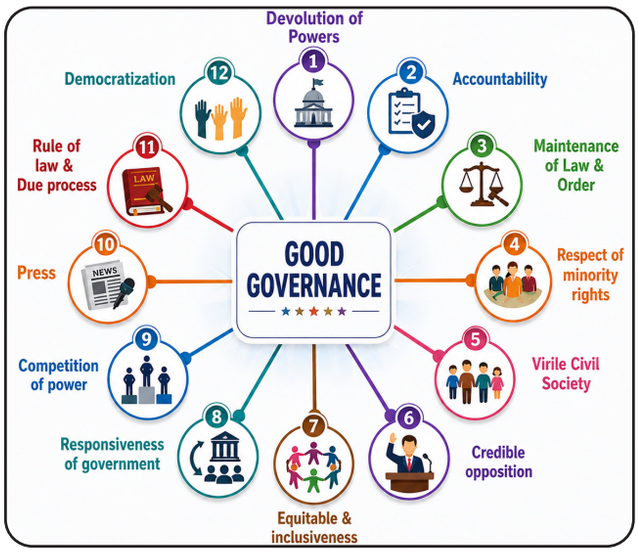


Fig. 3.2: Good Governance

Indic Idea of Good Governance – Key Teachings

- **Brihadaranyaka Upanishad** emphasizes the ruler's duty to uphold Dharma and ensure equal opportunities and protection for all, especially the weak.
- **Mundaka Upanishad** highlights Satyamev Jayate (Truth alone triumphs), a core principle of ethical governance.
- **Ramayana** advocates Ram Rajya — an ideal state with no hunger, discrimination, or injustice, where the king serves the people selflessly.
- **Bhagavad Gita** speaks of Adhishthan (foundation of action), promoting responsibility, accountability, and wise leadership.
- **Atharvaveda** through Bhumi Suktam teaches respect for nature and sustainable living as part of good governance.
- **Thirukkural** emphasizes environmental protection, equitable resource use, and orderly social development.
- **Arthashastra by Kautilya** focuses on Yogakshema (welfare of citizens) and defines a ruler as a public servant ensuring care for the vulnerable.
- **Antyodaya**, inspired by Mahatma Gandhi, promotes the upliftment of the poorest as the pathway to Sarvodaya (welfare of all).

Good Governance in India

- **Ninth Five Year Plan (1997-2002)**: Addressed governance weaknesses in plan programs.
- **Tenth Five Year Plan (2002-2007)**: Defined governance as enabling **capabilities** for **human development**.

Good Governance in Indian Constitution

While the Indian Constitution does not explicitly use the term "good governance," it incorporates several provisions that uphold its core principles:

- **Preamble**: Establishes the ideals of justice, liberty, equality, and fraternity, which form the ethical foundation of good governance.
- **Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP)**: Articles 38 to 40 direct the state to ensure social welfare, equitable resource distribution, and democratic governance at the grassroots through village Panchayats.
- **Fundamental Rights**: Articles 14, 15, and 21 guarantee equality before the law, prohibit discrimination, and ensure the right to life and personal liberty — which have been interpreted to include rights to livelihood, education, and a clean environment.

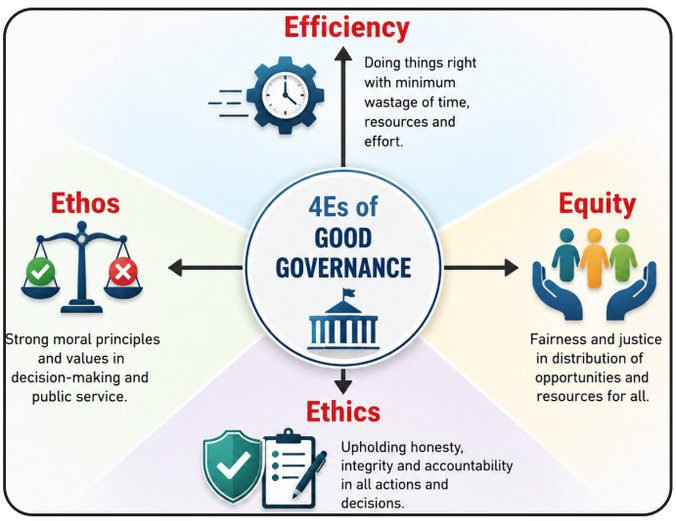


Fig. 3.3: 4E's of Good Governance

- **Separation of Powers**: Article 50 of the Indian Constitution directs the State to separate the judiciary from the executive in public services. This ensures independence of the judiciary, upholds the rule of law, and strengthens institutional accountability — all of which are essential components of good governance.
- **Local Self-Government**: Article 243 and subsequent provisions give constitutional status to Panchayats and Municipalities, promoting decentralization and people-centric governance.

Characteristics of Good Governance

United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) recognizes **eight core** characteristics of good governance:

Characteristic	Explanation	Example
Participation	Citizens participate in decision-making, implementation, and monitoring of governance.	MyGov platform for citizen engagement
Consensus-Oriented	Governance mediates diverse interests to achieve broad consensus for collective welfare.	Gram Sabha and social audits in decentralised governance
Rule of Law	Legal frameworks are fair, impartial, and uniformly enforced.	Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, Fugitive Offenders Act
Transparency	Decisions and processes are open, and information is easily accessible.	RTI Act, Section 4(1)(b) – proactive disclosure
Accountability	Institutions and individuals are answerable for their actions and decisions.	Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023
Responsiveness	Institutions respond to stakeholder needs within a reasonable timeframe.	PRAGATI portal, Ease of Doing Business reforms
Effectiveness & Efficiency	Optimal use of resources ensures timely and impactful outcomes.	ONDC initiative for digital commerce integration
Equity & Inclusiveness	Ensures participation and benefits for all sections, especially marginalized groups.	Women's Reservation Act (one-third seats for women)

The Need for Good Governance

- **Social and Economic Development : The World Bank** has highlighted the direct link between governance improvements and **GDP per capita growth**. Initiatives like the **GST** and **PMJDY** demonstrate how **good governance** drives **economic development**.
- **Poverty Reduction and Equality:** Inclusive development programs, and targeted interventions help uplift marginalized populations and reduce disparities. **E.g, PM Vishwakarma Yojana** supported traditional artisans with training and credit, promoting livelihood and reducing economic inequality among marginal groups.
- **Security and Stability:** The **World Justice Project's Rule of Law Index** emphasizes how the **rule of law** contributes to lower **crime rates**. Investments in **police modernization** and initiatives like the **Smart Policing Project** in Rajasthan illustrate how **good governance** enhances **security**.

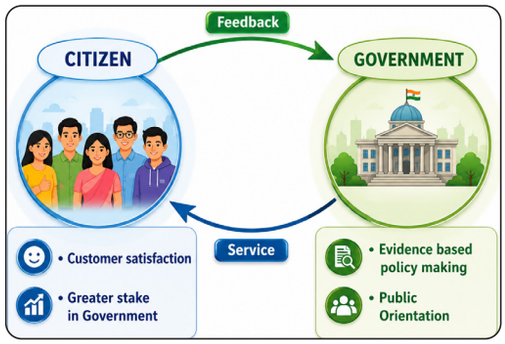


Fig. 3.4: Responsive Governance Cycle

- **Efficient Service Delivery**: The **COVID-19 pandemic** accelerated the adoption of digital governance solutions. Platforms like **Aarogya Setu** and **Co-WIN** showcase the potential of **technology** in improving **service delivery**, while **Aadhaar integration** enhances targeting in welfare programs.
- **Combating Corruption** The **Central Vigilance Commission's** proactive measures have led to a significant increase in inquiries into **corruption cases**. E-procurement platforms and **integrity pacts** in government contracts enhance **transparency** and reduce **corruption** opportunities.

Challenges to Good Governance

Barrier	Description	Recent Example
Lack of Accountability	Officials often act with authority but without being held responsible for poor service or corruption.	India's score on the Corruption Perceptions Index 2024 dropped to 38, ranking 96th out of 180 countries, indicating ongoing issues in public accountability.

Delayed Transparency Mechanisms	Mechanisms like RTI suffer from backlogs, limiting citizens' timely access to information.	As of June 30, 2024, over 4.05 lakh RTI appeals and complaints were pending; 7 Information Commissions were non-functional due to lack of appointments.
Ineffective Law Implementation	Even well-drafted laws are not impactful unless followed up by proper rules and enforcement mechanisms.	As per PRS Legislative Research, only 37% of laws enacted between 2014-2019 had the required rules framed for their implementation.
Digital Divide in Governance	Gaps in digitization and poor IT infrastructure delay service delivery and weaken transparency.	A 2023 National Institute for Smart GovernanceReport highlighted the need to bridge digital gaps within government offices to improve e-governance and citizen interaction.
Weak Local Governance (PRIs)	Panchayati Raj bodies lack sufficient funds, staff, and autonomy to deliver effectively.	The Centre for Policy Research's 2024 Report stressed that better financial devolution is essential to strengthen local governance and support rural development.
Judicial Delays	Slow court processes and case backlogs reduce public trust in justice and governance.	The Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy's 2024 report called for reforms like fast-tracking pending cases and improving use of technology to enhance court efficiency.
Low Public Awareness	Lack of awareness about rights and grievance mechanisms weakens citizen participation.	Though events like the CVC's Vigilance Awareness Week 2024 aim to raise awareness, broader citizenship education programs are needed for wider impact.

Major Initiatives to Promote Good Governance

- **Decentralization of Power** - Through the **73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments**, elected **Panchayats and Municipalities** were set up to empower local self-governments.
- **Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005** - Gave citizens the right to ask for information from government offices—helping ensure transparency and check misuse of power.
- **National Centre for Good Governance (NCGG)** - Set up in **2014** to train civil servants and work on public policy, administrative reforms, and governance improvement.
- **E-Governance** - Use of technology (like online portals and apps) to make government services faster, more transparent, and citizen-friendly. *(e.g. Digital India, e-Bhoomi, e-Choupal, e-Procurement, MCA21)*
- **Transparency and Accountability Tools were introduced:**
  - **Citizen Charters**: Official documents that outline the services provided by government departments, their standards, and expected timelines for delivery.
  - **Centralized Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System:** An online platform where citizens can register and track the status of their complaints to government departments.
- **DBT (Direct Benefit Transfer)**: A system where government benefits are directly transferred to the bank accounts of citizens, minimizing corruption and leakage.
- **Good Governance Index (GGI):** Ranks all Indian states and UTs based on their performance in governance and service delivery.
- **Criminal Justice Reform:** Introduction of **e-FIR**, faster trials, and simplified procedures to make justice more accessible.
- **Mission Karmayogi:** Aims to improve skills and ethics of government officers through modern training and performance-based learning.
- **Ease of Doing Business Reforms:** Steps taken to make starting and running a business in India easier, faster, and less bureaucratic.
- **Other Key Initiatives**
  - **PRAGATI**: PM-led platform to track development projects and resolve bottlenecks.
  - **Online Income Tax Filing**: Easy and transparent tax process.
  - **Digital India**: Overall digital infrastructure to connect governance with technology.

India Proposes New International Governance Index

- India, as President of the International Institute of Administrative Sciences, has proposed a new International Governance Index, announced during the 100th day of its presidency.
- **Key Features:** The index will be developed with support from World Bank, OECD, and UN DESA, and will use a methodology combining quantitative data with qualitative insights for balanced regional representation, with further discussions planned at the IIAS Annual Conference 2026.

Global Indices for Reforms and Growth (GIRG) Initiative

- India is intensifying efforts under the GIRG initiative to improve rankings across 26 international indices.
- GIRG is a government-led initiative aimed at improving India's **global standing across key international indices**.
- It focuses on identifying performance gaps, aligning national data with global methodologies and implementing targeted reforms to support **economic, governance, developmental, and industrial growth.**

Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2025

Introduction: Union Commerce and Industry Minister introduced the Bill to further **decriminalise minor offences**.

Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2023

- **First Consolidated Reform:** Decriminalised **183 provisions across 42 Central Acts**.
- **Administrative Coverage:** Covered laws administered by **19 Ministries/Departments**.
- **Shift in Penalty Structure:** Replaced imprisonment and criminal fines for minor offences with **monetary penalties, warnings, and administrative actions**.

Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2025

- **Objective:** Enhance **Ease of Doing Business and Ease of Living** by removing criminal liability for **minor, technical, and procedural offences**.
- **Scope of Amendments:** Proposes changes in **355 provisions across 16 Central Acts**.
- **Decriminalisation Extent:** Around **288 provisions decriminalised**, mainly to promote business efficiency.

Significance

- **Regulatory Simplification:** Reduces compliance burden on businesses.
- **Trust-Based Governance:** Moves from punitive to facilitative approach.
- **Economic Efficiency: Encourages investment and entrepreneurship.**

ROLE OF STATE, MARKET, AND CIVIL SOCIETY IN GOVERNANCE

- **The State:**
  - **Policy Formulation and Implementation:** Enacts laws, regulations, and policies (e.g., **National Rural Employment Guarantee Act - NREGA**), implements them through administrative machinery.
  - **Regulation and Oversight:** Regulates markets, industries (e.g., **Securities and Exchange Board of India - SEBI**), ensures fair competition, and environmental sustainability.
  - **Public Goods Provision:** Invests in infrastructure, national defense, law enforcement (e.g., **Vande Bharat Trains**).
  - **Social Justice and Equity:** Promotes inclusivity, human rights, and empowers marginalized communities (e.g., reservation quotas).
- **The Market:**
  - **Economic Growth:** Drives growth, innovation, and productivity, creates jobs, and generates wealth (e.g., **Information Technology sector - IT**).
  - **Resource Allocation:** Efficiently allocates resources, fosters entrepreneurship and investment (e.g., commodity markets determining agricultural produce prices).
  - **Innovation and Entrepreneurship:** Encourages creativity, efficiency, and technological advancements (e.g., **Reliance Industries** investing in research and development).
  - **Promoting Competition:** Enhances sectors like telecommunications, aviation, and retail (e.g., private telecom operators lowering tariffs).
- **Civil Society:**
  - **Advocacy and Activism:** Advocates for citizens' rights, promotes social justice, holds governments and businesses accountable (e.g., **Greenpeace** raising awareness about environmental issues).

- **Service Delivery:** Provides social services, humanitarian aid, and development assistance (e.g., **Akshaya Patra** providing mid-day meals to schoolchildren).
- **Community Engagement:** Fosters civic engagement, grassroots mobilization, and social cohesion (e.g., **Self-Employed Women's Association - SEWA** empowering women).
- **Monitoring and Oversight:** Monitors policies, conducts research, enhances transparency, and accountability (e.g., **Transparency International India** combatting corruption).

Aadhaar vs NPR: Balancing Identity Schemes for Inclusive and Accountable Governance **(UPSC 2014)**

Aadhaar and NPR are two identity-based schemes by the Government of India. Aadhaar focuses on service delivery, while NPR is part of a demographic database under the Citizenship Act, 1955. Their simultaneous implementation has sparked legal and ethical debates.

Debates and Litigations Around Aadhaar and NPR

- **Privacy and Data Security:** The Supreme Court's K.S. Puttaswamy (2017) verdict upheld the right to privacy, highlighting risks of data misuse. **Eg:** Aadhaar leaks exposed data of 81.5 crore Indians on the dark web.
- **Link to Citizenship Issues:** NPR's connection with the **National Register of Citizens (NRC)** has triggered concerns over potential exclusion. **Eg:** The **Assam NRC exercise** led to thousands being left out due to document gaps.
- **Administrative Redundancy:** Maintaining **two identity databases** increases duplication and operational costs.

Arguments for Running Both Aadhaar and NPR Concurrently

- **Welfare Targeting:** Aadhaar enables **direct benefit transfers (DBT)**, while NPR aids demographic planning. **Eg: PM-KISAN and Ujjwala Yojana** rely on Aadhaar for fund transfers.
- **National Security:** NPR helps track **population movements**, aiding borders and policy planning. **For instance:** NPR assists in **identifying illegal immigration trends**.
- **Smart Governance Integration:** Both link to **Digital India, ONORC (One nation One ration card), and smart city projects**. **For instance: ONORC** Plan allows migrant workers to access ration across India.

Arguments Against Concurrent Operation

- **Redundancy and Resource Wastage:** Both collect similar biometric and demographic data—leading to **duplication of effort and cost**.
- **Privacy and Surveillance Concerns:** Mandatory nature of NPR, especially with proposed new fields (like parent's birthplace), raises **fears of misuse**, particularly among minorities and migrants. Aadhaar itself has seen **legal scrutiny** on privacy; running NPR alongside may intensify constitutional and legal challenges.
- **Public Distrust and Litigation:** The linkage between NPR and NRC has **triggered national protests**, especially during the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) debate. Simultaneous execution could erode **public confidence in governance** and lead to further litigations.
- **Operational Confusion:** Citizens may be unclear on the purpose, necessity, and requirements of maintaining two parallel ID systems, complicating compliance.

DECENTRALISATION AND CONTEMPORARY DEVELOPMENT MODELS

Contemporary development models rely on centralised decision-making and technocratic systems.

- **Core Requirement:** Effective development requires decision-making close to the **source of information and execution**.
- **Key Issue:** Weak linkage leads to **inefficiency, exclusion, and disconnect from ground realities**.

Nature of Contemporary Development Models

- **Centralised Planning:** Policies are formulated at higher administrative levels.
- **Technocratic Approach:** Governance is driven by data, algorithms, and digital systems.
- **Standardisation:** Uniform policies are applied across diverse regions.
- **Resulting Gap:** Creates a disconnect between **policy design and local realities**.

Challenges Due to Distance between Decision and Execution

- **Ground Reality Disconnect:** Centralised systems lack local context, leading to generic policies.
  - **Example:** Aadhaar-related exclusion due to biometric and connectivity issues.

- **Implementation Gap:** Separation of policy design and execution causes coordination failures and delays.
  - **Example:** MGNREGA planning lacks local responsiveness.
- **Weak Local Governance:** Limited devolution under 73rd and 74th Amendments reduces the role of Panchayats and ULBs, weakening local ownership.
- **Exclusion of Vulnerable Groups:** Digital dependence excludes those lacking access and literacy.
  - **Example:** DBT errors leading to exclusion of beneficiaries.
- **Reduced Accountability:** Centralisation weakens local accountability and reduces citizen participation.

Rationale for Centralisation

- **Uniformity:** Ensures equal standards in sectors like health and education.
- **Efficiency through Technology:** Digital systems improve delivery and reduce leakages.
  - **Example:** DBT streamlining subsidies.
- **Capacity Constraints:** Local bodies lack technical and administrative capacity.
- **National Coordination:** Centralisation is necessary for large-scale issues like infrastructure and climate policy.

Way Forward

- **Strengthening LSG:** Ensure devolution of functions, finances, and functionaries.
- **Participatory Planning:** Empower Gram Sabhas and community institutions.
- **Context-Based Implementation:** Provide flexibility to states and local bodies.
- **Human-Centric Technology:** Ensure inclusive digital systems with offline alternatives and grievance redressal.
- **Enhanced Accountability:** Promote social audits and citizen participation.

LOCAL GOVERNANCE IN INDIA

The **73rd** and **74th Constitutional Amendments**, enacted in 1992, were important in decentralizing governance in India. These amendments introduced **Part IX** and **Part IXA** to the Constitution, respectively, granting constitutional status to **Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) and Urban Local Bodies (ULBs).** They mandated regular elections, reservations for marginalized communities, and the establishment of State Election Commissions and Finance Commissions to ensure autonomy and accountability at the grassroots level.

Constitutional Recognition of Local Governance Bodies

The **73rd and 74th Amendments** institutionalized local self-governance by:

- **Granting Constitutional Status**: Ensuring that local bodies are integral to the governance structure.
- **Mandating Regular Elections**: Ensuring democratic functioning through periodic elections.
- **Providing Reservations**: Allocating seats for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and women to promote inclusivity.
- **Establishing Finance Commissions**: To recommend financial devolution to local bodies.
- **Enabling State Election Commissions**: To oversee the conduct of elections at the local level.

Do you know?

- The Ministry of Panchayati Raj organized a National Colloquium on "Governance at the Grassroots after 30 Years of the 73rd Constitutional Amendment" on 24th April 2024.
- The National Colloquium on Grassroots Governance brings together key stakeholders to discuss enhancing Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) through digital technology, good governance, and public service delivery.
- It focuses on MoPR's initiatives like Smart Panchayats, e-governance, and citizen participation to strengthen transparency, efficiency, and grassroots engagement.

PANCHAYATS AND MUNICIPALITIES

- **Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs):** A three-tier system comprising Gram Panchayats (village level), Panchayat Samitis (block level), and Zila Parishads (district level).
  - Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) play a vital role in rural governance, providing essential services like healthcare, sanitation, and education at the grassroots level. **Eg.,** Pimpri Gavali (Maharashtra) showcases successful PRI involvement, where the local Gram Sabha led watershed development, securing water resources for the community.
  - Gram Sabhas promote direct democratic participation, enabling marginalized groups to voice their concerns and contribute to local governance and development planning. **Eg.,** Gariba Gram Panchayat (Bihar) highlights how local participation in development projects improves infrastructure and fosters inclusive growth.

- **Urban Local Bodies (ULBs):** Urban Local Bodies (ULBs) are small local bodies that administers or governs a city or a town of specified population. They are divided into Nagar Panchayats (transitional areas), Municipalities (smaller urban areas), and Municipal Corporations (larger urban areas).

PURA: Connectivity-Centric Rural Development through Good Governance **(UPSC PYQ 2013)**

Provision of Urban Amenities in Rural Areas **(PURA)**, proposed by **Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam** in ***Target 3 Billion,*** aims to transform rural India by delivering urban infrastructure and services to rural regions.

Role of Connectivity in Providing Urban Amenities in Rural Areas (PURA)

- **Physical Connectivity:** Building roads and networks linking rural areas to urban centers improves access to markets, services, and jobs.
  - **Eg.:** The **PM Gram Sadak Yojana**, aims to provide all-weather road connectivity to rural areas.
- **Economic Connectivity:** Rural connectivity to markets and financial institutions boosts entrepreneurship by enabling farmers and artisans to sell products more efficiently.
  - **Eg.:** The **e-NAM (National Agriculture Market)** platform.
- **Energy Connectivity:** A reliable energy supply, such as through solar or wind power, is essential for supporting businesses, lighting, and the functioning of essential services.

Functions and Responsibilities of Panchayats and Municipalities

- Panchayats are responsible for rural development, including implementing schemes like MGNREGA, maintaining village infrastructure, managing primary schools and health centers, and promoting local economic activities.
- Municipalities handle urban governance tasks such as city planning, waste management, housing (e.g., PMAY-U), public transport, and slum rehabilitation, along with disaster management and environmental protection.

Significance of Decentralization in Local Governance (UPSC 2022)

- **Empowerment of Local Institutions:** PRIs and ULBs now have constitutional status, empowering them to make **region-specific decisions** and improve **local service delivery**.
- **Eg:** Decentralized governance to improve **primary education** and **health services**.
- **Increased Citizen Participation:** Decentralization has encouraged direct participation of local communities in decision-making, fostering **accountability** and **inclusivity**.
- **Faster Resolution of Local Issues:** Local governance reduces bureaucratic delays and enables a quick response to issues like sanitation, water supply, and infrastructure. **Eg:** The **Zero Waste Initiative** in **Alappuzha, Kerala**, led by municipal bodies, successfully transformed waste management through decentralized planning.
- **Strengthening of Local Economic Development:** Local governments promote small-scale industries, SHGs, and cooperative movements, boosting **rural livelihoods** and **self-reliance**.
- **Eg:** The **Kudumbashree program** in Kerala, led by local self-government institutions, has empowered women economically.

Challenges in Empowering Local Governance (UPSC 2023)

Challenges	Explanation	Recent Example (2024–25)
Limited Financial Autonomy	Local bodies rely on state/central funds; poor own revenue generation limits independence.	Only 36% of Urban Local Bodies (ULBs) met Smart Cities revenue targets (MoHUA, Jan 2025).
Capacity Deficit	Many representatives lack training in planning, budgeting, and execution.	Mission Karmayogi for Panchayats proposed to boost local capacity (PIB, Feb 2025).
State Interference	States delay elections, override local decisions, and control fund flow. Limited Role in City Planning: States have created parallel structures like SPVs in urban development projects limiting ULBs role.	Panchayat elections delayed in Andhra Pradesh due to state-level administrative hurdles. SPVs under Smart Cities Mission to plan, appraise, approve, release funds and implement projects

Weak People's Participation	❖ Gram Sabhas and Ward Committees are often inactive, undermining grassroots democracy.	❖ CAG 2023 report flagged low Gram Sabha activity in Bihar and Madhya Pradesh.
Gender & Social Inequality	❖ Women and SC/ST leaders face discrimination or proxy control in governance.	❖ Reports from Rajasthan (2024) show women sarpanches sidelined by male relatives.
Digital Divide	❖ Lack of internet and digital tools in rural areas hinders e-governance and data-driven decision making.	❖ SVAMITVA Scheme rollout faced delays in northeastern states due to low digital infrastructure.

Issues in Auditing of Local Bodies

- **Poor Record Keeping:** Financial records are often incomplete, inconsistent, and vary across states due to lack of uniform standards.
- **Lack of Skilled Personnel:** Shortage of trained auditors leads to weak and superficial audits.
- **Overlapping Jurisdictions:** Multiple auditing agencies (CAG, State departments, etc.) create confusion and inefficiency.

Way Ahead (2nd ARC Recommendations)

- Simplify audit/accounting formats for ease of understanding by elected PRI members.
- Ensure independence of auditing bodies like DLFA by separating them from state administration.
- The head of this body should be appointed by the State Government from a panel approved by CAG.
- Ensure legal access to relevant records for audit authorities through state laws.

Way Forward for Strengthening Local Governance in India

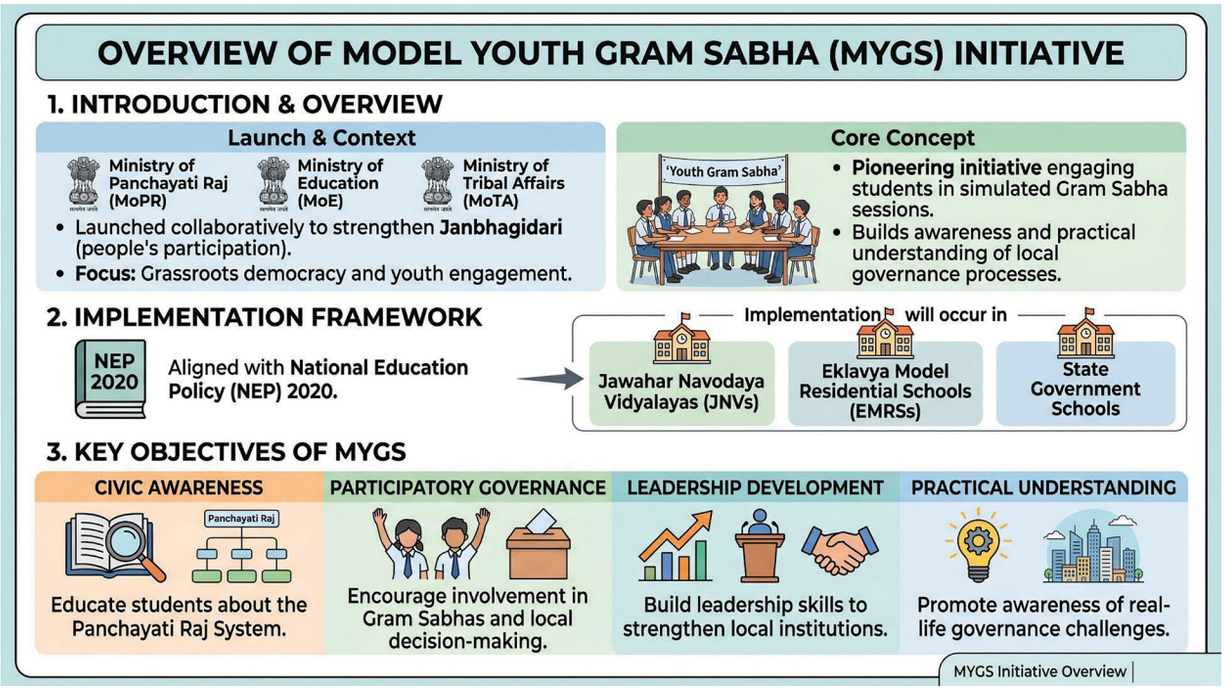
- **Enhancing Financial Autonomy:** Local bodies should be able to raise and use their own money better. This can be done by improving property tax collection, setting fair user charges, and giving performance-based grants. For example, the **15th Finance Commission** suggested giving more funds to Panchayats based on their work (GoI, 2024).
- **Capacity Building Initiatives**: Regular training for elected representatives and local officials is crucial for effective governance. For example, the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj**, in collaboration with State Institutes of Rural Development (SIRDs), conducts training under the *Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan (RGSA)* to enhance the capabilities of Panchayat functionaries.
- **Digital Governance**: Regular training and adoption of digital tools (e.g., e-municipality systems) can improve service delivery and transparency Eg: the **Smart Cities Mission** promoting GIS-based planning and online grievance redressal.
- **Timely Devolution of Powers**: Ensuring timely elections, financial transfers, and real autonomy to State Election Commissions can help decentralization succeed. Eg: In 2024, the **Supreme Court** directed Maharashtra to conduct pending Panchayat elections without delay, reinforcing this principle.
- **Strengthening People's Participation**: Active functioning of Gram Sabhas must be ensured through awareness drives, digital tools, and regular meetings. Eg: The **"Gram Manchitra"** portal was recently expanded to enable participatory village planning using GIS technology (MoPR, 2024).
- **Empowering Marginalized Sections**: Women and other marginalized groups need leadership support and safeguards against proxy representation. Eg: Odisha's **"Leadership for Change"** initiative in 2024 trained women sarpanches to lead independently and effectively (State Gov. Report, 2024).

Do you know?

The International Centre for Audit of Local Governance (iCAL) was inaugurated in Rajkot, Gujarat recently.

- **Expand CAG Audits to PRIs**: Extend the Comptroller and Auditor General's (CAG) audits to all Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) for better financial oversight and accountability, addressing gaps seen in cases like **Malur, Karnataka.**
  - Grant CAG quasi-judicial powers, standardize accounting practices, and involve citizens through social audits to ensure efficient use of public funds and enhance transparency in local governance.

MODEL YOUTH GRAM SABHA



Key Words

Evenhanded Strategy, Political Acumen, Fact-Based Interventions, Culture of Inactivity, Community Perspectives, Unified Standards of Behavior, 3P (Pro-Poor Public) Welfare, Departmental Separation, Shift from Biased to Comprehensive Governance, Decisive Administration, Limited Authority, Swarajya (Self-Governance) and Surajya (Effective Governance), Reform, Transform and Perform

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	"In contemporary development models, decision-making and problem-solving responsibilities are not located close to the source of information and execution defeating the objectives of development." Critically evaluate.	2025
2.	"The states in India seem reluctant to empower urban local bodies both functionally as well as financially." Comment.	2023
3.	To what extent, in your opinion, has the decentralization of power in India changed the governance landscape at the grassroots?	2022
4.	Khap Panchayats have been in the news for functioning as extra-constitutional authorities, often delivering pronouncements amounting to human rights violations. Discuss critically the actions taken by the legislative, executive and the judiciary to set the things right in this regard.	2015
5.	Two parallel run schemes of the Government, viz the Adhar card and NPR, one of voluntary and the other as compulsory, have led to debates at national levels and also litigations. On merits, discuss whether or not both schemes need to run concurrently. Analyze the potential of the schemes to achieve development benefits and equitable growth.	2014
6.	The basis of providing urban amenities in rural areas (PURA) is rooted in establishing connectivity. Comment.	2013

❖ ❖ ❖

4 e-Governance

World Bank defines **"e-Governance as the use by government agencies of information technologies** (such as Wide Area Networks, the Internet, and mobile computing) that have the ability to transform relations with citizens, businesses, and other arms of government". e- governance is the use of power of information technology by the government to ease the process of governance. (ICT + Governance = e-governance)

INDIA'S E-GOVERNANCE JOURNEY

Year	Event & Significance
1970	Establishment of Department of Electronics, marking the government's commitment to electronic governance.
1977	Launch of DISNIC by NIC to computerise district administration and streamline processes.
1987	Introduction of NICNET using satellite technology, enabling nationwide e-governance.
1980s–90s	Expansion of NICNET and DISNIC, strengthening digitisation at district level.
2006	Launch of National e-Governance Plan (NeGP) to improve service delivery, transparency, and efficiency.
Post-2006	Initiatives like Digital India, DigiLocker, Mobile Seva, and MyGov promoted digital governance and citizen empowerment.

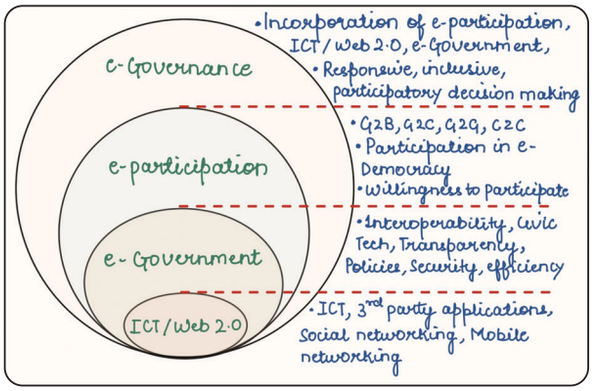


Fig. 4.1: Evolution of e-Governance

Knowledge Nuggets

- As of April 2024, 95.15% villages have access to the internet.
- Total internet subscribers increased from 251.59 million as of March 2014 to 1028 million in December 2025 **(PIB)**

FEATURES OF E-GOVERNANCE

The purpose of implementation of e-governance is to raise the level of performance and ensure the proper delivery of services to all this will be possible through five main features of e-governance termed as **"SMART".**

- **S-Simple**: Government rules and procedures need to be simplified to make them more user-friendly.
- **M-Moral**: Since anti-corruption and vigilance agencies have improved, officers are being instilled with ethics and values.
- **A-Accountable**: ICT aids in the establishment of performance criteria and the effective measurement of those standards.
- **R-Responsive**: Service delivery that is efficient and government that is responsive to the people.

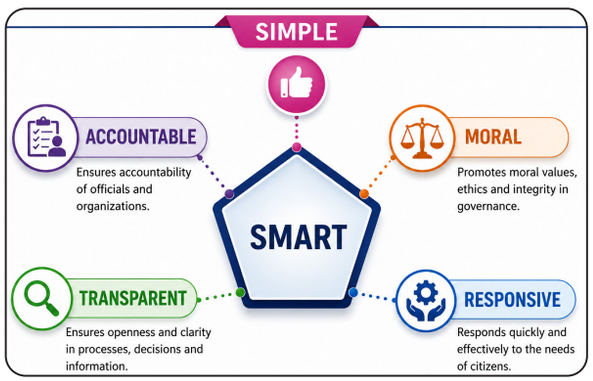


Fig. 4.2: Features of e-Governance

- **T-Transparent**: Information that was once kept secret is now available to the public, bringing equity and the rule of law in government departments.

COMPONENTS OF E-GOVERNANCE

According to 2nd ARC, Interaction in governance happen at Government To Citizen (G2C), Government To Government (G2G) including Government To Employees (G2E), and Government To Business (G2B) LEVEL. The significance of e-governance can be understood by analyzing the impact of e-governance on these interactions.

1. **Government to Citizen (G2C):** G2C involves the direct delivery of government services and information to citizens through digital platforms, ensuring transparency and efficiency. Examples: UMANG (multi-service app), DigiLocker (secure digital storage), CPGRAMS (grievance redressal).
2. **Government to Business (G2B):** G2B focuses on simplifying business interactions with the government by digitiSing regulatory and service processes. Examples: GST Portal (tax compliance), GeM (e-procurement), Udyam (MSME registration).
3. **Government to Government (G2G):** G2G refers to digital collaboration and information exchange between various government bodies to enhance governance efficiency. Examples: e-Samiksha (project monitoring), Sandes (official messaging).

Knowledge Nuggets

Digital sovereignty refers to a nation's control over its digital infrastructure—data, hardware, and software—to safeguard security, privacy, and economic interests. It reduces foreign dependence and boosts innovation but faces challenges from global interconnectedness and trade barriers. Strengthening local tech capabilities, investing in digital skills, and fostering global cooperation are key to achieving it.

Interactive Service Model' of e-Governance **(UPSC 2024)**

The Interactive Service Model of e-Governance enables two-way communication between citizens and the government using ICT. It enhances access to government services while promoting active citizen participation, allowing citizens to both access services and engage in governance processes.

Role of the Interactive Service Model of e-Governance

- **Enhanced Citizen Engagement:** Offers platforms for feedback, improving governance. **Eg: MyGov** allows citizens to share suggestions on government policies.
- **Improved Service Delivery:** Streamlines services, reducing delays and enhancing **accessibility**. **Eg: Digital India Portal** simplifies services like passport renewals and tax filings.
- **Transparency in Operations:** Provides real-time data to monitor government services. **Eg: e-Taal** tracks e-transactions for services like **public distribution systems**.
- **Accountability through Feedback:** Tracks complaints and ensures official accountability. **Eg: RailMadad** allows citizens to lodge and track railway complaints.

E-governance, particularly through the Interactive Service Model, holds the potential for transforming public service delivery by promoting inclusivity and transparency. As the current Indian **Prime Minister** emphasised, **"E-governance is easy, effective, and economic governance."**

INITIATIVES BY GOVERNMENT TO PROMOTE E-GOVERNANCE

The National e-Governance Plan has enabled many e-Governance initiatives, the foremost being the Digital India Mission (2015). Its primary components include establishing a secure and resilient digital infrastructure, delivering government services digitally, and ensuring universal digital literacy. Some of the e-Governance initiatives in different sectors are discussed below:

Public Service Delivery

- **Aadhar:** The collaboration between the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) and various private entities enables the Aadhaar-based authentication system, facilitating access to government services and subsidies.
- **Digital Locker (DigiLocker):** It is a digital document storage and sharing platform that allows citizens to store, access, and share their digital documents and certificates issued by various government agencies.

- **e-District Project:** It aims to deliver various government services electronically to citizens at the district level, including issuance of certificates, land records, and revenue administration. As per Assam govt. e-District Project has delivered over **10 million digitally signed certificates.**
- **e-Courts Integrated Mission Mode Project:** It aims to digitise court processes and improve judicial efficiency through e-filing, case tracking, and virtual court hearings. As of October 31, 2024, **3.38 crore cases** were heard via video conferencing in District and High Courts, enhancing judicial efficiency.
- **Public Grievance Redressal Portal (CPGRAMS):** It enables citizens to lodge grievances online, track their status, and receive timely redressal across various government departments. Between 2020 and 2024, over **1.15 crore grievances** were redressed through CPGRAMS.
- **e-Sampark Portal:** It is a citizen engagement platform that enables interaction between citizens and government departments, allowing citizens to provide feedback, file grievances, and access information about government services.
- **E-Daakhil Portal** : It enables consumers across all states and UTs to file complaints online, offering a cost-effective and efficient grievance redressal system.
- **Common Service Centres** : These are run by Village Level Entrepreneurs to deliver essential e-governance, financial, and commercial services in rural areas, promoting inclusive digital growth.

Knowledge Nuggets

National e-Governance Service Delivery Assessment (NeSDA) Report, 2025

- Himachal Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Kerala, Gujarat, Karnataka and Maharashtra have achieved 100% saturation of 56 mandatory e-services.

PRAGATI Platform:

- It was launched in 2015, PRAGATI (Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation) is a multi-purpose, technology-enabled governance platform that integrates accountability, transparency, and timely decision-making across all levels of government, with regular review meetings chaired by the Prime Minister to ensure direct Centre–State coordination ("Team India" approach).

Healthcare

- **Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM):** It aims at establishing the essential infrastructure required for the integrated digital health ecosystem in the country.
- **ABHA Cards:** They provide each citizen with a unique 14-digit health ID to digitally access and share their medical records securely. They enable seamless interaction between patients, doctors, and healthcare providers across digital platforms.
- **Poshan Tracker:** ICT platform for real-time monitoring of nutrition and growth of children (0–6 years) using WHO standards, enabling early detection of malnutrition.
- **Other Examples:** National Health Claims Exchange (NHCX), Digital Health Incentive Scheme (DHIS)

Education

- **SWAYAM (Study Webs of Active Learning for Young Aspiring Minds):** SWAYAM is an online platform that offers free courses and resources from various universities and institutions across India.
  - **SWAYAM Prabha** is a group of several DTH channels dedicated to broadcasting educational content 24x7.
- **DIKSHA (Digital Infrastructure for Knowledge Sharing):** It is a national digital platform that provides teachers with access to e-content and teaching resources. It offers interactive textbooks, lesson plans, quizzes, and other learning materials to support classroom teaching and enhance student engagement.
- **ePathshala**: It is an initiative by NCERT that provides digital textbooks and educational resources for school.
- **National Academic Depository (NAD):** NAD is a digital platform that stores academic certificates and transcripts in a secure and tamper-proof manner.

Agriculture and Rural Development

- **National Agriculture Market (e-NAM):** e-NAM is an online trading platform that facilitates transparent and competitive bidding for agricultural produce. It connects agricultural markets (mandis) across the country, enabling farmers to sell their produce to buyers anywhere in India.
- **M-KISAN:** M-KISAN, through its mKisan Portal, disseminates crop-related advisories to registered farmers via SMS. mKisan Provide timely information on weather forecasts, pest outbreaks, and best farming practices in regional languages

- **Soil Health Card (SHC) Scheme:** It provides digital soil health cards to farmers, containing information about soil nutrients, fertilisers, and recommendations for crop-specific nutrient management.
- **e-Krishi Samvad:** It is an online platform that enables farmers to seek agricultural advice and information from experts. It facilitates two-way communication between farmers and agricultural scientists through toll-free helplines.

Financial Development and Inclusion

- **Unified Payments Interface (UPI):** With UPI, users can conveniently make payments, split bills, and conduct transactions across various platforms and banking institutions.
- **e-Rupi:** It is a prepaid voucher-based system that enables seamless and contactless digital transactions, ensuring transparency and eliminating leakages in the distribution of government benefits
- **RuPay credit card linkage with UPI:** It allows users to make UPI payments using their RuPay credit cards — a boost for digital transactions and small merchants.

Urban and Rural Governance

- **Pradhan Mantri Gramin Digital Saksharta Abhiyan (PMGDISHA):** It aims at digitally literating six crore individuals in rural areas. It targets approximately 40% of rural households by ensuring at least one member from each eligible household receives digital literacy training.
- **National Optical Fiber Network (NOFN):** It aims to provide broadband connectivity to over 250,000 gram panchayats, enabling delivery of e-governance services to rural areas.
- **e-Gram Swaraj:** It enables panchayats to digitise administrative processes, maintain records, and provide citizen services online. e-Gram Swaraj promotes transparency, accountability, and efficiency in rural governance.

Do you know?

Under the Digital India Land Records Modernization Programme (DILRMP), as of 2024, 98.5% of rural land records have been digitized.

- **e-Municipality Portals**: These portals enable citizens to pay property taxes, apply for building permits, request birth and death certificates, lodge complaints, and track the status of their applications from the comfort of their homes.

Election Management

- **Election Commission of India (ECI) Portal:** The Election Commission of India has developed a comprehensive online portal to provide voters with access to electoral information, including voter registration, electoral rolls, polling station locations, and election schedules.
- **Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) and Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT):** VVPATs provide voters with a physical paper trail of their votes, enhancing transparency and confidence in the electoral process.
- **Electoral Photo Identity Card (EPIC) Management System:** The EPIC Management System digitises the process of issuing and managing EPICs, enabling the Election Commission to maintain accurate records of voters and prevent electoral fraud.
- **C-Vigil Mobile App:** It allows citizens to report violations of the Model Code of Conduct and other electoral malpractices by capturing and uploading photos or videos of such incidents in real time.

Transportation and Logistics

- **VAHAN and SARATHI:** These online platforms enable citizens to apply for and renew vehicle registrations and driving licences, make fee payments, and access relevant documents and information.
- **e-Challan System:** These systems use technology such as cameras and sensors to detect traffic violations such as speeding and jumping red lights. Violators receive electronic fines (e-challans) which can be paid online, reducing the need for physical paperwork and improving the efficiency of traffic management.
- **e-Toll Collection:** The implementation of electronic toll collection (ETC) systems such as FASTag has transformed toll collection on highways in India.

Social Welfare and Poverty Alleviation

- **National Career Service (NCS):** It aims at providing a variety of employment-related services to job seekers and employers.
- **Pensioners' Portal:** It provides a single platform for retired government employees to access pension-related information, download pension payment orders, and submit grievances online.
- **Shram Suvidha Portal:** It is an online platform launched by the Ministry of Labour and Employment to consolidate labour-related compliances and facilitate ease of doing business.
- **e-SHRAM Portal:** It is an online platform for registering and tracking unorganised sector workers under various social security schemes.

State level e-Governance Initiatives

- **E-Seva (Andhra Pradesh):** facilitates payment of utility bills, issuance of certificates, licenses and permits.
- **Khajane Project (Karnataka):** digitalized the treasury system of the state.
- **FRIENDS (Kerala):** is a single-window facility to pay taxes and other financial dues to the State government.
- **Lokvani Project (Uttar Pradesh):** Single-window solution relating to the handling of grievances; land record maintenance and providing a mixture of essential services.
- **MARVEL (Maharashtra):** The Maharashtra Advanced Research and Vigilance for Enhanced Law Enforcement (MARVEL) is an AI-driven system implemented by the Maharashtra Police to enhance crime-solving capabilities and predictive policing.
- **Kottayam E-Governance Plan (Kerala):** Initiatives include implementing eOffice systems, setting up free public Wi-Fi hotspots, and promoting the Kottayam Tourism Mobile App to enhance digital infrastructure and services.
- **Namma Gramsabha App (Tamil Nadu):** A mobile application designed to facilitate citizen participation in local governance by providing information on Gram Sabha meetings and decisions.

e-Governance: Case Studies

Telangana has emerged as a frontrunner in e-governance through initiatives such as the Dharani Portal for land records, T-App Folio for integrated public services, and TS-iPASS for streamlined industrial approvals.

- Its data-driven platforms like **Samagra Vedika** and schemes like **Rythu Bandhu** ensure targeted and transparent welfare delivery.
- Innovative pilots like **Medicine from the Sky** further highlight the state's tech-led governance approach.
- **Kerala** pioneered digital governance through initiatives like e-Health Kerala, which offers a unified health information system, and e-Office, which digitizes government workflow.
  - The state's **Akshaya Centres**, set up across villages, provide a wide range of G2C services and have been crucial in bridging the digital divide.

Use Value' of Information in e-Governance **(UPSC 2018)**

- **Informed Policy Formulation and Decision-Making:** Accurate data analysis from digital platforms informs effective public policies and enables targeted interventions.
- **Public Accountability:** Accessible information enables citizens to hold authorities accountable. **Eg:** The **Right to Information (RTI) Act** empowers citizens to seek information.
- **Targeted Welfare Programs:** Data-driven insights ensure benefits reach intended beneficiaries.
- **Disaster Response:** Timely information dissemination aids in effective disaster management. **Eg:** The **Indian Meteorological Department's** early warning systems provide real-time updates during cyclones, enabling prompt evacuations.
- **Citizen Participation:** Informed citizens can actively engage in governance processes. **Eg:** The **MyGov** platform promotes participatory governance via feedback mechanism.

Visakhapatnam Declaration (28th National Conference on e-Governance)

- **National Vision:** Promotes inclusive, citizen-centric, and transparent governance aligned with Minimum Government, Maximum Governance and Viksit Bharat 2047.
- **Technology Integration:** Encourages use of AI, ML, Blockchain, GIS, IoT, and Data Analytics for efficient governance with focus on ethical and transparent AI adoption.
- **Best Practices Replication:** Emphasises scaling successful models like SAMPADA 2.0, eKhata, DAMS, Rohini Panchayat.
- **Inclusive Digital Governance:** Expands services to North-East and Ladakh under NeSDA and promotes digital literacy for women, youth, and marginalised groups.
- **Cybersecurity Focus:** Advocates Zero-Trust architecture, AI monitoring, and post-quantum security to build resilient digital systems.
- **Agriculture Digitisation:** Promotes National Agri Stack for credit, advisories, and market access supporting climate-smart farming

CHALLENGES OF E-GOVERNANCE (UPSC 2023, 2021, 2019)

- **Digital Divide:** Rural/marginalised groups lack access to internet and digital literacy despite Digital India efforts.
- **Data Privacy:** Incidents like Aadhaar breach highlight weak data protection in e-governance systems.

- **Poor Infrastructure:** Inadequate broadband and tech access, especially in remote areas (e.g., Arunachal Pradesh and North Eastern states have poor infrastructure).
- **Resistance to Change:** Government officials and citizens often resist shifting from paper-based to digital systems.
- **Technical Complexity:** Limited expertise/resources to handle technical advancements (e.g., GSTN glitches during rollout).
- **Data Deniability:** Withholding key data (e.g., PLFS, caste census and consumption expenditure data delay) weakens accountability and informed policy-making.
  - To counter this, there is a need for autonomous and statutorily-backed data institutions, real-time digital data systems, and responsible governance that values transparency over short-term image management.

E-Governance: Bias towards Technology vs User-Centric Design

E-governance in India has focused on **strong digital infrastructure and backend integration**. However, many services remain **complex and less user-friendly**, indicating a bias towards technology over citizens.

Bias towards Technology

- **Language & Accessibility Gap:** Platforms often ignore linguistic diversity and accessibility needs.
- **Over-Reliance on Digital Systems:** Emphasis on digitisation reduces accessibility for digitally excluded groups. **Eg:** DILRMP land records remain complex for farmers.
- **Complex Interfaces:** Technical jargon and multi-step processes confuse users.
- **High Cost Focus:** Investment prioritised on infrastructure over citizen training and awareness.
- **Output-Based Metrics:** Focus on system integration rather than service quality and ease of use.

Bias towards Back-End Integration

- **Authentication over Access:** Strict e-KYC and biometric systems create barriers during failures.

  Eg: Aadhaar authentication issues causing welfare exclusion.
- **One-Size-Fits-All Design:** Centralised portals ignore regional, linguistic, and demographic diversity.
- **Security over Usability:** Multiple OTPs and compliance layers make platforms cumbersome.
- **Lack of Personalisation:** Services do not adapt to user needs or capabilities.
- **Weak Support Systems:** Limited guidance and help mechanisms for first-time users.

  Eg: e-Shram registration challenges for migrant workers.

Emerging User-Centric Shift

- **UMANG & DigiLocker:** Provide simplified, integrated access to services.
- **Aadhaar-enabled DBT:** Ensures direct benefit delivery with reduced leakages.
- **e-Sanjeevani:** Expands access to telemedicine, especially in rural areas.

WAY FORWARD FOR EFFECTIVE E-GOVERNANCE IN INDIA

- **Improving Digital Infrastructure:** Expand projects like BharatNet to provide high-speed connectivity to all gram panchayats, supporting e-Governance across rural areas. (Aspirational Districts are being digitally upgraded under the Digital India program.)
- **Increasing Digital Literacy:** Continue and expand initiatives like PMGDISHA to improve digital skills among rural households, ensuring broader access to e-Governance. (Over 6 crore people trained under PMGDISHA by 2024 to use basic digital services.)
- **Ensuring Data Security and Privacy**: Implement robust cybersecurity measures and legislative frameworks, like the Personal Data Protection Bill, to protect citizens' data and boost trust in e-Governance.
- **Streamlining Services:** Leverage platforms like UMANG to offer seamless access to government services, promoting 'Faceless, Paperless, Cashless' interactions.
- **Promoting Inclusivity and Accessibility:** Make e-Governance tools accessible in multiple regional languages and adapted for differently-abled users to ensure wider inclusivity.
- **Integrate services through single-window platforms:** Offer multiple government services through one unified digital platform to reduce duplication. (UMANG app provides access to over 1,500 services on a single interface.)

Digital India Initiative

Digital India initiative, launched by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) in 2015, aims to transform India into a digitally empowered society. It focuses on providing digital services to citizens, improving governance, and fostering a cashless economy.

Objectives

- Empower citizens with digital resources in multiple languages.
- Enhance governance efficiency through seamless digital processes.
- Create a cloud-based platform for better planning and decision-making.

Achievements

- **BharatNet**: Connected 2.5 lakh Gram Panchayats with fiber-optic networks.
- **Common Service Centres (CSCs)**: Over 5.2 lakh CSCs provide government services across rural and urban areas.
- **Aadhaar**: Covers 99% of the population, enabling digital access to government services.
- **DigiLocker**: More than 13.7 crore users store over 562 crore documents digitally.
- **UMANG**: Provides 1668 e-services and 20,197 bill payment services through mobile apps.
- **UPI**: Facilitates over 730 crore digital transactions worth Rs. 11.9 lakh crore.

SOCIAL MEDIA AND GOVERNANCE

Social media can be defined as **any web or mobile based platform that enables an individual or agency to communicate interactively** and enables the exchange of user generated content.

Knowledge Nuggets

National e-Governance Service Delivery Assessment (NeSDA) Report, 2024

- As of March 2024, the average monthly data consumption per user rose to **20.27 GB** (up from 0.27 GB in 2014–15), with **954.4 million internet subscribers—556 million urban** and **398 million rural**.
- **4G** dominates with 82.7% users, while **5G** adoption has reached 16.9%.
- With over **660 million smartphone users**, and data costs ranging from ₹8.7 to ₹10.4 per GB, India is among the most affordable internet markets globally.

Positive Impact of Social Media on Governance

- **Government and citizens:** Social media has enabled two-way communication between the government and citizens, **e.g.** use of Twitter by ministers during COVID-19 etc.
- **Women empowerment:** Social media has empowered women by providing them a platform to raise their concerns and issues, **e.g. MeToo campaign** etc.
- **Real-time grievance redressal:** Governments use social media platforms like Twitter and Facebook to promptly address citizen complaints. Example: Railways and police departments respond to passenger and safety complaints via Twitter handles like @RailMinIndia and @Uppolice.
- **Policy feedback and consultations:** Social media enables participatory governance by inviting public suggestions on policy matters. Example: Platforms like MyGov.in seek citizen input on draft policies and bills, promoting transparency and inclusivity.
- **Disaster management and crisis response:** Social media is used by government agencies to disseminate warnings and coordinate relief efforts. Example: During floods and cyclones, state disaster response forces use X (formerly Twitter) to share helpline numbers and evacuation updates.

Need for Regulation

- **Undermining public institutions:** Coordinated misinformation campaigns target democratic institutions like the judiciary, Election Commission, and Parliament, eroding public trust. Example: Viral posts questioning EVM credibility without evidence during elections.
- **Challenges in policy enforcement:** Lack of accountability from social media platforms hampers effective enforcement of national regulations and laws. Example: Non-compliance by platforms with India's IT Rules 2021 regarding takedown of unlawful content.
- **Digital vigilantism and mob justice:** Viral misinformation often leads to extrajudicial actions, burdening law enforcement and threatening rule of law. Example: Lynching incidents in India linked to WhatsApp rumors about child kidnappers.
- **Invasion of privacy:** Social media platforms have been allegedly compromising the privacy of users and there is a need to protect personalized data of users. **E.g. Cambridge analytical case.**
- **Terror promotion:** Social media platforms have been used by terror organizations for radicalisation, recruitment and training of their cadre. Example: Additionally, the Left Wing Extremism (LWE) Division of the MHA monitors the activities of groups such as the CPI (Maoist), which have been known to exploit social media for propaganda and recruitment purposes.

❖ **Propagation of Hate Speech and Civil Unrest:** Platforms have been used to incite communal tensions and riots, such as during the Delhi riots of 2020, highlighting the urgent need for governance frameworks that enforce accountability, content moderation, and crisis response mechanisms.

Steps Taken for Countering Challenges Posed by Social Media

Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021:

1. **Due Diligence**: Social media platforms with over 5 million users must appoint a grievance officer, nodal officer, and chief compliance officer.
2. **Grievance Redressal**: Platforms must establish a time-bound grievance redressal mechanism.
3. **Traceability**: Significant platforms must identify the originators of problematic content to aid government investigations.
4. **Automated Content Flagging**: Platforms are required to use technology to proactively identify and remove unlawful content.
5. **Oversight Mechanism**: Introduction of an inter-departmental committee and self-regulatory bodies for monitoring content.
6. **Penalties**: Non-compliance could lead to the loss of intermediary status, making platforms liable for user-generated content.

Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 (DPDPA)

Key Features of the Act:

❖ **Scope**: Applies to digital personal data processed in India and outside India if offering goods or services in India.
❖ **Consent**: Requires lawful consent after informing individuals about data collection and its purpose.
❖ **Lower Age of Consent**: Government may lower the age of consent for minors to ensure safe internet access.
❖ **Cross-Border Data Flows**: Eases international data transfers with a blacklisting mechanism.
❖ **Impact on Social Media**: Significant Data Fiduciaries must implement user verification to reduce anonymity and combat trolling.
❖ **Exemptions**: Data protection rights may be exempt in cases like preventing offences or enforcing legal rights, especially for government activities related to security.
❖ **Data Protection Board**: Establishment of a board to monitor compliance, address grievances, and impose penalties.

Challenges:

❖ **Ambiguity in Exemptions**: Broad exemptions for government use of data could lead to misuse and weaken citizens' privacy rights.
❖ **Enforcement Challenges**: Effective implementation and resources for the Data Protection Board are critical; otherwise, non-compliance may persist.
❖ **Impact on Innovation**: Strict compliance requirements could burden businesses, especially start-ups, and hinder innovation.
❖ **Cross-Border Data Flow**: Restrictions on cross-border data could lead to conflicts with international norms and affect global data-sharing practices.

EMERGING TECHNOLOGIES AND THEIR POTENTIAL IMPACTS ON GOVERNANCE

Cybersecurity and Governance

Cybersecurity plays a crucial role in preserving the integrity, confidentiality, and availability of government data and services. It ensures trust in digital transactions, protects critical infrastructure, and safeguards national security interests. Without robust cybersecurity measures, governments are vulnerable to cyber threats such as data breaches, ransomware attacks, and cyber espionage, which can disrupt governance processes and erode public trust.

Examples of Cyber Attacks in India

❖ **AIIMS Delhi Cyberattack (2022)**: Ransomware attack disrupted hospital services for days; patient data and medical records were inaccessible, highlighting gaps in healthcare cybersecurity.

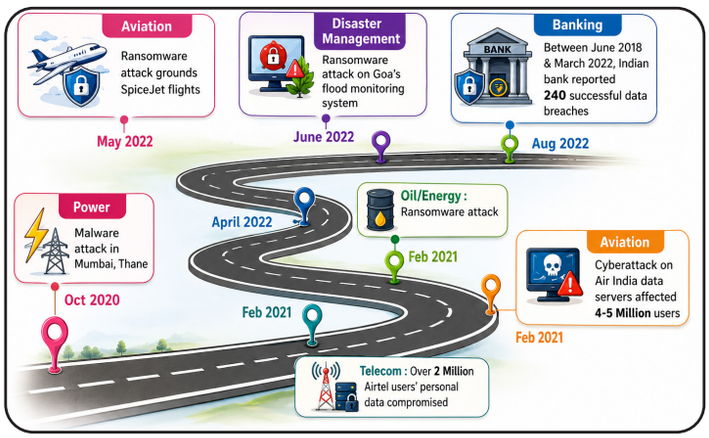


Fig. 4.3: Recent Cyber Attacks and Security incidents

- **Kudankulam Nuclear Plant (2019)**: Administrative network breached by North Korea-linked Lazarus Group, raising national security concerns.
- **WazirX Crypto Exchange Hack (2024):** A cyberattack led to the theft of ~$230 million (₹2,000 crore) from digital wallets, forcing suspension of withdrawals and exposing vulnerabilities in India's fintech and crypto infrastructure.

Cyber Security Initiatives by India

1. In India, the **Information Technology (IT) Act, 2000**, and initiatives like the **National Cyber Security Policy, 2013**, provide the legal framework for cybersecurity governance and enforcement.
2. **Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In):** Nodal agency under MeitY for responding to cyber threats, issuing alerts, and coordinating incident response.
3. **National Cyber Security Policy (2013):** Aims to protect public and private infrastructure from cyberattacks and establish a secure cyber ecosystem.
4. **Cyber Swachhta Kendra (Botnet Cleaning Centre):** Provides tools to detect and remove malicious software and secure user systems.
5. **National Cyber Coordination Centre (NCCC):** Monitors cyber threats in real time and coordinates between intelligence agencies for proactive responses.
6. **Information Security Education and Awareness (ISEA) Program:** Conducts training and awareness campaigns on cyber hygiene for citizens, especially students and government employees.
7. **Cyber Surakshit Bharat Initiative:** Public-private partnership to train government officials in cyber security best practices.

Way Forward for Cybersecurity in India

- **Strengthen Institutional Framework: Example**: Expand and empower the *Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C)* and *CERT-In* to ensure proactive threat detection and response.
  - Need for a dedicated **Cybersecurity Authority** for critical infrastructure.
- **Enact Robust Data Protection Law:** Swift implementation of the **Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023** to safeguard citizen data and ensure accountability of data processors.
- **Enhance Public-Private Partnerships:** Collaboration with tech firms and startups to develop indigenous cybersecurity solutions. **Example**: Infosys' Cyber Defense Center working with the government for security audits.
- **Promote Cybersecurity Awareness and Education:** Integrate cybersecurity education into school and college curricula. **Example**: *Cyber Surakshit Bharat Initiative* promotes awareness among CISOs in government departments.
- **Focus on Indigenous Technology Development:** Encourage domestic R&D in cybersecurity tools and software to reduce dependency on foreign tech. **Example**: DRDO's work on secure communication systems for defense networks.
- **Regular Cyber Drills and Simulations:** Conduct frequent cyber readiness exercises. **Example**: *Cyber Shockwave 2023* led by CERT-In for critical sectors like energy and banking.

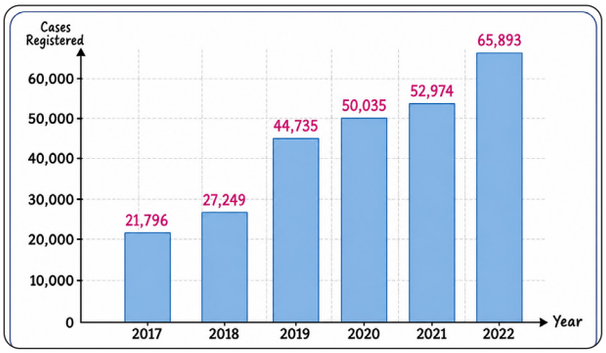


Fig. 4.4: Total Cyber Crime during 2017-2022 (NCRB)

BLOCKCHAIN TECHNOLOGY AND GOVERNANCE

Blockchain technology has garnered significant attention from the Government of India, which recognizes its potential to revolutionise public sector operations. The release of the "National Strategy on Blockchain" by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) underscores the government's commitment to integrating blockchain across various sectors, including healthcare, agriculture, finance, voting, and e-governance.

Government Initiatives and Applications

- **Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC):** The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is developing its own CBDC, the digital rupee, to modernise payment systems and reduce reliance on physical cash. CBDC implementation will enhance payment efficiency and mitigate risks associated with private cryptocurrencies.
- **Land Registration and Digital Certificates:** Blockchain technology is being deployed for land registration, issuance of digital certificates, and customs duty payment, streamlining administrative processes and enhancing transparency.

Example: Telangana and Maharashtra have piloted blockchain-based land record systems to reduce property fraud and enhance transparency.

- *Similarly,* CBSE uses blockchain to issue tamper-proof digital academic certificates via DigiLocker, ensuring authenticity.

- **Sectoral Adoption:** Regulatory bodies like the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) are exploring blockchain applications in telecommunications and financial markets, respectively.

Case Studies and Examples

- **NFTs for Land Mutation in West Bengal:** The New Town Kolkata Development Authority has implemented NFTs for land mutation, ensuring transparent land ownership records and eliminating manual paperwork. Municipal corporations in Durgapur and Bankura districts have adopted blockchain for issuing birth certificates.
- **Tamil Nadu Blockchain Backbone:** The initiative aims to provide citizens with a unique state ID consolidating essential documents into a digital wallet. The e-Pettagam App allows secure sharing of documents with various entities.
- **Unified Land Management System in Karnataka:** Similar to Tamil Nadu's initiative, Karnataka aims to streamline land records management through a unified digital system.
- **Firozabad Public Grievance Management System**: The Uttar Pradesh Government, in collaboration with Polygon, has launched an online portal for filing and tracking complaints using blockchain technology, ensuring transparency and integrity of records.

Challenges of Blockchain in Governance

- **Scalability & Energy Consumption**: High computational power requirements and slow transaction speeds hinder large-scale government adoption.
- **Regulatory & Legal Uncertainty**: Lack of clear legal frameworks for blockchain-based records can lead to disputes and poor enforceability.
- **Data Privacy Concerns**: Public blockchains may expose sensitive citizen data unless strong encryption and privacy layers are applied.

Way Forward for Blockchain in Governance

- **Develop Clear Regulatory Frameworks**: Enact laws defining legal validity of blockchain records—like **Estonia**, which has integrated blockchain into national ID and health records with strong legal backing.
- **Adopt Permissioned Blockchains**: Use private/permissioned blockchains (e.g., **India's NIC e-Office platform**) to ensure better control, scalability, and privacy for government use.
- **Invest in Capacity Building**: Train officials and create sandbox environments—like **Dubai's Blockchain Strategy**, which includes pilot projects and public sector training.

Fourth Industrial Revolution: Shaping e-Governance **(UPSC 2020)**

The Fourth Industrial Revolution, driven by **AI and IoT, is reshaping governance**. Digital India has advanced e-Governance, making it vital for transparent, efficient service delivery amid India's rising digital population.

Emergence of the Fourth Industrial Revolution (Digital Revolution)

- **Advanced Technologies Rise:** NASSCOM projects digital tech to comprise 40% of manufacturing spending by 2025, doubling from 20% in 2021.
- **Data-Driven Decision Making:** Increasing reliance on **big data analytics** to formulate **informed policies** and improve efficiency. **Eg:** The **Aadhaar-based DBT** ensures **reduced leakages** and **targeted welfare distribution**.
- **Digital Economy Expansion:** The rise of **e-commerce** and **digital payments** has transformed **global trade** and **finance**, making transactions more efficient. **Eg: UPI** processed **₹23.49 lakh crore** across **16.58 billion transactions** in October 2024 (RBI).
- **AI-Led Public Services:** The use of **AI-driven platforms** is enhancing **public governance, healthcare,** and **education services**, making them more efficient and accessible. **Eg: Aarogya Setu** tracked COVID-19 cases, aiding pandemic management and response.

GOVERNANCE AND AI

Governance and Artificial Intelligence (AI) refer to the integration of emerging technologies into administrative processes and decision-making systems. This intersection explores how AI can be structured, regulated, and aligned with democratic principles in public governance.

Role and Potential of AI in Governance

- **Efficient Service Delivery**: AI helps automate government services, reducing workload and improving quality.
- **Education**: Enables smart content and personalized learning. Example: NCERT tagging metadata in NROER resources.
- **Healthcare**: Improves diagnostics and reach through AI-driven telemedicine. Example: Cancer image database by NITI Aayog and DBT.
- **Agriculture**: AI offers predictive insights for pest control and weather. Example: National Pest Surveillance System.
- **Inclusivity**: AI bridges language gaps. Example: Bhashini provides services in regional languages.

Challenges in AI-Driven Governance

- **Fragmented Data**: National Data Governance Framework Policy is pending implementation.
- **Infrastructure Gaps**: 45% of Indians lack internet access (IAMAI 2023), especially in rural areas.
- **No AI-Specific Laws**: Unlike the EU's AI Act, India lacks a dedicated legal framework.
- **Skill Gap**: Shortage of 1.4 lakh AI professionals (NASSCOM).
- **Privacy Concerns**: AI's data reliance can lead to leaks. Example: Aadhaar data leak affected 81.5 crore people.

Way Forward

- **Ethical Oversight**: Regular risk assessments, fairness metrics, and human supervision.
- **Data Sovereignty**: Enforce DPDP Act, especially for cross-border data flows.
- **Transparency**: Audits, model cards, and use of diverse datasets.
- **Skill Development**: Expand AI education in underserved regions.
- **Public-Private Collaboration**: Build AI infrastructure (e.g., 10,000+ GPUs under IndiaAI).

National AI Initiatives

- **IndiaAI Mission**: It aimed at developing AI infrastructure, including 10,000 GPUs, to support AI startups and public sector applications.
- **BharatGen:** A government-funded project to develop a multilingual, multimodal AI model tailored to India's linguistic diversity, reducing reliance on foreign AI models.
- **Digital India Bhashini (National Language Translation Mission):** An AI-powered platform facilitating real-time translation across Indian languages, enhancing digital inclusion and communication.
- **AI Governance Guidelines (By MeitY):** It Adopts a "hands-off" regulatory approach, focusing on responsible innovation rather than strict control. Its Core Objective is to promote safe, trusted, and inclusive AI ("AI for All"), balancing innovation with accountability, ethics, and safety.

AI in Governance

- **India Urban Data Exchange (IUDX):** A platform enabling data sharing among urban stakeholders to improve city governance and service delivery.
- **Ideal Train Profile:** An AI-driven system by Indian Railways to optimize train occupancy and revenue by analyzing passenger demand patterns.
- **Crime Detection & Surveillance:** AI tools like facial recognition and smart CCTV enable identification of suspects, crowd monitoring, and detection of suspicious behaviour, traffic violations, and accidents.
- **Predictive & Judicial Support:** AI uses data analytics for crime prediction, financial fraud detection, and assists in pre-trial risk assessment, parole decisions, and high-risk operations through robotics.
- **Arunachal Pradesh**: Implemented a Generative AI system to analyze Monthly Development Reports from 67 departments, enhancing administrative decision-making.

DEEPFAKE REGULATION IN INDIA

Deepfakes are digital media — video, audio, and images edited and manipulated using technologies such as AI and machine learning, thereby blurring the lines between fiction and reality.

Existing Legal Framework

- India lacks specific laws governing deepfake technology.
- Sections 67 and 67A of the Information Technology Act (2000) are applied for defamation and explicit material.
- India's IT Rules, 2021 mandate the takedown of reported deepfake content within 36 hours.
- Sections 66C (identity theft) and 66E (privacy violation) of the IT Act, 2000 are also applicable.
- Section 500 of IPC provides punishment for defamation, while Section 292 addresses obscene content, and Sections 465 and 469 deal with forgery and harming reputation.

Impact of Deepfake on Governance in India

1. **Electoral Misinformation:** Fake videos distort political narratives and mislead voters.
2. **National Security Risk:** Deepfakes of officials can trigger panic and harm diplomacy.

3. **Trust Deficit:** Undermines credibility of media and government communication.
4. **Cybercrime Threat:** Enables fraud through impersonation of leaders and officials.
5. **Regulatory Gap:** Weak detection and legal frameworks hinder effective control.

Government Advisory on Deepfake Regulation 2023

1. **Directive to Intermediaries**: MeitY issued an advisory urging compliance with IT rules to combat AI-driven misinformation, including deepfakes.
2. **Prohibited Content Communication**: Intermediaries must clearly inform users about prohibited content and its legal consequences.
3. **Enforcement of IT Rules**: Intermediaries must swiftly remove prohibited content as per Rule 3(1)(b) of the IT Rules.
4. **Stakeholder Engagement**: Minister Rajeev Chandrasekhar held meetings to address deepfake concerns, stressing adherence to laws.
5. **Future Measures**: MeitY will monitor compliance and may amend rules to enhance internet safety.

OVER THE TOP PLATFORMS

Over-the-Top (OTT) platforms like Netflix and Amazon Prime have revolutionized content consumption by delivering on-demand audio and video via the internet, bypassing traditional media.

Need of Regulations

- **Rapid growth:** OTT platforms have grown rapidly in recent years, **e.g.** by the end of 2022, India's OTT base grew 20% to 424 million people from 353 million people in 2021.
- **Obscenity:** The language and content on some of the OTT platforms promote obscenity, representing a danger to the social and moral upsides of our country.
- **Lack of censorship:** There is lack of censorship and therefore, people of all ages, particularly children are exposed to all kinds of content that might not be suitable to their age.
- **Threat of cybercrime:** There are threats of cybercrime with OTT platforms, where people share their confidential information like bank details, credit card etc.

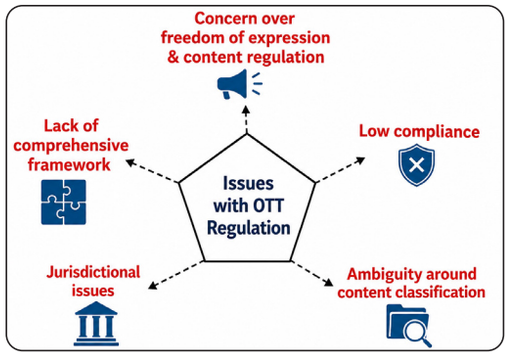


Fig. 4.5: Issues with OTT Regulation

Digital Media Ethics Code

Government has notified Digital Media Ethics Code that provide for:

- **Content Classification:** OTT platforms must classify content as U, U/A 7+, U/A 13+, U/A 16+, A; enable parental locks (U/A 13+) and age verification (A).
- **Norm Compliance:** Digital news publishers must follow Press Council norms and Cable TV Programme Code—ensuring parity with print/TV media.
- **3-Level Grievance Redressal:**
  - **Level I:** Self-regulation by publisher's internal grievance officer.
  - **Level II:** Self-regulatory body led by retired judges/eminent persons (max 6 members).
  - **Level III:** Govt. oversight via Inter-Departmental Committee and Code of Practice by MoI&B.

Key Words

Cyber Inclusion, Knowledge Bubble, Online Traces, Data Accessibility, Environmentally Friendly, Paper-Free Office, Digital Sovereignty, Digital Democracy, Tech-Driven Transformation, Virtual Empowerment, Digital Renaissance, eGovernance Renaissance, Tech-Enriched Administration, Digital Inclusivity, eGovernance Upliftment, Digital Outreach, Digital Emancipation

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	e-governance projects have a built-in bias towards technology and back-end integration than user-centric designs.	2025
2.	E-governance is not just about the routine application of digital technology in the service delivery process. It is as much about multifarious interactions for ensuring transparency and accountability. In this context evaluate the role of the 'Interactive Service Model' of e-governance.	2024
3.	What inadequacies hinder the enhancement of effectiveness, transparency, and accountability in e-governance?	2023
4.	How has the emergence of the Fourth Industrial Revolution initiated e-Governance as an integral part of government?	2020
5.	Identify factors hindering the implementation of ICT-based projects/programs and suggest measures for effective implementation.	2019
6.	Explain the critical importance of the 'use value' of information in e-Governance, beyond just the utilization of new technology.	2018

5 Social and Economic Governance

Socio-economic governance refers to the management of a nation's social and economic resources and institutions transparently, accountably, and equitably to promote sustainable development and welfare. It is vital for inclusive growth, social justice, and effective public service delivery to bridge developmental gaps and achieve constitutional ideals.

Quotes

- *"For any nation to prosper, we must prioritize policies that address both economic and social inequalities."*
- *"The care of human life and happiness, and not their destruction, is the first and only object of good government." - John Adams*

SOCIAL GOVERNANCE IN INDIA

Social Governance refers to the system through which government, private sector, and civil society work together to manage social issues and improve people's well-being. Key features of social governance as follows:

- **Welfare Schemes and Social Security:** Covers government programs like MGNREGA, PM-KISAN, Ayushman Bharat, and PM Awas Yojana that aim to improve livelihoods and provide a safety net for the vulnerable sections.
- **Education and Health Governance:** Includes policies like the National Education Policy 2020, Right to Education Act, and schemes like Mid-Day Meal and Ayushman Bharat, aiming for universal access to quality education and healthcare.
- **Gender and Child Welfare:** Government programs like Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, POSHAN Abhiyaan, and protection laws aim to enhance the status of women and children.
- **Marginalized Communities and Inclusive Development:** Focus on SCs, STs, OBCs, minorities, and PwDs through schemes like Stand-Up India, Pre-Matric/Post-Matric Scholarships, and targeted legal provisions.

ECONOMIC GOVERNANCE IN INDIA

Economic Governance refers to the institutional frameworks, policies, rules, and processes used by governments and other authorities to manage a country's economic affairs. Few features of social governance as as follows:



Fig. 5.1: Pillars of Economics Governance

- **Fiscal Policy and Public Finance**: Involves how the government manages its income (mainly through taxes) and expenditure. Tools like the Union Budget, fiscal deficit targets, and subsidies fall under this. Fiscal discipline is crucial for macroeconomic stability.
- **Monetary Policy and Inflation Control:** Handled by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), monetary policy aims at controlling inflation and ensuring liquidity in the economy through instruments like repo rate, reverse repo rate, and CRR.
- **Public Sector Enterprises and Disinvestment:** Public sector undertakings (PSUs) are vital for strategic sectors. However, disinvestment or privatization is pursued to reduce the fiscal burden and promote efficiency.
- **Ease of Doing Business and Regulatory Reforms:** Initiatives like single-window clearances, GST, IBC (Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code), and the removal of outdated laws have improved India's investment climate.

INSTRUMENTS OF SOCIO-ECONOMIC GOVERNANCE

Socio-economic governance in India is supported by a combination of legal frameworks, policies, and robust institutional mechanisms. These instruments ensure effective delivery of welfare, promote transparency, and foster inclusive growth.

Key Instruments Include

Laws and Policies

1. **Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025:** It replaces MGNREGA. This revamped legislation increases guaranteed work from 100 to 125 days per household, aims to create durable infrastructure, and uses a supply-driven approach to focus on rural development.
2. **NFSA (National Food Security Act):** NFSA aims to provide subsidized food grains to approximately two-thirds of India's population, ensuring food security and nutritional support to vulnerable groups.
3. **NEP 2020 (National Education Policy 2020):** NEP 2020 is a transformative policy that overhauls India's education system. It promotes holistic, multidisciplinary education, integration of vocational skills, technology-enabled learning, and flexible curricula.
4. **DBT (Direct Benefit Transfer):** DBT is a technology-enabled system that transfers subsidies and welfare payments directly into beneficiaries' bank accounts. This reduces leakages, curbs corruption, and ensures that government benefits reach the intended recipients efficiently.

Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) [VB-GRAM G] Act, 2025

- **Objective:** Seeks to enhance rural employment and livelihood security, building on existing schemes like MGNREGA.
- **Employment Focus:** Aims to provide expanded wage and livelihood opportunities beyond traditional manual work.
- **Skill & Livelihood Integration:** Promotes skill development, self-employment, and rural enterprise creation.
- **Target Group:** Focuses on rural poor, youth, women, and vulnerable households.
- **Convergence Approach:** Integrates multiple schemes for holistic rural development and income generation.
- **Digital Monitoring:** Emphasises technology-based tracking and transparency in implementation.
- **Outcome Goal:** Supports the vision of Viksit Bharat through inclusive and sustainable rural growth.

Institutional Mechanisms

1. **NITI Aayog:** As India's premier policy think-tank, NITI Aayog fosters cooperative federalism by involving states in policy-making.
2. **Finance Commission:** A constitutional body that recommends the distribution of tax revenues between the central and state governments, ensuring fiscal devolution and balanced regional development.
3. **Lokpal and Central Vigilance Commission (CVC):** These are anti-corruption institutions. The Lokpal investigates complaints against public functionaries, while the CVC oversees vigilance administration and integrity in government operations, promoting accountability and ethical governance.
4. **RTI (Right to Information) and CPGRAMS (Centralized Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System):** RTI empowers citizens to seek information from public authorities, fostering transparency. CPGRAMS is an online platform for citizens to lodge grievances and track their resolution, ensuring responsive governance and public accountability.

Competition Commission of India: Role in strengthening Economic Governance **(UPSC 2023)**

Competition Commission of India (CCI) plays a vital role in economic governance by ensuring fair competition and preventing market distortions caused by monopolistic practices. It fosters transparency, efficiency, and consumer welfare through regulatory oversight and policy advisories. By curbing anti-competitive behavior, the CCI supports a level playing field essential for inclusive and sustainable economic growth.

- **Market Studies:** CCI conducts studies to assess market conditions and design regulations accordingly. **Eg:** It examined India's e-commerce sector to identify competition concerns.
- **Capacity Building:** CCI collaborates with global competition bodies to enhance expertise. **Eg:** It partners with the U.S. Federal Trade Commission for training workshops.
- **Consumer Welfare:** CCI takes action against unfair practices to protect consumers. **Eg:** It penalized cement companies for cartelization that led to inflated prices.
- **Dispute Resolution:** CCI intervenes in business disputes to ensure fair competition. **Eg:** It resolved conflicts related to film releases and unfair cinema hall practices.
- **Collaboration with Other Agencies:** CCI partners with global institutions to combat anti-competitive practices effectively. **Eg:** It collaborates with the European Commission to share best practices.

Key Constitutional Provisions Regarding Socio-Economic Governance

- The Indian Constitution embeds socio-economic governance primarily through the Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSPs), which are found in Articles 36 to 51 in Part IV of the Constitution.

Major Articles and their Socio-Economic Focus	
Article 38	Promotion of welfare of the people by securing a just social order and minimizing inequalities
Article 39	Securing adequate means of livelihood, equitable distribution of resources, prevention of wealth concentration, equal pay for equal work, protection of children and workers
Article 39A	Promotion of equal justice and provision of free legal aid to the poor
Article 41	Right to work, education, and public assistance in cases of unemployment, old age, sickness, and disablement
Article 42	Just and humane conditions of work and maternity relief
Article 43	Living wage and decent standard of life for all workers
Article 43A	Participation of workers in management of industries
Article 47	Raising the level of nutrition, standard of living, and improvement of public health

- **Article 244 (Fifth Schedule):** Empowers the Governor to regulate administration and control of Scheduled and Tribal Areas, focusing on the socio-economic development of marginalized communities.
- **Article 31-C (25th Amendment):** Provides that laws made to implement certain socio-economic principles (like those in Articles 39(b) and 39(c)) cannot be challenged on the grounds of violating fundamental rights, reinforcing the primacy of socio-economic governance.
- **In fundamental rights:**

Article	Provision	Socio-Economic Relevance
Article 15	Prohibits discrimination on grounds of religion, race, caste, sex, or place of birth.	Enables affirmative action and special provisions for socially and educationally backward classes.
Article 16	Equality of opportunity in public employment.	Mandates fair access to government jobs, promoting socio-economic mobility.
Article 17	Abolition of untouchability.	Supports social inclusion and equality, crucial for marginalized communities.

SIGNIFICANCE OF SOCIO-ECONOMIC GOVERNANCE

- **Inclusive Development:** It improves education, income, and employment, ensuring benefits reach all sections. Eg: Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan improved PTR and GER.
- **Poverty Reduction:** It implements welfare policies to reduce inequality and enhance social security. Eg: Ayushman Bharat reduced out-of-pocket expenditure.
- **Institutional Strength:** It enhances service delivery and crisis response capacity, ensuring stability. Eg: COVID-19 response through health infrastructure and policy measures.
- **Accountability & Transparency:** It promotes checks and reduces corruption, improving public trust. Eg: CVC and Lokpal mechanisms.
- **Participatory Governance:** It involves government, private sector, and civil society in decision-making.
- **Resource Optimization:** It ensures efficient allocation of resources for maximum public benefit. Eg: Smart Cities Mission.
- **Policy Effectiveness:** It supports formulation, implementation, and monitoring of development policies.

Balancing Equity and Efficiency: Socio-Economic Governance through Welfare Schemes (UPSC 2023)

Development and **welfare schemes** are essential tools to bring about socio-economic development and uplift the **underprivileged sections** of society. Though implemented with good intentions, such schemes may be seen as discriminatory by some, yet remain essential for **bridging existing social** and **economic gaps**.

Arguments Highlighting Discrimination

- **Focused Approach:** Policies in education and jobs face criticism for allegedly **diluting meritocracy**.
- **Resource Allocation:** Schemes like **MGNREGA** benefit rural areas, potentially neglecting the **urban poor** who lack similar employment support. **Eg:** Urban employment schemes remain limited compared to **rural-focused programs** like **MGNREGA**.

- **Potential for Misuse:** The PDS system, aimed at supporting the poor, faces corruption and leakages, diverting resources away from **intended beneficiaries**. **Eg:** Reports indicate PDS grains being illegally sold in open markets.
- **Creation of Dependency:** Free electricity and water for farmers may encourage reliance on subsidies rather than promoting **sustainable resource usage**. **Eg: Continuous subsidies** have led to **excessive groundwater depletion** in states like Punjab.
- **Geographical Disparities:** Programs like **PM-DevINE** focus on specific regions, leading to perceptions of neglect in other areas lacking similar attention.

Counter-arguments: Need for Targeted Welfare Schemes

- **Social Justice:** These schemes **bridge socio-economic gaps** and empower marginalized groups. **Eg: Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao** promotes girls' education and gender equality.
- **Economic Equity:** Ensures financial inclusion for the disadvantaged. **Eg: Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana** has expanded banking access for millions.
- **Health and Well-being:** Aims to provide healthcare to vulnerable populations. **Eg: Ayushman Bharat** offers free health insurance to low-income families.
- **Educational Equity:** Promotes access to education and nutrition. **Eg: Mid-Day Meal Scheme** improves school attendance and fights malnutrition.

Going forward, addressing concerns of **discrimination** while recognizing the **need for targeted interventions** is key. A collaborative, tech-driven, and transparent approach can ensure **inclusive** and **sustainable development**.

Challenges of Socio-Economic Governance

- **Fiscal Constraints:** It limits funding for social and economic programmes due to competing budgetary demands.
- **Infrastructure Deficit:** It hampers service delivery due to weak transport, energy, and communication systems.
- **Regional Inequality:** It creates uneven development and exclusion of marginalised groups.
- **Persistent Poverty:** It restricts access to basic services and weakens policy outcomes.
- **Bureaucratic Delays:** It slows implementation due to complex procedures and red tape.
- **Corruption:** It leads to resource leakages and reduces trust in governance.
- **Weak Accountability:** It undermines transparency and governance effectiveness.
- **Institutional Weakness:** It limits enforcement and oversight capacity of institutions.

How Digital Illiteracy and ICT Inaccessibility Hinder Socio-Economic Development **(UPSC 2021)**

- **Limited Access to Government Services:** Digital illiteracy in rural areas prevents many citizens from accessing vital government schemes and direct benefit transfers. **Eg:** A CIS report highlights **e-KYC** and **document** upload issues, delaying **PDS access** and worsening food insecurity.
- **Educational Barriers:** A lack of digital skills and reliable ICT infrastructure hinders access to e-learning platforms, widening the educational divide. **Eg:** The Annual Status of Education Report **(ASER)** 2022 states that only **32%** of rural students had access to online learning during **COVID-19.**
- **Financial Exclusion:** Inadequate access to ICT restricts rural residents from utilizing digital banking and financial services, which are crucial for economic inclusion. **Eg:** RBI's 2023 Digital Payment Index shows that **over 40% of rural users** lack awareness of digital payments.
- **Healthcare Access Limitations:** The absence of robust digital infrastructure limits the reach of telemedicine and e-health services, affecting timely healthcare delivery. **Eg:** The National Health Mission (NHM) 2023 highlights that **60% of rural areas** lack access to teleconsultation.

Strategies for Bridging the Gap

- **Expanding Digital Literacy:** Strengthen programs like **PMGDISHA** to enhance digital skills in remote areas.
- **Boosting ICT Infrastructure:** Scale up initiatives like **BharatNet** for reliable rural broadband access.
- **Public-Private Partnerships:** Collaborate with telecom firms to roll out affordable digital solutions.



Grievance Redressal Assessment and Index (GRAI)

- It was conceived and developed by the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG), Government of India, following recommendations from the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Personnel, Public Grievances, and Pensions.
- **Objective**: The initiative aims to provide a comparative assessment of organizations and offer key insights into their strengths and areas needing improvement in grievance redressal mechanisms.

Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 **(UPSC 2024)**

- **Preserve Academic Integrity**: To safeguard the sanctity of examination processes, deterring practices that compromise the **fairness** and **credibility** of exams. **Eg:** All offences under this Act, shall be **cognizable**, **non-bailable** and **non-compoundable**.
- **Standardise Examination Protocols**: The Act seeks to establish **uniform guidelines** and **procedures** for conducting examinations, ensuring **consistency** across various educational institutions.
- **Legal Framework for Action:** It provides a legal basis to penalise the use of unfair means, with punishments ranging from fines to imprisonment. **Eg:** An officer not below the rank of **DSP** or **ACP** shall investigate any offence under this Act.
- **Promote level playing field:** The Act enforces stringent measures against cheating, ensuring that all candidates are evaluated fairly and on a **level playing field**. **Eg:** Provisions for **random invigilation** and **spot checks** create a transparent and fair examination environment.
- **Empower Authorities**: The Act empowers examination boards and universities to take **decisive actions** against offenders and enforce preventive measures. **Eg:** Any person or persons resorting to unfair means face at least **three years' imprisonment** and a fine up to **₹10 lakh**.

GOVERNMENT INITIATIVES IN DIFFERENT SECTORS

Health and Nutrition

- **National Health Mission (NHM):**to provide universal access to equitable, affordable, and quality healthcare services. It focuses on strengthening health systems, improving maternal and child health, and controlling communicable and non-communicable diseases.
- **Janani Suraksha Yojana:** promoting institutional deliveries among poor pregnant women. It provides cash incentives-₹1,400 for rural and ₹1,000 for urban institutional deliveries-to eligible women.
- **National Nutrition Mission (POSHAN Abhiyaan)**:POSHAN 2.0 aims to transform the nutrition status of children aged 0 to 6 years, pregnant women and lactating mothers across India.
- **National Digital Health Mission:** Digitizes health records to improve healthcare delivery.

Knowledge Nuggets

National Health Claims Exchange (NHCX)

- NHCX is a digital platform in India designed to streamline and standardize health insurance claim processing.
- It aims to improve efficiency, transparency, and the patient experience by facilitating the exchange of claim information among various stakeholders in the healthcare ecosystem

Education and Skill Development

- **Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan:** Integrates school education from pre-school to class 12. It integrates three previous schemes: SSA(Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan), RMSA (Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan), and Teacher Education (TE). It aims to ensure inclusive and equitable quality education from preschool to senior secondary levels. The program focuses on digital education, vocational training, and teacher training.
- **New Skilling Programme in 2024:** 20 lakh youth will be skilled over a period of 5 years and 1,000 Industrial Training Institutes will be upgraded in hub and spoke arrangements with outcome orientation.
- **Comprehensive scheme for Internship Opportunities:** To provide internship opportunities to 1 crore youth in 5 years in the top 500 companies. The students will gain exposure for 12 months to a real-life business environment and varied professions and employment opportunities. An internship allowance of Rs.5,000 per month and a one-time assistance of Rs.6,000 will be provided.
- **Skill Loan Scheme:** The government will revise the Model Skill Loan Scheme to facilitate loans up to Rs.7.5 lakh with a guarantee from a government-promoted Fund. It is expected to help 25,000 students every year.

Social Welfare and Inclusion

- **National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP):** Provides pensions to the elderly, widows, and disabled.
- **Stand-Up India:** Facilitates loans to women and marginalized communities for entrepreneurship.
- **Adivasi Shiksha Rinn Yojana:** Soft loans for tribal students to pursue higher education

- **Pradhan Mantri Shram Yogi Maandhan (PM-SYM):** It is a voluntary pension scheme for unorganised sector workers aged 18–40 years with monthly income up to ₹15,000. It assures a minimum monthly pension of ₹3,000 after the age of 60, with the government matching the worker's contribution on a 1:1 basis.
- **Pradhan Mantri Janjatiya Unnat Gram Abhiyan**, a new scheme to improve the socio-economic condition of tribal communities. This scheme will be implemented by adopting saturation coverage for tribal families in aspirational districts and tribal-majority villages. It will cover 63,000 villages benefitting 5 crore tribal people.

Agriculture and Allied Sectors

- **PM Fasal Bima Yojana:** The scheme offers comprehensive insurance coverage at affordable premium rates-2% for food crops and 5% for commercial and horticultural crops-making it accessible even to small and marginal farmers.
- **Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-KISAN):** provides financial support of ₹6,000 per year in three equal installments to all landholding farmer families across India, directly into their bank accounts.
- **Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (RKVY):** Supports agricultural development and infrastructure.
- **Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana:** It focuses on increasing fish production, modernizing infrastructure, and doubling fishers' incomes, with a total investment of ₹20,050 crore over five years.

Rural Development

- **Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission Gramin (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025:** It aims to improve rural infrastructure and climate resilience, increasing the guaranteed wage employment from 100 days to at least 125 days per household.
- **Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana – Gramin (PMAY-G):** Provides affordable housing to the rural poor.
- **Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY):** Focuses on rural road connectivity, improving access to markets, health, and education.
- **Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Grameen Kaushalya Yojana (DDU-GKY):** Offers skill development and employment opportunities to rural youth

Urban Development

- **Smart Cities Mission:** launched in 2015, aims to enhance the quality of life in 100 selected cities by providing efficient services, robust infrastructure, and a sustainable environment through technology-driven solutions and citizen participation.
- **Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT):** Focuses on water supply, sewerage, and urban transport.
- **Pooled Finance Development Fund Scheme:** Enables urban local bodies to raise funds for infrastructure.

Financial Inclusion

- **Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY):** A flagship initiative to provide universal access to banking facilities, encourage savings, and enable direct benefit transfers, especially for the unbanked population.
- **Digital Payment Infrastructure:** Platforms like UPI, RuPay, and FASTag promote digital transactions, enhancing transparency and reducing reliance on cash.



Ralegan Siddhi Transformation, Maharashtra
In the 1970s, Ralegan Siddhi was a drought-prone, impoverished village with barren land and widespread poverty. Led by Anna Hazare, the community initiated watershed development, water harvesting, and afforestation with strong local participation. This intervention improved groundwater levels, enabling multi-cropping and increased agricultural productivity.

Kerala's decentralized planning, launched with the People's Plan Campaign in 1996, empowered local governments by devolving significant funds and decision-making authority to them, making planning participatory and inclusive.

Suggestions and Way Forward

- **Zero Poverty:** Aims for poverty elimination and universal access to education, healthcare, and skills under Viksit Bharat vision.
- **Women Participation:** Promotes higher workforce participation and gender equity in economic activities.
- **Targeted Welfare:** Strengthens schemes for marginalized groups with focus on last-mile delivery.

- **Local Empowerment:** Decentralises governance by strengthening Panchayats and Urban Local Bodies.
- **Cooperative Federalism:** Enhances Centre–State coordination through platforms like NITI Aayog.
- **Digital Governance:** Expands e-governance, DBT, and grievance systems to improve efficiency and reduce leakages.
- **Regulatory Reforms:** Simplifies laws, removes outdated provisions, and improves ease of doing business.
- **Project Efficiency:** Improves public procurement and project management to reduce delays and costs.
- **Credit Access:** Enhances financial access for MSMEs and startups to boost innovation and jobs.
- **PPP Promotion:** Encourages public-private partnerships for infrastructure and service delivery.

AFFIRMATIVE ACTION IN INDIA

Affirmative action in India aims to promote social justice and empower marginalized communities, including Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), Other Backward Classes (OBCs), and Economically Weaker Sections (EWS).

Key Affirmative Action Measures

- **Reservations in Education and Employment:** Constitutional provisions (Articles 15(4), 16(4), 16(6)) ensure quotas for SCs, STs, OBCs, and EWS in educational institutions and government jobs, enhancing representation and access to opportunities.
- **Political Representation:** Reserved seats for SCs,STs and women in Parliament, state legislatures, and local bodies guarantee their participation in governance and decision-making.
- **Legal Safeguards:** Laws like the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act protect marginalized groups from discrimination and exploitation.
- **Targeted Welfare Schemes:** Special scholarships, hostels, and economic development programs support the educational and economic advancement of disadvantaged communities.

Significance of Affirmative Actions

- **Promotes Social Justice:** Addresses historical injustices and fosters a more equitable society by creating opportunities for marginalized groups.
- **Enhances Diversity and Inclusion:** Ensures representation in education, employment, and governance, enriching institutions with diverse perspectives.
- **Economic Empowerment:** Improves access to education and jobs for disadvantaged communities, reducing poverty and inequality.
- **Boosts Political Participation:** Reserved seats guarantee marginalized groups a voice in policymaking and governance.
- **Reduces Discrimination:** Legal safeguards protect against exploitation and discrimination, promoting fairness.
- **Enables Socio-Economic Mobility:** Opens pathways for upward mobility, helping individuals improve their socio-economic status.

Judgments on Affirmative Actions in India

- **The Indra Sawhney (Mandal Commission) case (1992)** upheld 27% reservation for OBCs in central government jobs, recognizing caste as a valid criterion for social and educational backwardness. The Supreme Court introduced the "creamy layer" concept to exclude affluent OBCs from reservation benefits and set a 50% cap on total reservations.
- **The Supreme Court in Janhit Abhiyan v. Union of India (2022)** upheld the constitutional validity of the 103rd Amendment, allowing 10% reservation for Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) in education and public employment, even if it exceeds the 50% reservation cap.
- **State of Punjab v. Davinder Singh (2020):** Permitted sub-classification within SC and ST categories, allowing states to identify and prioritize the most marginalized among them
- **Jarnail Singh v. Lachhmi Narain Gupta (2018):** Clarified that states need not prove backwardness for SC/ST promotions, but must provide quantifiable data on inadequate representation.
- **Reservation in Local Bodies (2021):** The Supreme Court laid down a three-step protocol for states to provide OBC reservation in local bodies: appoint a commission, gather empirical data, and ensure the 50% ceiling is not breached.

The Rohini Commission on sub-categorisation of OBCs

It found that a small number of OBC caste groups were disproportionately benefiting from reservations, with 25% of OBC sub-castes availing 97% of reserved jobs and educational seats, while 37% of OBC communities had zero representation. Its findings highlight the need for sub-categorization to ensure equitable distribution of benefits among all OBCs and provide, for the first time, detailed data on the socio-economic status of these communities.

US Supreme Court Strikes Down Race-Based College Admissions

On June 29, 2023, the US Supreme Court ruled that race-based admissions at Harvard College and the University of North Carolina were unconstitutional, violating the Equal Protection Clause of the Fourteenth Amendment.

Challenges of Affirmative Actions

- **Perception of Unfairness:** Seen by some as reverse discrimination, leading to debates about fairness.
- **Stigmatization:** Beneficiaries may face prejudice, with achievements attributed to quotas rather than merit.
- **Resistance and Backlash:** Political and social opposition can result in legal challenges and slow progress.
- **Resource Constraints:** Limited resources may reduce the effectiveness and reach of these programs.
- **Measuring Impact:** Assessing long-term outcomes and effectiveness is often challenging.
- **Administrative Complexity:** Managing these policies requires significant coordination and oversight.
- **Balancing Merit and Equity:** Maintaining fairness while promoting equity remains a persistent issue.

Way Forward and Suggestions

- **Strengthen implementation and monitoring** through robust oversight, regular evaluation, and data-driven adjustments to ensure benefits reach intended groups.
- **Broaden the scope** by including income-based and intersectional criteria (such as gender, disability, and region) to address multiple layers of disadvantage.
- **Enhance public awareness and capacity-building programs** to empower beneficiaries and reduce stigma.
- **Involve stakeholders in policymaking**, regularly update policies, and foster consensus to address resistance and ensure legal protection.
- **Balance merit and equity** by designing inclusive, merit-based policies and introducing mentorship and support initiatives.

GOVERNANCE OF SPORTS IN INDIA

Sports governance refers to **the system by which the sports organizations are governed** in the country. It includes the process of oversight and the directions based on which decisions are made and implemented in a sports organization.

Need of Sports Governance

- **Administrative issues:**
  - **Unclear roles and responsibilities:** Multiple organizations at national, state and district levels lead to issues of confusion, duplication of services and gaps in sports administration.
  - **Harassment charges:** The people at senior and powerful positions in sports organisations face charges of sexual harassment, **e.g.** recent protest of wrestlers.
  - **Lack of professionalism:** There are issues of fiefdom, factionalism, nepotism, and irregular elections because of the stronghold of politicians, bureaucrats and businesspersons over sports.
  - **Unethical practices:** Doping undermines fair competition and sports integrity. Eg: 2018 Commonwealth Games – Sanjita Chanu tested positive for a banned substance.
- **Financial issues:**
  - **Limited funds:** The size of the sports industry in India is around $100 billion in the last 5 years, but the majority of it is concentrated around cricket and other sports do not receive sufficient funds.
  - **Limited central government funding:** Sports is a state subject under entry 33 of state list and therefore there is limited funding from the central government.
  - **Cooperation and Coordination issues:**

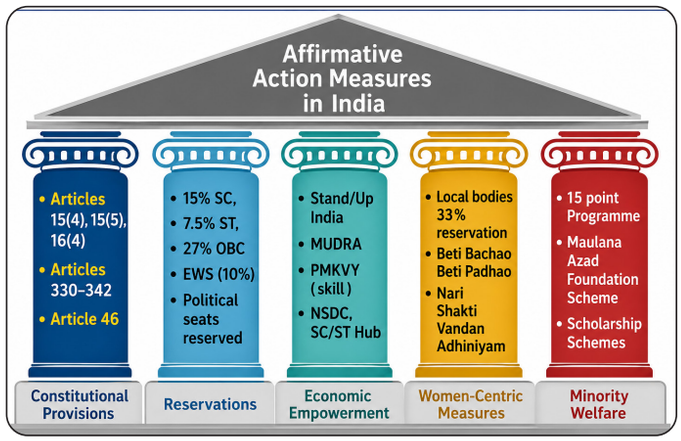


Fig. 5.3: Affirmative Action Measures in India

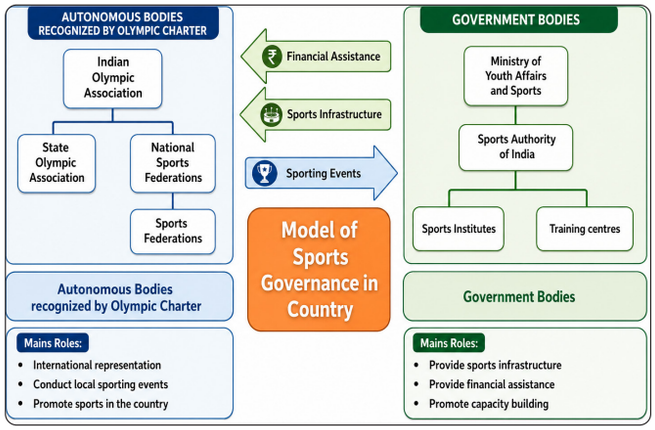


Fig. 5.4: Model of Sports Governance in India

- **Governance structure:** Except for some sports such as cricket, hockey etc. there is lack of clear and functional sports architecture in the country, e.g. **Ban on AIFF by FIFA due to third-party influence**.

Challenges in Sports Governance

- **Sports as hobby v. profession:** There is considerable challenge to transform sports from just a hobby due to its low success rate, academic pressure and job-seeker mentality to sports as a profession.
- **Religious barriers:** Some sports like swimming and athletics require attire that does not fully cover a woman's body and is against the laws of some religions.
- **Biasedness:** The enthusiasm in sports is mainly concentrated in cricket which easily attracts investment and pays the cricketers a hefty sum of revenues.
- **Lack of implementation of PoSH Act, 2013:** Despite the enactment of Prevention of Sexual Harassment Act, 2013, there are 15, out of 30 National Sports Federations which do not meet this mandatory requirement of having an Internal Complaints Committee.
- **High performance pressure:** A high degree of pressure is inflicted upon a sportsperson to perform or else be prepared to live a vulnerable life.
- **Resource deficit:** There is a dearth of good-quality sporting infrastructure available across the country. The government has developed some good stadiums in urban regions, but the situation is very poor in rural regions.

Steps Taken

- **Financial assistance:** Government has provided direct and indirect financial assistance to sports federations such as tax benefits.
- **Sports facilities** are provided for hosting events for the National Sports Federation.
- **National Sports Development Code of India, 2011:** It provides for minimum standards to be compiled by the sports body to retain the sports ministry's annual recognition and enjoy the privileges.
- **National Anti-Doping Act, 2022:** The act provides for the constitution of the National Anti-Doping agency as a statutory body for regulating anti-doping activities in sports.
- **Draft National Code for Good Governance:** The draft National Code for Good Governance in Sports 2017 is a proposed set of guidelines for the management and administration of sports bodies in India.

National Sports Governance Act, 2025 – Key Highlights

- **National Sports Bodies:** Establishes National Olympic, Paralympic, and Sports Federations with state/district units, aligned with international charters.
- **National Sports Board (NSB):** Grants recognition to sports bodies; only recognised bodies receive government funding.
- **Ethics & Transparency:** Mandates Code of Ethics; recognised bodies treated as public authorities under RTI Act, 2005.
- **NSB Composition:** Members appointed by Central Government based on expert qualifications in sports governance and public administration.
- **National Sports Tribunal:** Adjudicates sports disputes (excluding international events and internal matters).
- **Election Oversight:** Establishes electoral panels at national and federation levels for fair elections.
- **Government Powers:** Central Government can exempt provisions for promotion of sports in public interest.

Way Forward

- **Sexual harassment:** There is need to implement Prevention of Sexual Harassment Act, 2013 in letter and spirit in the sports bodies.
- **Professionalism:** There is a need to have professional sports governance and administration to curb the abuse of power, **e.g.** qualifications on selection and retention of members in sports bodies.
- **Collaboration:** There is a need to develop educational resources on governance and promote collaboration to optimize resource use.
- **Accountability:** There is a need to enforce accountability and transparency requirements such as mandatory Public Disclosures for administrative decisions, regular issuing of statements etc.
- **Bottom-up approach:** There is a need to adopt a Bottom-up approach to reconstitute and reform district and state bodies which will influence the national sports bodies.

CONSUMER PROTECTION

Consumer protection is **the practice of safeguarding buyers of goods and services, as well as the public, against unfair practices** in the marketplace. Consumer protection measures are often established by law with the intention of preventing businesses from engaging in fraud or other specified unfair practices.

Need for Consumer Protection Mechanism

- **Quality of products:** To safeguard the consumer from poor quality of products.
- **Fraudulent practices:** To ban fraudulent practices adopted by some of the consumer goods and services providers, such as deceitful warranties etc.
- **Effective grievance redressal:** There is a need to provide for an effective grievance redressal mechanism against the complaints raised by the consumers.
- **Protect rights of consumers:** There is a need to protect rights of consumers such as right to know about the product, right to choose etc.
- **Faster dispute resolution:** There is a need to have a mechanism for faster dispute resolution outside the courts that are overburdened.
- **Unite consumers:** While the businessmen and traders in our country are united, consumers are not united and such a mechanism unites them.
- **Hoarding:** Sometimes, the firms or producers create artificial scarcity of essential products by hoarding products which leads to increased prices.

Steps Taken

- **Consumer Protection Act, 1986:** The Act has provided a separate mechanism for consumer protection through separate consumer courts, recognition of six rights of consumers etc.
- **Consumer Protection Amendment Act, 2019:** The 1986 Act was amended to provide for the following:
  - **Expansion of consumer rights** such as right to information on other aspects, complaint from anywhere and to seek compensation under product liability.
  - Coverage of e-commerce under the ambit of the Act.
  - Expansion of definition of **unfair trade practices** such as failure to issue a bill or receipt, refusal to accept a good return within 30 days, disclosure of personal information unless any law requires in public interest.
  - Complaints can be filed where the consumer resides.
  - Inclusion of provision of mediation as an Alternative Dispute Resolution Mechanism.
  - Establishment of the Central Consumer Protection Authority to promote, protect and enforce the rights of consumers.
  - Raise the pecuniary jurisdiction of Consumer Dispute Resolution Commissions.
    - **District level:** Up to Rs one crore. (further reduced to Rs. 50 lakh)
    - **State level:** Between Rs one crore and up to Rs 10 crore; (Further reduced to 50 lakhs to 2 crores)
    - **National level:** Above Rs 10 crore. (Further reduced to Rs. 2 crores)
- **E-Daakhil Portal:** The Central Government has set up the E-Daakhil Portal, which provides a hassle-free, speedy and inexpensive facility to consumers to conveniently approach the relevant consumer forum.
- **Consumer Protection (e-Commerce) Rules, 2020:** The rules provide that sellers cannot refuse to take back goods or withdraw services or refuse refunds, prohibit the e-commerce companies from manipulating prices of goods etc.
- **Guidelines on Prevention of Misleading Advertisements and Endorsements for Misleading Advertisements, 2022:** The guidelines have been notified to protect the consumers from misleading advertisements and protect the consumers' rights.
- The **National Consumer Helpline (NCH)** is a key platform for grievance redressal, witnessing a tenfold rise in calls from 2015 to 2024. It offers pre-litigation support in 17 languages via toll-free number and digital platforms.
  - Consumers can file complaints through the **INGRAM** (Integrated Grievance Redressal Mechanism) portal, WhatsApp, SMS, email, app, and web services.

Knowledge Nuggets

- The Department of Consumer Affairs runs the **"Jago Grahak Jago"** campaign to spread consumer awareness across all regions through simple, clear messages. It also launched the **"Jagriti"** mascot to educate and empower consumers about their rights and protections.

Challenges

- **Pendency:** Currently there are more than 5.5 lakh pending consumer cases in the country which includes more than 4,029 pending cases filed before the year 2000.
- **Lack of remedy to producers:** There is little or no provision for the victims (producers) of product recalls which not only damage the financial position of such companies but also impairs its reputation among consumers for a long period of time.

- **Violation of rules:** Despite guidelines against misleading advertisements, there has been violation of those guidelines, especially in the gaming industry such as Winzo, MPL etc.
- **Arm-twisting of weaker parties:** Certain provisions of the Act such as mediation for dispute resolution provide stronger parties an opportunity to arm-twist the weaker parties.
- **Vacancies:** There are more than 250 vacancies for members in district commissions that hampers the working of the commissions.

Way Forward

- **Ranking:** Various district commissions can be ranked on the basis of their performance in dispute resolution to bring competitiveness in their functioning.
- **Executive intervention:** There is a need for swift executive intervention to ensure compliance with the guidelines for misleading ads, tele-marketing, multi-level marketing etc.
- **Awareness:** There is a need to raise awareness among the masses about their rights through social media, Jagriti mascot etc. to ensure that they are vocal about their rights.
- **Guidelines for celebrity endorsement:** There is a need to have separate guidelines for celebrities regarding unhealthy food, alcohol etc.
- **Duties of consumers:** Along with the rights, consumers should also exercise their duties such as filing complaints, class action suits, indulging in activism to ensure their rights are safeguarded by the institutions.

Dark Patterns in e-Commerce

Context: The Ministry of Consumer Affairs formed a **17-member task force** to frame guidelines against **Dark Patterns** in e-commerce.

Dark Patterns: These are deceptive design tactics on websites/apps that **manipulate users** into unintended actions. Term coined by **Harry Brignull (2010)**; exploit **cognitive biases**.

Key Types Identified (9)

1. **False Urgency** – Pressure through fake scarcity.
2. **Basket Sneaking** – Adding items without consent.
3. **Confirm Shaming** – Guilt-tripping users.
4. **Forced Action** – Forcing actions to access services.
5. **Nagging** – Repeated prompts to act.
6. **Subscription Trap** – Easy to join, hard to cancel.
7. **Bait & Switch** – Misleading offers.
8. **Hidden Costs** – Extra charges shown late.
9. **Disguised Ads** – Ads mimicking real content.

Consequences: Harms consumer rights, **leads to data misuse**, **unwanted payments**, and **poor online experience**.

Way forward: The government's initiative to frame guidelines aims to curb deceptive online practices and protect consumer rights. Raising public awareness is key to empowering users against manipulative dark patterns.

Key Words

Social Governance, Economic Governance, Welfare Schemes, Education and Health Governance, Gender and Child Welfare, Marginalized Communities, Fiscal Policy, Monetary Policy, Public Sector Enterprises, Ease of Doing Business, MGNREGA, NFSA, NEP 2020, DBT (Direct Benefit Transfer), NITI Aayog, Finance Commission, Lokpal, CVC (Central Vigilance Commission), RTI (Right to Information), Accountability, Transparency, Participation, Rule of Law, Equity and Inclusiveness, Effectiveness and Efficiency, Digital India Programme, E-Governance Platforms, Grievance Redressal, Affirmative Action.

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	What are the aims and objectives of recently passed and enforced, The Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. Whether University/State Education Board examinations, too, are covered under the Act?	2024
2.	Discuss the role of the Competition Commission of India in containing the abuse of dominant position by the Multi-National Corporations in India. Refer to the recent decisions.	2023
3.	"Development and welfare schemes for the vulnerable, by its nature, are discriminatory in approach." Do you agree? Give reasons for your answer.	2023
4.	Has digital illiteracy, particularly in rural areas, coupled with lack of Information and Communication Technology (ICT) accessibility hindered socio-economic development? Examine with justification.	2021

6 Environmental and Ethical Governance

ENVIRONMENTAL GOVERNANCE

- Environmental governance refers to the frameworks, institutions, policies, and practices through which societies identify and address environmental challenges. It involves strategies, policies, and long-term management plans aimed at reducing environmental impact.
  - It ensures that environmental considerations are integrated into every stage of development.
  - Good environmental governance also demands that decision-makers consider both environmental and social consequences of their actions.

Key Principles of Environmental Governance

- **Integration:** Environmental considerations should be incorporated into all decision-making processes and activities.
- **Interconnection:** Recognizing the interconnectedness of urban centers, societies, economies, and governance with the environment.
- **Interdependence:** Emphasizing the mutual reliance between individuals and the ecosystems they inhabit.
- **Transition:** Advocating for a shift from linear, wasteful systems to circular, regenerative approaches.

Environmental Policies and Regulations in India

1. **Policy Framework for Sustainability:** The **National Environment Policy (2006)** and **National Action Plan on Climate Change (2008)** guide sustainable development and climate response through missions like solar energy and water conservation.
2. **Legal Backing for Protection:** Acts like the **Environment (Protection) Act, 1986**, **Air and Water Acts**, and **Wildlife Protection Act, 1972** provide regulatory power to curb pollution and preserve biodiversity.
3. **Institutional Enforcement Mechanism:** Bodies like **MoEFCC**, **Central Pollution Control Board**, and **National Green Tribunal (NGT)** ensure implementation, monitoring, and grievance redressal (e.g., NGT banned construction in eco-sensitive zones).
4. **Recent Initiatives & Enforcement Examples:**
   - The **Plastic Waste Management Rules (2016, updated 2022)** banned single-use plastics;
   - **E-Waste Rules** promoted safe disposal;
   - **WCCB** cracked down on illegal wildlife trade, supporting India's commitment to biodiversity conservation.
   - **Participatory Mechanisms** Public and community involvement in decision-making. E.g., Public hearings, joint forest management.

Constitutional Provisions and Judiciary Role in Environment Governance in India

- **Article 48A (Directive Principles of State Policy) –** Directs the State to protect and improve the environment and safeguard forests and wildlife. It was added by the 42nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1976.
- **Article 51A(g) (Fundamental Duties) –** Imposes a duty on every citizen to protect the natural environment including forests, lakes, rivers, and wildlife, and to have compassion for living creatures.
- **MC Mehta v. Union of India (1987, Oleum Gas Leak case):** Established the **principle of absolute liability** for hazardous industries and expanded **public interest litigation (PIL)** for environmental causes.
- **MC Mehta v. Union of India (Ganga Pollution case):** Directed the closure/treatment of polluting tanneries, emphasizing the **"Polluter Pays Principle."**
- **Vellore Citizens' Welfare Forum v. Union of India (1996):** Recognized **sustainable development** as part of Indian law and reinforced **precautionary and polluter-pays principles.**

Key Challenges in Environmental Governance

- **Development–Environment Trade-off:** Infrastructure projects often prioritise economic gains over ecological and social costs, leading to displacement and environmental damage.

Eg: Sardar Sarovar Dam on Narmada River.

- **Implementation Constraints:** Despite high allocations, projects face delays and inefficiencies in execution.

  Eg: Under Namami Gange, only 307 of 406 projects completed (Jan 2025).
- **Policy & Coordination Gaps:** Inconsistent policies and weak inter-sectoral coordination hinder effective environmental management.

  Eg: Plastic waste generation (~26,000 tonnes/day) despite circular economy initiatives.
- **Financial Barriers:** Large investment needs and limited access to green finance slow progress in renewable energy expansion.

  Eg: $293 billion required by 2030.
- **Knowledge & Adaptation Gaps:** Limited understanding of local climate impacts weakens adaptation strategies and policy effectiveness.

POLICY CONTRADICTIONS AND ENVIRONMENTAL DEGRADATION (UPSC 2018)

Environmental protection is critical due to rising human impact, but conflicting policies and competing stakeholder interests limit the effectiveness of mitigation efforts.

Key Policy Contradictions

- **Development vs. Environment:** Economic projects like highways or mining often override environmental concerns. Example: Forest clearances for industrial zones.
- **Uneven Regulations:** Large polluting industries sometimes escape strict rules due to lobbying, while smaller ones face stricter compliance.
- **Stakeholder Conflict:** Mining companies vs. environmental groups – differing priorities lead to weak or delayed policies.
- **Lack of Inter-sectoral Coordination:** Environment Ministry policies may clash with Industry or Energy Ministry plans, creating confusion and inaction.

Way Forward

- **PCB Strengthening:** Address understaffing and underfunding of Pollution Control Boards to improve enforcement.
- **Climate Law:** Enact a comprehensive national climate legislation for clear climate governance.
- **Green Infrastructure:** Invest in eco-friendly projects like electric highways to reduce emissions.
- **Renewable Expansion:** Promote rooftop solar under PM Surya Ghar Yojana (2024) targeting 1 crore households.
- **Green Bonds:** Increase issuance to finance environmental projects.
- **Carbon Market:** Implement National Carbon Trading Scheme to incentivize emission reduction.



Fig. 6.1: Sustainable Development Goals

- **Early Warning:** Strengthen disaster forecasting and response systems.
- **Resilient Infra:** Develop climate-resilient infrastructure with risk-based planning

SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS (SDGS) AND INDIA

The Sustainable Development Goals outline an exceptionally ambitious and all-encompassing agenda for worldwide development by 2030. India has implemented numerous proactive measures to integrate the SDGs into the policies, schemes, and programs of the government.

Tracking India's Governance Efforts and Progress in Sustainable Development Goals

Sustainable Development Goals	India's Efforts and Progress	Notable Initiatives
SDG 1: No Poverty	❖ Women's labor force participation increased to **37.0%**. ❖ **33.98 lakh** Self Help Groups (SHGs) connected to bank credit.	❖ Implementation of **Kudumbashree** in Kerala since **1998**.

SDG 2: Zero Hunger	❖ NFSA coverage increased to **97.6%** in **2018-19**. ❖ Soil health cards distributed: **224 million** ❖ Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana extended to 2028, providing free food grains to over 81 crore beneficiaries.	❖ Establishment of a Breast **Milk Bank** in Ramanathapuram, Tamil Nadu. ❖ Central kitchens in Nandurbar, Maharashtra.
SDG 3: Good Health and Well-being	❖ Ayushman Bharat PMJAY provided health insurance to **100 million** families. ❖ Maternal Mortality Ratio decreased to **97**. ❖ Malaria incidence decreased to **0.13** per **1000** cases in **2022**.	❖ **YSR Aarogyasri Health Insurance Scheme** in Andhra Pradesh. - Establishment of **Child Protection Unit** in Muzzafarpur.
SDG 4: Quality Education	❖ Dropout rates are reduced at elementary and secondary levels. ❖ Gender Parity Index for higher education improved to **1**. ❖ GER in Higher Secondary Education: **57.6%**.	❖ **Unnayan Banka Smart Classroom Model** in Bihar.
SDG 5: Gender Equality	❖ PMJDY opened **381 million** bank accounts, **54%** by women. ❖ **75%** of MUDRA Yojana beneficiaries are women. ❖ Women's political participation in parliament: **14.36%**. ❖ Women's Reservation Bill passed, reserving 33% seats in Parliament and State Assemblies for women.	❖ **Children First** initiative in Muzzafarpur.
SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation	❖ Rural households with access to improved drinking water: **99.25%**. ❖ Rural individual household toilets: **100%**. ❖ **97.4%** of schools have separate toilets for girls.	❖ **'TAANKA' Technique** for Water Conservation in Uttar Pradesh. ❖ **Subsurface Dams** in Y.S.R Kadappa, Andhra Pradesh.
SDG 7: Affordable and Clean Energy	❖ Renewable energy capacity target by **2030**: **450 GW**. ❖ India added nearly 28 GW of renewable energy capacity in 2024, with solar power constituting 70% of the increase.	❖ **Suryashakti Kisan Yojana (SKY)** in Gujarat.
SDG 8: Decent Work and Economic Growth	❖ Patents issued increased to **34,134**. ❖ Startups recognized under Startup India Scheme: **26,522**. ❖ Banking outlets per 1 lakh population: **98.8**.	❖ **Atal Incubation Center (AIC)** supporting entrepreneurship.
SDG 9: Industry, Innovation and Infrastructure	❖ Investment in Bharatmala program tripled. ❖ Sagarmala project increased port cargo handling capacity. ❖ India ranks as the third-largest domestic market for civil aviation.	❖ **Streamlining ease of doing business** in Mumbai and Delhi for construction permits.
SDG 10: Reduced Inequality	❖ **MUDRA scheme**: 48% of loan accounts held by SC, ST, and OBC entrepreneurs. ❖ 44.4% of seats in panchayati raj institutions are held by women.	❖ **Sweekruti Scheme** in Odisha for transgender community empowerment.
SDG 11: Sustainable Cities and Communities	❖ Completed houses in urban areas: 3.2 million. ❖ 98% of wards achieved 100% door-to-door waste collection. ❖ Development of Palava City near Mumbai as a net-zero emissions urban area with green infrastructure.	❖ **Bhubaneswar One** electronic portal in Odisha. ❖ Panaji's **"Boardwalk"** amidst mangroves in Goa.

SDG 12: Responsible Consumption and Production	❖ India ranks 9th globally in organic agriculture land. ❖ Waste segregation at source in 75% of municipal wards. ❖ Implementation of e-waste management rules	❖ **"Nirmala Bhavanam Nirmala Nagaram"** project in Alappuzha, Kerala.
SDG 13: Climate Action	❖ Solar installed capacity surged 13 times to 34.62 GW. - Emission intensity of GDP reduced by 21%.	❖ **India Cooling Action Plan (ICAP)** to ensure sustainable cooling.
SDG 14: Life Below Water	❖ India ranks 16th in maritime nations, 2nd in fish production. ❖ Maximum sustainable yield in fishing increased by 43%.	❖ **Sindhudurg Mainstreaming Project** in Maharashtra.
SDG 15: Life on Land	❖ 1.69 million hectares of land under afforestation initiatives. ❖ 26 million hectares targeted for restoration by 2030.	❖ **Green Highways Policy** for sustainable highways.
SDG 16: Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions	❖ More than 90% enrolled in **Aadhaar**. ❖ Decrease in overall crime rate. ❖ Expansion of e-Courts and digitalization of judicial processes	❖ **Police Uncle Tutorial** program in Simdega, Jharkhand.
SDG 17: Partnership for the Goals	❖ India's leadership in G20 and collaboration with global partners to promote digital public infrastructure.	❖ **International Solar Alliance (ISA)** to promote solar energy deployment.

SDG India Index

- ❖ The SDG India Index published by Niti Aayog. Monitors the advancement of all States and Union Territories based on crucial national indicators, evaluating their progress regarding the outcomes of interventions and programs implemented by the Government of India.
- ❖ The SDG India Index aims to offer a comprehensive perspective on the social, economic, and environmental conditions of the nation along with its Union Territories and States
- ❖ India stands as the pioneering nation in creating a government-led sub-national gauge of SDG progress.
- ❖ It was formulated in partnership with the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), the United Nations in India, and the Global Green Growth Institute.

NITI Aayog SDG India Index 2023–24

The NITI Aayog's SDG India Index 2023–24 tracks state-wise progress on 16 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) using 113 national indicators. It promotes cooperative and competitive federalism and aids in integrating SDGs into state development strategies.

Key Highlights

- ❖ **India's score** improved to **71** (up from 66 in 2020–21 and 57 in 2018), reflecting gains in poverty reduction, economic growth, and climate action.
- ❖ **Top performers**: **Kerala** and **Uttarakhand** (79 points each).
- ❖ **Lowest performers**: **Bihar (57)** and **Jharkhand (62)**.
- ❖ **32 States/UTs** are in the **Front-Runner** category (scores: 65–99), including new entrants like **Assam, UP, and Chhattisgarh**.
- ❖ **The index excludes SDG 14 (Life Below Water)** from composite scores, as it applies only to coastal states.

The Index supports **evidence-based policymaking**, strengthens SDG localisation, and aligns with India's goal of **Viksit Bharat @2047.**

UN Sustainable Development Report 2025

- ❖ The UN Sustainable Development Report 2025, released by the UN Sustainable Development Solutions Network (SDSN), highlights that the world is significantly behind in achieving the SDGs by 2030.
- ❖ **India's Ranking:** India entered the top 100 (out of 193 countries) for the first time in SDG performance.

- **Global Progress Slowdown:** Only 17% of SDG targets are on track to be achieved by 2030.
- **Areas of Progress:** Significant improvements seen in Electricity access (SDG 7), Mobile and internet usage (SDG 9) and Child and neonatal mortality (SDG 3)
- **Areas of Regression:** Decline observed in Obesity (SDG 2), Press freedom & corruption (SDG 16), Biodiversity (SDG 15) and Nitrogen management (SDG 2).

Environmental Governance and Sustainable Development Linkage

- **Integration of Economic, Environmental, and Social Objectives:** Environmental governance balances development with ecological preservation for present and future generations. **Eg.** National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC) integrates environmental concerns across sectors like agriculture, water, and energy.
- **Decentralization and Participatory Governance:** Empowers local communities in resource management and decision-making. **Eg.** Joint Forest Management (JFM)
- **Equity and Intergenerational Justice:** Considers both intra-generational (e.g., tribal rights) and inter-generational equity. **Eg.** Forest Rights Act (2006) acknowledges traditional forest dwellers' rights, combining environmental protection with social justice.
- **Polluter Pays and Precautionary Principles:** Promotes accountability and preventive action for green practices. **Eg.** National Green Tribunal (NGT) enforces environmental accountability in infrastructure and industrial projects.

Role of Governance in Promoting Sustainable and Inclusive Development

Sustainable Infrastructure Development

- **Invest in renewables and green infrastructure:** India added 29 GW of renewable energy capacity in 2024-25, raising the total to 220.10 GW—about 46.3% of total installed capacity. The National Green Hydrogen Mission, aims to produce 5 MMT of green hydrogen annually by 2030.
- **Enhance EIAs and community engagement:** Conduct comprehensive Environmental Impact Assessments (EIAs) and involve local communities in decision-making.

Responsible Resource Extraction

- **Promote efficiency and enforce regulations:** The government is re-evaluating a **$30 billion sulphur-cutting programme** for coal plants due to minimal impact on pollution levels, considering more cost-effective technologies like electrostatic precipitators.
- **Invest in alternatives and ensure community benefits:** The National Green Hydrogen Mission aims to position India as a global leader in green hydrogen production, with increased allocations for green ammonia production under the SIGHT Programme

Clean Industrial Growth

- **Adopt green technologies and enforce pollution control:** The National Clean Air Programme (NCAP) targets a 40% reduction in particulate matter (PM) concentrations by 2026, with city-specific action plans implemented across 131 cities.
- **Engage communities and uphold corporate responsibility:** Inform communities. Encourage responsible industry practices.

Sustainable Land Use Management

- **Conserve ecosystems and empower communities:** Urban planning initiatives emphasize the creation of green spaces and the conservation of ecosystems, with cities like Delhi aiming to allocate 15% to 20% of land use for green belts and recreational areas.
- **Implement smart urban planning and minimize land acquisition**: Developments like Palava City near Mumbai showcase sustainable urban planning with features like walkability, renewable energy integration, and efficient resource management, aiming for net-zero emissions.

Effective governance is essential for driving sustainable development and achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). By promoting partnerships among governments, civil society, private sector, and international organisations, nations can leverage collective expertise to tackle issues like poverty, inequality, climate change, and social injustice.

ETHICAL GOVERNANCE IN INDIA

Ethical governance refers to the practice of conducting public affairs with fairness, transparency, integrity, and accountability. It emphasises using power responsibly, prioritising the public good, and upholding moral principles in decision-making. It is crucial for building a strong and inclusive democracy, fostering economic development, and ensuring social justice.

Philosophical Basis of Ethical Governance

Kautilya's Arthashastra

- **Citizen-Centricity:** Kautilya stressed the king's duty to prioritize the welfare of his subjects, stating, "In the happiness of subjects lies the happiness of the king."

- **Combating Corruption:** He advocated for strict measures like "Kantakshodhana" to purge corruption, highlighting transparency and accountability.

Gandhi's Vision of Ramrajya

- **Ramrajya:** Gandhi envisioned an ideal state based on moral principles like nonviolence and truth, believing governance must be rooted in morality.
- **Swaraj:** His concept of self-rule emphasized citizen participation as crucial for ethical governance.

Aristotle's Distinction: Aristotle classified governments as either "perverted" or "legitimate," emphasizing the latter's focus on the public good over the ruling class's interests.

Other Philosophical Traditions

- **Confucianism:** Stresses ethical leadership, social harmony, and meritocratic selection for public office.
- **John Locke and Social Contract Theory:** Highlights the consent of the governed and protection of individual rights.
- **Utilitarianism:** Advocates maximizing happiness and well-being for the greatest number of people.

Role of Ethical Leadership in Ensuring Good Governance

1. **Setting Moral Standards:** Ethical leaders set the tone for the organization. Their conduct becomes a benchmark for subordinates, creating a culture of integrity and fairness. **Eg.** E. Sreedharan, known as the "Metro Man of India", upheld high ethical standards in public service, ensuring timely and corruption-free execution of the Delhi Metro project.
2. **Promoting Accountability:** Ethical leaders create systems for internal and external accountability through transparency, citizen feedback, and audit mechanisms. **Eg.** Kiran Bedi, during her tenure in Tihar Jail, introduced reforms that promoted accountability and humane treatment of inmates.
3. **Championing Equity and Social Justice:** Ethical leadership ensures policies do not favor vested interests but are based on fairness, especially for the vulnerable. **Eg.** Mahatma Gandhi's idea of "Sarvodaya" (welfare of all) exemplified how moral leadership can guide inclusive governance.
4. **Institution Building:** Ethical leaders contribute to building institutions that endure beyond their tenure, embedding values into organizational structures. **Eg.** Nandan Nilekani, As first Chairman of UIDAI (2009), he led the creation of Aadhaar, which became a foundational Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) enabling efficient governance and targeted welfare delivery.

ETHICAL ISSUES IN INDIAN GOVERNANCE

- **Abuse of Authority:** Officials exceeding **powers**, making biased decisions, or misusing **resources** erode trust. Recent reports cited unauthorized **land acquisitions** by government officials, bypassing legal procedures.
- **Negligence and Dereliction of Duty:** Failures by **public servants** lead to inefficiency and harm. Recent incidents include healthcare workers neglecting duties, resulting in substandard care and avoidable deaths.
- **Bribery and Corruption:** Rampant **corruption** diverts resources from public needs. Notable cases involve high-profile officials accepting bribes for awarding contracts, undermining fair competition and public welfare.
- **Complacency and Lack of Motivation:** Many officials prioritize personal **benefits** over public service. Surveys reveal widespread dissatisfaction, with lack of recognition and incentives cited as demotivating factors.

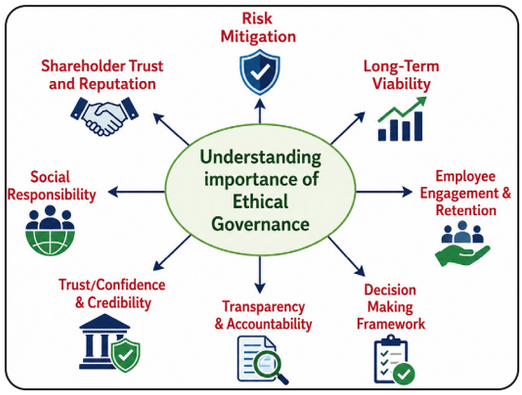


Fig. 6.2: Importance of Ethical Governance

- **Patronage and Favouritism:** Nepotism and favoritism in **appointments** undermine transparency. Recent controversies include political leaders appointing unqualified individuals based on personal relationships rather than merit.
- **Excessive Secrecy and Lack of Transparency:** Opacity in decision-making obstructs **accountability**. Instances of withholding crucial information about public projects raise concerns about conflicts of interest.

Steps Taken in India to Promote Ethical Governance

- **Accountability to Parliament:** Administrators are answerable to political executives, who are accountable to Parliament**.Eg.,** In March 2024, the **CAG report** flagged irregularities in PM Poshan Scheme implementation in several states, which was debated in Parliament.
- **Code of Conduct for Ministers:** A Code of Conduct applies to Ministers at both Union and State levels, with recommendations for a code of ethics suggested by parliamentary committees.

- **Committees on Ethics:** Both the Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha have Committees on Ethics overseeing the moral conduct of Members of Parliament. **The Lok** Sabha Ethics Committee's review of alleged conduct violations by an MP in late 2023 showcased the institutional role in upholding ethical standards among lawmakers.
- **Disclosure of Interest:** Mandatory disclosure of interest in both Houses of Parliament ensures transparency, with members required to declare any personal pecuniary interests.
- **Code of Conduct for Civil Servants:** Civil servants adhere to a prescribed code of conduct to prevent private interests from influencing government decisions.
- **Legal Mechanisms to Check Corruption:** Laws such as the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, Benami Transactions (Prohibition) Act, 1988, and Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002, combat corruption.
- **Right to Information Act, 2005:** This Act promotes participatory governance and democracy by granting citizens access to government information. **E.g.,** In January 2024, an RTI query revealed delays in the disbursal of PM-KISAN funds in certain districts
- **Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act, 2013**: In 2024, the Lokpal received over 500 complaints, indicating rising public awareness and trust in anti-corruption institutions, although delays in appointments to the Lokpal bench were criticised by civil society.

Way Forward

While India has taken commendable steps towards strengthening its ethical framework, further action is needed to fully address the challenges and secure lasting progress. Here are some key areas for improvement:

- **Strengthening Legal Frameworks and Accountability Mechanisms:**
  - **Clarity and Comprehensiveness:** Ensure laws are clearly defined and easily accessible.
  - **Accountability Mechanisms:** Outline clear consequences for unethical conduct.
- **Enhancing Management Practices and Whistleblower Protection:**
  - **Anti-Corruption Training:** Equip officials to identify and report corruption.
  - **Internal Compliance Systems:** Establish robust systems for ethical conduct.
  - **Whistleblower Protection:** Strengthen laws and provide anonymous reporting channels.
- **Implementing Robust Integrity Audits and Addressing Recommendations:**
  - **Regular Assessments:** Conduct integrity audits to identify vulnerabilities.
  - **Proactive Measures:** Implement preventive actions based on audit findings.
  - **Addressing Recommendations:** Act on suggestions like partial state funding of elections.
- **Combating Corruption with Stronger Measures:**
  - **Confiscation of Property:** Expand confiscation scope to deter corrupt practices.
  - **Speedy Trials:** Streamline judicial processes for swift action.
  - **Damages for Corruption:** Hold corrupt officials financially accountable.

These focused areas provide a roadmap for India's pursuit of ethical governance, fostering transparency, accountability, and integrity in public service.

Key Words

Environmental Governance: Green Governance, Sustainable Development Governance, Eco-Governance, Environmental Stewardship, Protecting Our Planet for Future Generations, Climate Change Mitigation & Adaptation.

Ethical Governance: Responsible Leadership, Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR), Transparency & Accountability, Building Trust & Integrity, Business Ethics & Anti-Corruption, Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DE&I), Sustainable Business Practices, Stakeholder Engagement

Previous Year Questions	Year
1. "Environmental governance is not just about protecting the environment but ensuring sustainable development." Discuss this statement with examples from India's environmental policies.	2020
2. “Ethical governance is the foundation of a responsive and accountable administration.” Examine the role of ethical leadership in ensuring good governance.	2021

7 Citizen Charter

CITIZEN CHARTER

The Citizen Charter is a public declaration by a government agency about its commitment to deliver services transparently, efficiently, and accountably. Introduced in India in 1997 during the Conference of Chief Ministers, it was inspired by the UK model and aimed to improve service delivery, especially in departments with high public interface.

Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances in the Ministry **of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions**, Government of India, coordinates the efforts to formulate and operationalize Citizens' Charters in Central Government, State Governments and UT Administrations. It provides guidelines for formulation and implementation of the Charters as well as their evaluation.

KEY COMPONENTS OF A CITIZEN'S CHARTER

- **Vision and Mission Statement:** States the organization's goals and commitment to service delivery. Reflects the overall purpose and core values.
- **Details of Services Offered:** Clearly lists the services provided by the department or agency. E.g., issue of licenses, delivery of certificates, processing of applications.
- **Service Standards/Delivery Timelines:** Specifies timeframes, quality benchmarks, and expected outcomes. E.g., passport to be delivered within 15 working days.
- **Grievance Redressal Mechanism** Details of how citizens can lodge complaints. Includes contact persons, timelines for resolution, and escalation matrix.
- **Responsibility Centers/Contact Details:** Names and contact details of responsible officers. Helps citizens reach out for assistance or clarification.
- **Expectations from Citizens** Lists responsibilities of citizens to enable effective service delivery. E.g., submission of correct documents, respectful behavior with staff.
- **Additional Commitments:** Provisions such as **compensation or apology** in case of failure to meet service standards. E.g., penalty to be paid or service charge refunded if deadlines are not met.

SALIENT FEATURES OF CITIZEN CHARTER

- **Clear Service Standards:** Citizen Charters should define transparent and time-bound service standards.
- **Transparency:** Citizens should receive simple and accurate information about services and procedures.
- **Citizen Participation:** Users should be consulted regularly and given service choices wherever possible.
- **Responsiveness:** Public institutions should ensure fair, courteous, and citizen-friendly service delivery.
- **Grievance Redressal:** Effective mechanisms should address complaints promptly and improve service quality.
- **Accountability:** Officials should be clearly responsible for efficient and timely service delivery.

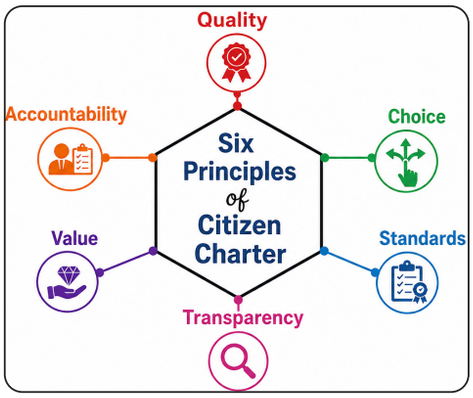


Fig. 7.1: Six Principles of Citizen Charter

Progress of the Citizen Charter Movement in India

1. **Initial Step (1997)**: The decision to implement Citizen Charters in India was taken during the 1997 Chief Ministers' Conference, emphasizing sectors with significant public interaction like health, education, transport, etc.

2. **Legislative Step (2011)**: The *Citizens Charter Bill, 2011* aimed to give statutory backing to the charter. It proposed mandatory formulation within six months and penal provisions (up to ₹50,000) for non-compliance. However, the Bill lapsed and was not enacted.
3. **Government Platforms**: A centralized online repository has been developed, collating Charters of various Ministries and Departments, improving visibility and comparability.
4. **Model Panchayat Citizens Charter (2021)**: Released by the Ministry of Panchayati Raj, this Charter covers service delivery in 29 sectors, linking local governance with Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), especially relevant in rural service delivery. *Example:* In 2023–24, several Gram Panchayats in Kerala and Himachal Pradesh adopted this model, aligning it with local service delivery priorities.

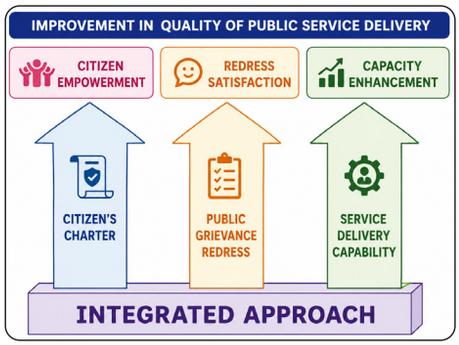


Fig. 7.2: Integrated Approach

CHALLENGES IN IMPLEMENTATION OF CITIZEN CHARTER (UPSC 2013, 2018, 2024)

- **Absence of Legal Mandate**: Without statutory backing, the Citizen Charter lacks enforceability, making compliance voluntary and inconsistent across departments.
- **Generalized and Repetitive Content**: Many charters are copied from one ministry to another without customization, reducing their relevance and effectiveness in addressing specific departmental needs.
- **Language and Accessibility Barriers**: Most charters are not available in regional languages, limiting reach among non-Hindi/English speakers. Additionally, they are not accessible to persons with disabilities, such as being unavailable in Braille or audio formats.
- **Lack of Public Consultation**: Citizens are rarely involved in the drafting process, which leads to charters that do not align with public expectations or ground realities.
- **Limited Awareness Among Citizens**: There are minimal outreach efforts or campaigns to inform citizens about their rights under the charter, especially in rural and marginalized communities.
- **Inadequate Grievance Redressal Mechanisms**: Feedback systems are often weak, with delays in redressal undermining public trust. ***Example*:** The CAG's 2024 report highlighted significant delays in resolving citizen complaints in urban local bodies under the Smart Cities Mission, pointing to structural inefficiencies.

MEASURES TO MAKE CITIZEN CHARTER EFFECTIVE (UPSC 2018)

2nd ARC recommendations

- **Standardization**: The charters should clearly spell out the remedy penalty compensation in case there is a default in meeting the standards spelt out in the charter.
- **Wide consultation process**: Citizen Charter should be formulated after having advocate consultation within organization and between organization and civil society.
- **Adequate grievances redressal mechanism:** In case of default Citizen Charter should clearly lay down the relief the organization is bound to provide if it defaults on the promised standards of delivery.
- **One size does not fit all**: The capability and resources and responsibility among government organizations are not equivalent and there is a need to implement Citizen Charter significantly across the country.
- **Periodic evaluation**: The citizen's charters should be reviewed and revised regularly.

IIPA (Indian Institute of Public Administration) Recommendations on Citizens' Charter

- **Grievance Data Management:** Develop a centralized database to track and analyze consumer grievances and redress mechanisms.
- **Public Awareness:** Ensure wide publicity of the Charter to enhance public awareness and participation.
- **Dedicated Budgeting:** Allocate specific funds for generating awareness and implementing the Charter effectively.

SEVOTTAM MODEL

- The Sevottam Model, aptly named after the Hindi words "Seva" (service) and "Uttam" (excellence), seeks to elevate the quality of public service delivery in India. Developed by the Second Administrative Reforms Commission (ARC) and launched in 2006, it offers a comprehensive framework for organisations to assess and improve their citizen-centric approach.

Three Modules of Sevottam Model

- **Citizen Charter**: Requires effective charter implementation, which creates a mechanism for people to provide feedback on how organizations decide service delivery requirements.

- **Public Grievance Redressal Mechanism**: Needs a good grievance redress mechanism that, regardless of the final judgment, leaves the citizen more comfortable with how the organization relates to grievances.
- **Services Delivery Capabilities:** Organisation could have exemplary service delivery efficiency only if it manages the key components for successful service delivery well and builds its own capacity to boost delivery continuously.

7 Steps of Implementation of Sevottam Model

- **Quality Management:** The Sevottam Model helps organisations improve service delivery through performance assessment and benchmarking.
- **Citizen-Centric Approach:** It focuses on citizen expectations, feedback, and grievance redressal to promote responsive governance.
- **Continuous Improvement:** The model encourages regular review and adaptation to improve efficiency and relevance.
- **Self-Assessment and Accountability:** It enables departments to assess their performance and strengthen accountability in citizen service delivery

Significance of Sevottam Model

The Sevottam Model carries significant implications for public service delivery in India:

- **Quality Management:** It provides a structured framework for organisations to systematically assess and improve their service delivery performance. **E.g.,**The 2025 national workshop organized by DARPG in Bhopal aimed to build capacity for quality service delivery, reinforcing Sevottam's focus on performance benchmarking and efficiency.
- **Citizen-Centricity:** It emphasises citizen inputs, grievances, and expectations, promoting a service-oriented mindset within organisations.

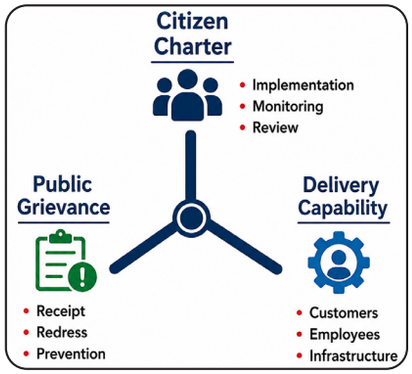


Fig. 7.3: Sevottam Model

Challenges of Sevottam Model

- One major challenge is the ***lack of awareness and capacity*** among public officials. Many departments treat Sevottam as a formality rather than a tool for reform, due to limited training and sensitization. Additionally, ***fragmented implementation***—with only a few departments adopting it fully—hampers its potential for wider transformation in governance.
- Another challenge lies in the ***inadequate integration with digital platforms***. While Sevottam emphasizes service quality and grievance redressal, many departments still lack robust IT systems to collect citizen feedback, track service timelines, or conduct real-time self-assessment. This reduces the model's efficiency and adaptability in a digital-first era.

Way Forward

- To strengthen Sevottam's impact, there is a need for *capacity building and mandatory training* of officials to internalize the model's citizen-centric approach. Departments should be encouraged to embed Sevottam into their core governance strategy rather than treating it as a stand-alone certification.
- Moreover, *digital integration* is essential. Linking Sevottam with platforms like CPGRAMS, MyGov, or service delivery dashboards can enhance transparency and responsiveness. Finally, periodic third-party audits and feedback loops must be institutionalized to ensure *accountability and continuous improvement*.

Key Words

Empowering Citizens, Right to Service, Improved Service Delivery, Charter for Good Governance, Citizen-Centric Administration, Service Delivery Excellence, Citizen Satisfaction, Innovation in Public Service Delivery, SEVA (Service), UTTAM (Excellence), Last-Mile Delivery, Minimum Standards in Service Delivery, Citizen Feedback, Grievance Redressal Mechanisms, TQM (Total Quality Management) in Government Services

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	The Citizens' charter has been a landmark initiative in ensuring citizen-centric administration. But it is yet to reach its full potential. Identify the factors hindering the realisation of its promise and suggest measures to overcome them.	2024
2.	The Citizens' Charter is an ideal instrument of organizational transparency and accountability, but it has its own limitations. Identify the limitations and suggest measures for greater effectiveness of the Citizens' Charter.	2018
3.	Analyze the gap between the formulation of **Citizen's charters** by public service delivery organizations and the level of citizens' satisfaction and quality of services provided.	2013

8 Towards Transparent and Responsible Governance

Transparency and responsible governance are the bedrock of a healthy democracy, ensuring that public power is exercised openly and for the common good. Tools like the Right to Information Act, Social audits, Whistleblowing empower citizens to access government records, promoting openness and enabling informed public participation. Together, these approaches enhance transparency and create strong checks on power, leading to a more responsive, inclusive, and democratic governance system.

Quotes

"Information is the currency of democracy," — **Thomas Jefferson**

"Accountability is the first principle of good governance." — **Amartya Sen**

RIGHT TO INFORMATION

- **RTI as Fundamental right**: The right to information has been upheld by the Supreme Court as a fundamental right flowing from Article 19(1)(a) of the Constitution, which guarantees every citizen the right to free speech and expression.
- **Purpose of the Right to Information (RTI):** The Right to Information (RTI) Act serves several vital objectives that reinforce democratic governance and civic engagement. Its primary purposes include:
  - **Promoting transparency** in the functioning of public authorities by making information accessible to citizens.
  - **Empowering individuals by granting them the legal right** to obtain information held by government bodies.
  - **Reducing corruption and fostering greater accountability** among public officials through open access to administrative actions and decisions.
  - **Strengthening democratic principles** by upholding the public's right to be informed about government policies, programs, and decision-making processes.

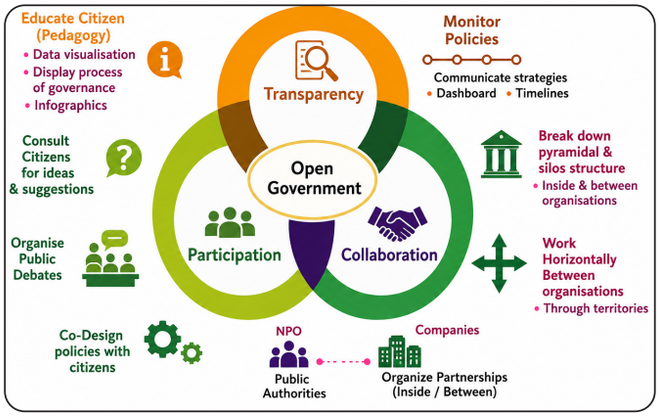
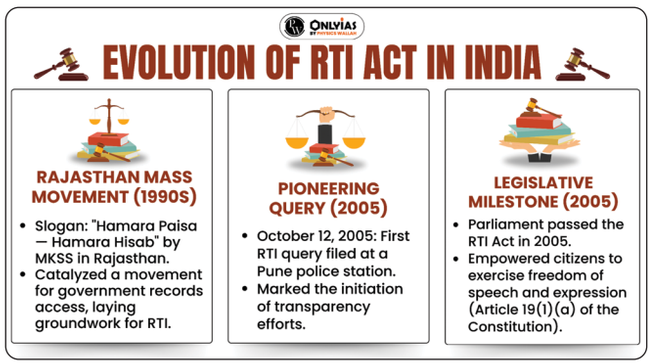


Fig. 8.1: Characteristics of Open Government

History and Development of Act

The concept of the Right to Information (RTI) has evolved over centuries, beginning in Europe and gradually gaining momentum worldwide before taking root in India.

- First RTI law developed by Sweden in 1766.
- **RTI Movement in India**
  - **In Raj Narayan vs Uttar Pradesh Government case, 1975**, The Supreme Court upheld the Right to Information as a fundamental right under Article 19 of the Indian Constitution.
  - The **first grassroots campaign** advocating for the Right to Information was launched by the **Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan (MKSS)** in **1994**.



  - In **1996**, the **National Campaign for People's Right to Information (NCPRI)** was formed. It played a key role in drafting the initial RTI legislation.
  - **Tamil Nadu** became the **first Indian state** to enact its own RTI law in **1997**.
  - The **Freedom of Information Act** was passed by the Indian Parliament in **2002**, but it remained largely unimplemented.

- The **Right to Information Act, 2005**, came into **full effect on October 12, 2005**, marking a significant milestone in India's democratic journey.

Knowledge Nuggets

RTI VS Right to Privacy

The Right to Information (RTI) and the Right to Privacy are both fundamental rights in India, but they can sometimes conflict.

- **Key Differences**
  - RTI promotes transparency and allows access to government information, but certain personal data may be exempt from disclosure under Section 8.
  - Right to Privacy ensures the protection of personal and sensitive information, such as medical and financial data.
- **Points of Conflict**
  - Personal Information: RTI requests for personal information can conflict with privacy rights. However, personal data can be disclosed under RTI only if public interest outweighs privacy concerns.
  - Public Interest vs Privacy: Information about public officials may be disclosed, but personal information unrelated to public duties is protected.
- **Legal Balance**: The Supreme Court has ruled that the Right to Privacy is not absolute and can be limited for public interest, while RTI also has exceptions for personal privacy.
- **Recent Developments:** The DPDP Act, 2023 strengthens personal data protection, affecting how public authorities handle personal data requests under RTI.

Do you know?

"Public authority" means any authority or body or institution of self-government established or Constituted—

- by or under the Constitution;
- by any other law made by the Parliament/State Legislature.
- by notification issued or order made by the appropriate Government, and includes any—
- body owned, controlled or substantially financed.

Salient Features of RTI Act, 2005

- **Rights Provided Under the Act:** The Act allows every citizen to request information from public authorities. **Section 4** mandates public authorities to maintain records systematically and proactively disclose specific categories of information to minimize formal RTI requests.
- **Institutional Framework:** The Central Information Commission (CIC) and State Information Commissions (SICs) are established to oversee the Act's implementation and to address appeals regarding the denial of information and Public Information Officers (PIOs) are appointed at both the central and state levels to provide information to citizens as per their requests.
- **Applicability:** The Act applies to all public authorities, including government bodies established by the Constitution, legislation, or notifications. Organizations and NGOs that receive substantial funding from the government, whether directly or indirectly, are also covered.
- **Timely Response:** Upon receiving an application, the PIO is required to respond within 30 days. In exceptional cases where the information concerns a third party, the response time is extended to 45 days.
- **Provision for Appeal:** An appeal can be made to a departmental Appellate Authority and also a second appeal can be made, if the decision of the Appellate Authority is not satisfactory.
- **Disclosure Obligations:** Public authorities must disclose information related to their organization, functions, decision-making processes, and public schemes.
  - **Type of Information that can be requested through RTI:** The information as defined under section 2 (f) has to be disclosed to the public.
    - Records, documents, memos, and e-mails.
    - Opinions, press releases, circulars, log books, Contracts, data material held in any electronic form and Information relating to any private body
    - It can be accessed by a public authority under any other law for the time being in force.

- **Exemptions:** While promoting transparency, Section 8 of the RTI Act provides specific exemptions to defence and security-related matters, trade secrets, personal information, and cabinet proceedings.
  - Provision for Exceptions under **Section 8 of the RTI Act**:
    - The sovereignty and integrity of India
    - Security, strategic, scientific or economic interests of the State
    - Relations with Foreign States
    - Lead to incitement of an offence
    - Section 8 (2) provides exemption under Official Secrets Act, 1923.
- **Jurisdiction**: The Act bars lower courts from entertaining suits or applications related to RTI requests. However, writ jurisdiction under Articles 32 and 226 of the Constitution remains unaffected.
- **Whistleblower Protection**: It includes provisions for whistleblower protection to encourage whistleblowing and safeguard those who expose corruption or wrongdoing. It prohibits the disclosure of the whistleblower's identity and provides penalties for any harm caused to them.

Significance of Right To Information (RTI) Act

Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005, has had a transformative impact on governance in India. It is a key legal tool that upholds transparency, strengthens democracy, and ensures accountability in public administration. The following points highlight its significance:

- **Empowers Citizens:** RTI enables citizens to access information about government policies and decisions, fostering participation and accountability.
- **Promotes Transparency:** Mandates proactive disclosure by public authorities (Section 4), reducing secrecy. Example: Coalgate scam disclosures led to reforms in resource allocation.
- **Ensures Accountability:** Allows citizens to question government actions and monitor public spending. Example: RTI exposed non-utilisation of MPLADS funds in many constituencies.
- **Combats Corruption:** Helps uncover administrative irregularities and misuse of power. Example: In Rajasthan, RTI exposed fake job cards under MGNREGA.
- **Improves Policy Implementation:** Citizens can track the status of schemes, ensuring better service delivery.
- **Example:** RTI queries led to corrections in MGNREGA data in several villages in Rajasthan.
- **Strengthens Democracy:** Creates an informed citizenry, enhancing civic engagement and government responsiveness.

Knowledge Nuggets

Judiciary under the Ambit of the Right to Information (RTI)

1. **CPIO, Supreme Court of India vs. Subhash Chandra Agarwal (2009):** The Central Information Commission (CIC) ruled that the Office of the Chief Justice of India (CJI) qualifies as a public authority under the RTI Act.
2. **Secretary-General, Supreme Court vs. Subhash Chandra Agarwal (2019):** The Supreme Court upheld the Delhi High Court's decision, confirming that the Office of the CJI is subject to the RTI Act.
3. **Anil Kumar vs. High Court of Punjab and Haryana (2010):** The Punjab and Haryana High Court held that High Courts are public authorities under the RTI Act, emphasizing the importance of transparency and accountability in the judiciary.

Transparency International's Integrity Index 2025 **(UPSC 2016, 2018)**

According to Transparency International's 2025 **Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI)**, India ranked 91st out of 180 countries, with a score of 39 out of 100, indicating a significant issue with corruption and public morality.

Key reasons behind India's low ranking on corruption indices

- **Weak Legal and Institutional Framework**: India lacks robust anti-corruption laws and effective enforcement, with delays in judicial processes allowing offenders to escape punishment.
- **Political Corruption and Lack of Transparency**: Political patronage, opaque election funding (e.g., electoral bonds), and the criminalization of politics erode public trust and institutional integrity.
- **Social Acceptance and Awareness Deficit**: Corruption is often normalized, with limited public awareness about rights and entitlements, and weak protection for whistleblowers discouraging reporting.
- **Cultural and Structural Factors**: Practices like nepotism, favoritism, and bribery rooted in social hierarchies and kinship systems perpetuate corruption across governance structures.

Issues and Challenges in Implementation of RTI

Functional Challenges

- **Vacancies in Information Commissions**: Many Central and State Information Commissions (CICs and SICs) remain under-staffed, with several posts, including Chief Information Commissioners, lying vacant.
  - As of Oct 2024, seven out of 29 state information commissions (SICs) in India were defunct or understaffed due to vacancies. *(As per 2023-24 report of the Satark Nagrik Sangathan)*
- **Backlog of Appeals and Complaints:**As of June 30, 2024, over 4.05 lakh appeals and complaints are pending across 29 commissions. Maharashtra leads with 1.08 lakh cases. Six commissions, including Maharashtra and Odisha, lack a Chief Information Commissioner, critical for managing operations. Eight CIC posts are vacant, despite a backlog of 23,000 cases.
  - Some SICs take over a year to dispose of cases, undermining the effectiveness of the Act.
- **Inadequate Gender Representation**: Since 2005, only 9 % of all Information Commissioners have been women, highlighting gender imbalance.
- **Dysfunctional:** Due to exceptions, the Information Commissions have remained dysfunctional. **Satark Nagrik Sangathan** in its recent study of State Information Commissions' performances found that **four out of 29 are defunct and at least three are still headless.**

Structural Challenges

- **Exemptions under Section 8:** Exemptions for reasons like national security and personal privacy are often misused to deny information. **Exclusions:** PM CARES Fund not covered under RTI as a public authority.
- **Dilution through Amendments:** The RTI (Amendment) Act, 2019 gave the Central Government the power to determine the tenure, salary, and service conditions of Information Commissioners, potentially affecting their independence.

Procedural Challenges

- **Bureaucratic Resistance**: Public officials are often reluctant to disclose information to protect themselves from scrutiny or to conceal inefficiency and corruption.
- **Non-Compliance by Political Parties**: Despite being brought under the RTI Act's purview, major political parties have not appointed Public Information Officers (PIOs).
- **Dependence on Subordinate Rules:** The RTI Act's implementation is dependent on subordinate Rules made by the Union Government and State Governments. Ex - States like **Tamil Nadu do not accept Indian Postal Orders (IPOs).**

Awareness and Safety

- **Safety Concerns for RTI Activist**s: Activists who expose corruption or misuse of power face threats, harassment, and even violence.
- **Weak Whistleblower Protection:** The Whistleblowers Protection Act, 2014, lacks robust provisions to safeguard those who expose wrongdoing, including RTI activists.

Others

- The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, amends Section 8(1)(j) of the RTI Act, restricting access to personal information, citing privacy under the *K.S. Puttaswamy* (2017) judgment. This poses a challenge to transparency by prioritizing privacy over public interest.

RTI Amendment Act 2019 **(UPSC 2020)**

- **Term and Appointment:** Amendment allows the central government to determine the term of CIC and ICs, **removing the fixed five-year term.**
- **Salary Determination:** Original act tied salaries to CEC, ECs, and state Chief Secretaries; amendment gives central government power to specify salaries, allowances, and service conditions.
- By vesting excessive powers with the central government, this amendment has hampered the autonomy of CIC.
- The RTI Act does not seek to make the Information Commission a constitutional body.

Impact on Autonomy and Independence

Negative

- **Increased Executive Influence:** Government control over tenure **weakens commissioners' impartiality**.
- **Reduced Public Trust:** Perceived lack of independence **deters citizens** from **filing RTIs**.
- **Erosion of Federalism:** State commissions **lose autonomy** due to **central oversight**.

Positive

- **Administrative Flexibility:** The amendments allow the government to tailor tenure and salary structures based on evolving governance needs, potentially improving efficiency.
- **Financial Prudence:** Decoupling salaries from Election Commission norms enables resource allocation based on fiscal realities, ensuring sustainable administrative costs.
- **Stronger Executive Coordination:** Centralized oversight can lead to better alignment of RTI implementation with national governance objectives, promoting uniformity in decision-making.

Vigilant scrutiny of the implementation of these amendments, coupled with continued advocacy for the principles of transparency and the autonomy of oversight bodies, will be essential to safeguard its spirit and ensure its continued role in fostering a more informed citizenry in India.

RTI VS Legislations Restricting Disclosure of Information

While the Right to Information (RTI) Act promotes transparency, several existing laws in India impose restrictions on the disclosure of sensitive information, particularly in matters of national interest and official confidentiality.

- **Indian Evidence Act (Sections 123, 124, 162):** Allows the government to withhold documents related to state affairs. A department head can refuse disclosure by declaring the information a state secret. Public officers are also protected from disclosing confidential communications received in official capacity.
- **Atomic Energy Act, 1912:** Prohibits the unauthorized disclosure of information classified as restricted by the Central Government.
- **Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules**: Restrict government servants from sharing official documents without express government permission.
- **Official Secrets Act, 1923:** Empowers officials to mark documents as "confidential," preventing their disclosure and penalizing unauthorized publication.

These provisions highlight the legal balance between transparency and the need to safeguard national security and official confidentiality.

RTI Act and Official Secret Act

The Official Secrets Act (OSA), 1923, prohibits retired officials from disclosing information without clearance. Serving civil servants are restricted from expressing personal opinions on policy matters.

- **OSA Background:** The **Official Secrets Act (OSA)**, rooted in the colonial era, was enacted in **1923** to govern matters of secrecy and confidentiality in governance.
- **OSA Provisions:** It encompasses penalties for spying, disclosure of secret government information, and espionage.
- **RTI vs. OSA:** Section 22 of the RTI Act declares its "overriding effect" over the OSA in specific situations. Public interest in disclosure can outweigh the need for secrecy, allowing access to some information even under the OSA.
- **Landmark Judgments:** The Supreme Court has played a crucial role in defining the boundaries. For instance, the Court ruled in favor of transparency in the Rafale deal case, highlighting RTI's primacy. Additionally, in 2019, the Court declared the Chief Justice of India's office subject to RTI scrutiny, a significant step towards judicial accountability.

Reasons for Stringent Secrecy Norms

- **National Security:** Secrecy safeguards authorized national security operations, preventing harm from leaks or disclosures.
- **Dynamic Security Challenges:** Ever-evolving security challenges require stable policies, necessitating some level of secrecy.
- **Limits to Freedom of Expression:** Absolute freedom of expression does not exist, especially concerning sensitive national security information.

Concerns Regarding OSA

- **Subjectivity in Data Interpretation:** Sensitive data's interpretation may vary among succeeding governments, leading to inconsistencies.
- **Challenges in Declassification:** Experience in declassifying secret files and addressing over-classification issues remains limited.
- **Balancing Transparency and Security:** Officials must balance disclosing governance issues with safeguarding national security interests.

OSA and 2nd ARC Recommendations

- **2nd ARC Proposal:** The **Second Administrative Reforms Commission (2nd ARC)** proposed repealing the OSA to enhance transparency.



Do you know?

Major Scams Exposed through the RTI Act

1. **Adarsh Housing Society Scam:** The misuse of authority by politicians, bureaucrats, and military officials to illegally acquire flats at below-market rates was exposed through RTI queries. The revelations led to the resignation of the then Chief Minister of Maharashtra, whose relatives were among the beneficiaries.
2. **2G Spectrum Scam:** The RTI Act played a key role in uncovering irregularities in the allocation of telecom licenses under the tenure of Telecom Minister A. Raja. The licenses were issued at undervalued rates, resulting in a notional loss of approximately ₹1.76 lakh crore to the exchequer.
3. **Vedanta University Land Acquisition Case:** RTI disclosures revealed that affected landowners were not given a fair hearing during the land acquisition process in Odisha, violating the Land Acquisition (Companies) Rules, 1963. The information was instrumental in legal challenges against the project.

- **RTI Act and Judicial Accountability:** In a landmark verdict, the **Supreme Court** ruled in **2019** that the Chief Justice of India's office falls under the purview of the RTI Act, enhancing judicial transparency.

India navigates a complex space between transparency and national security. The RTI Act plays a vital role in promoting openness, while the OSA safeguards sensitive information. Ongoing legal interpretations and potential legislative reforms will determine how this balance evolves in the future.

2nd ARC Recommendations to Strengthen RTI Implementation

- **Uniform RTI Fee Structure**: Ensure that RTI fees are consistent across all states and aligned with central government rules.
- **More Payment Options**: Allow applicants to pay RTI fees using postal orders, making the payment process more accessible.
- **Single Window System**: Set up a Single Window Agency at the district level to simplify the filing of RTI applications and appoint Assistant Public Information Officers (APIOs).
- **Include Major NGOs**: Bring NGOs receiving substantial government funding (₹1 crore or more) under the RTI Act to ensure transparency.
- **Tackle Frivolous Applications**: Allow Public Information Officers (PIOs) to reject clearly frivolous or vexatious RTI requests with approval from the appellate authority.

Way Forward

To strengthen the impact and implementation of the Right to Information (RTI) Act, the following key steps are recommended:

- **Recommendation Implementation:** Implement suggestions from the report card on the Performance of Information Commissions in India by **Satark Nagrik Sangathan (SNS)** and the **Centre for Equity Studies (CES)**. This includes addressing issues such as defunct commissions and vacancies.
- **Filling Vacancies**: Ensure timely appointments of Chief Information Commissioners (CICs) and State Information Commissioners (SICs) to reduce backlog and improve institutional efficiency.
- **Enhancing Public Awareness:** Launch extensive awareness campaigns, especially targeting rural and marginalized communities, to encourage informed and active citizen participation.
- **Protecting RTI Activists:** Develop strong legal and institutional mechanisms to protect RTI users and whistleblowers from threats, harassment, and violence.

SOCIAL AUDIT

- **Social Audit is a process in which details of the resources, both financial and non-financial, are used by public agencies** for development initiatives and are shared with the people often through public platforms. It includes in-depth scrutiny and analysis of the working of an entity in which the public is involved vis-à-vis its social relevance.
- Social audit entails a collaborative evaluation of government schemes by both officials and affected individuals, emphasizing **transparency** and **accountability**. It empowers beneficiaries, fostering **active participation** and ensuring schemes are genuinely intended for their welfare.

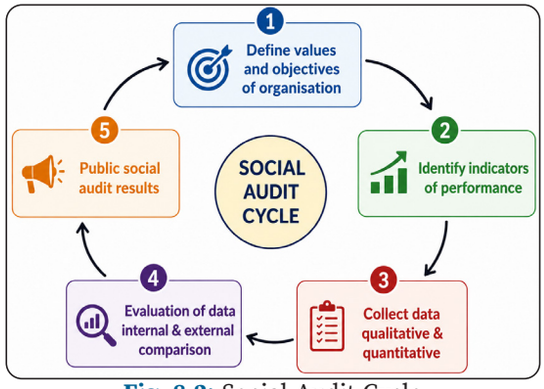


Fig. 8.2: Social Audit Cycle

EVOLUTION OF SOCIAL AUDIT IN INDIA

Period/Year	Event & Significance
1979	First social audit by Tata Iron and Steel Company (TISCO), focusing on organisational social accountability.
1990s	MKSS initiated Jansunwai in Rajasthan, linking social audits with citizen participation and RTI movement ("Hamara Paisa, Hamara Hisaab").
2002–07	73rd Amendment empowered PRIs and Gram Sabhas; 9th Five Year Plan emphasized social audits in governance monitoring.
2005–06	MGNREGA made social audits mandatory; Kerala pioneered full implementation.
2011 Onwards	Expansion under NRLM and across sectors like health, education, and infrastructure.
2010s	Institutionalisation through state-level Social Audit Units; Meghalaya enacted law for formal integration.
Recent Phase	Use of digital tools and civil society involvement (e.g., SAFAR) improved transparency and citizen oversight.

Principles of Social Audit

Drawing from global best practices, the following eight key principles are fundamental to the process:

- **Multi-Perspective (Polyvocality):** Social audits must reflect the views and experiences of **all stakeholders** involved—beneficiaries, employees, community members, and authorities—ensuring a diverse and representative assessment.
- **Comprehensive:** The process should evaluate **all aspects of an organization's work**, including its social, economic, and environmental impact, rather than limiting itself to selected programs or outcomes.
- **Participatory:** Stakeholders should be **actively involved** in the audit process, enabling them to contribute their values, feedback, and concerns. This fosters **ownership and transparency**.
- **Multidirectional Feedback:** The audit encourages **two-way or multidirectional communication**, where various stakeholder groups both **share and receive** feedback, promoting dialogue and improvement.
- **Disclosure:** Verified social audit findings should be **publicly disclosed** to all stakeholders and the broader community, reinforcing the principles of **transparency and accountability**.

Significance of Social Audit

Social auditing is a powerful tool for improving the effectiveness and transparency of social sector programs. Here's how it benefits various stakeholders:

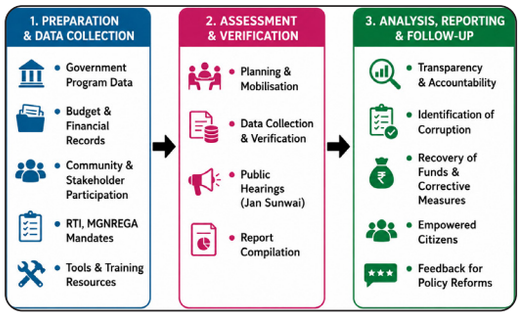


Fig. 8.3: Social Audit Process

Increased Transparency and Accountability

- **Reduces Corruption:** Social audits deter corrupt practices, ensuring funds are used appropriately. (e.g., MGNREGA social audits in **Rajasthan** and **Andhra Pradesh**)
- **Strengthens Oversight:** Publicly available data allows monitoring of government programs and addressing grievances. (e.g., Social audit facilitators in India resolved **32%** of grievances)

Improved Program Design and Delivery

- **Identifies Implementation Gaps:** Social audits reveal discrepancies between program goals and outcomes. **Eg: In MGNREGA programme, Social Audits identified** close to 3 lakh cases of financial misappropriation amounting a total of Rs 658 Crore, combining audits of both 2018-19 and 2019-20.
- **Promotes Stakeholder Engagement:** Stakeholders' voices are heard, leading to more inclusive and effective programs.

Stronger Governance and Development Outcomes

- **Empowers Local Communities:** Social audits strengthen Gram Sabhas, promoting participatory democracy. (e.g., Social audits in **Kumli Gram-Panchayat Chhattisgarh**)
- **Supports Inclusive Development:** Social audits ensure marginalized communities' needs are addressed.

Promotes Evidence-Based Decision Making

- **Provides Data for Impact Measurement:** Social audits provide data for measuring program impact and informing future interventions. (e.g., Society for Social Audit, Accountability and Transparency [SSAAT] in **Andhra Pradesh**)
- **Increases Efficiency and Effectiveness:** Social audits identify areas for improvement, leading to better program outcomes.

Do you know?

Innovative Practices in Social Audit

Chhattisgarh

- **Holistic Grievance Collection**: Social Audit Teams gather complaints not just related to MGNREGA but also other public service issues, which are forwarded to the Sarpanch and Sachiv for resolution.
- **Community Involvement through Wall Writing:** Critical documents such as muster rolls, bills, and measurement books are displayed on village walls to ensure transparency and facilitate public scrutiny.

Karnataka

- **Rotation of Audit Staff:** After every three rounds of social audit, the staff are reshuffled. This practice helps in maintaining objectivity, minimizing local biases, and enhancing the credibility of the audit process.

Challenges of Social Audit in India: Stifling Potential

Limited Scope and Implementation

- **Fragmentary Focus**: MGNREGA social audits in Andhra Pradesh often overlook work quality and labor law compliance, as per a **2021 CAG report**.
- **Sporadic Nature**: Social audits across states like Rajasthan lack consistency, with varying frequencies observed, according to a **2023 study by PRS Legislative Research**.
- **Data Constraints**: Tracking migrant populations poses challenges for assessing program reach and impact, especially in initiatives like adult literacy, as highlighted in a **2022 report by the Centre for Budget and Governance Accountability**.

Lack of Capacity and Standardization

- **Auditor Expertise**: Many states lack trained social auditors, leading to superficial audits missing critical details, as noted by **Transparency International India in 2021**.
- **Standardization Issues**: The absence of a standardized social audit mechanism hinders effective comparison of program effectiveness across states, according to the **PRS Legislative Research study**.

Institutional and Implementation Issues

- **Independence Concerns**: Social audit units in Telangana lack independence, being housed within the government machinery, according to a **2022 CAG report**.
- **Weak Enforcement**: Inadequate penalties for social audit norm violations undermine their deterrent effect, as highlighted by **PRS Legislative Research**.

Knowledge Nuggets

Critical Analysis of Social Audit Implementation in MGNREGA

- **Non-compliance with Rules:** Despite formal provisions, many Social Audit Units (SAUs) fail to seek records from Gram Panchayats, and often do not prepare or disseminate audit reports in local languages, violating basic transparency norms.
- **Lack of Institutionalization:** SAUs lack legal backing and autonomy, making auditors vulnerable to pressure from implementing agencies. This undermines their independence and effectiveness.
- **Weak Implementation Support:** Implementing agencies frequently delay reviews, withhold documents, and neglect follow-up actions on audit findings, rendering the process ineffective.
- **Absence of Legal Consequences:** The lack of penalties for ignoring or manipulating audit procedures reduces the audit's deterrent value, making it a mere formality in many areas.
- **Political Interference:** The appointment of SAU directors often lacks transparency and is influenced by political interests, compromising credibility.

Strengthening Social Audit in India

Enhance the Legal and Institutional Framework

- **Model Social Audit Law:** Enact a national act modeled on Meghalaya's 2017 law to mandate public service audits and empower community participation.
- **Independent Audit Units:** Establish autonomous social audit bodies with sufficient staff and resources (e.g., Andhra Pradesh's SSAAT model).
- **Support CAG and PRIs:** Strengthen the role of the CAG and enhance Panchayati Raj Institutions' capacity for conducting and managing audits.

Empower Stakeholders

- **Public Awareness and Training:** Launch education campaigns for Gram Sabha members and train auditors in audit procedures.
- **NGO and Media Involvement:** Partner with NGOs and engage the media to spread awareness and encourage accountability.
- **Incentives**: Recognize active participants in social audits to encourage wider engagement.

Standardize and Digitize Audit Processes

- **Online Access and Transparency:** Develop platforms for public access to audit reports and PRI records.
- **Proactive Disclosure:** Ensure government agencies release information in advance to aid audits.
- **Unified Guidelines:** Implement standard audit methodologies across sectors for consistency.

Adopt and Scale Best Practices

- **Chhattisgarh:** Integrates broader grievance redress and promotes wall writing for transparency.
- **Karnataka**: Ensures auditor neutrality by rotating audit teams every three cycles.

SOCIAL ACCOUNTABILITY

- Social accountability is **an obligation and responsibility on the part of the government** to be answerable to the citizens for its actions. Accountability of government officials is a cornerstone and a must for ensuring good governance.
- The process concludes with the holding of public hearings at which the findings are reviewed and disparities are revealed in front of service providers, officials, and beneficiaries.

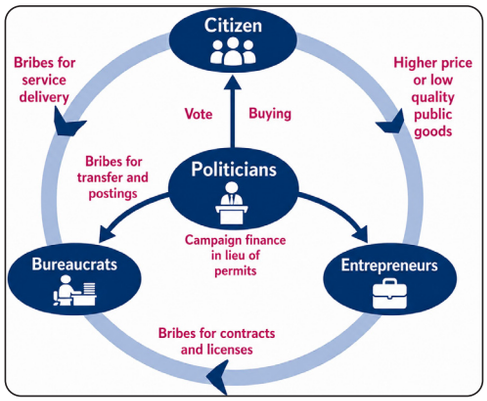


Fig. 8.4: The wheels of Corruption

Issues with Conventional Accountability

- **Limited Citizen Participation:** Accountability remains confined to executive–legislature or inter-governmental processes, excluding citizens.
  - **Example:** Council of Ministers, Parliamentary Committees, Lokpal.
- **Weak Grievance Redressal:** Lack of citizen empowerment leads to unresolved grievances and poor trust in governance.
  - **Example:** Inaction by bodies like CVC or Lokpal.
- **Policy Ineffectiveness:** Policies are designed without ground-level understanding, resulting in poor outcomes.
  - **Example:** Earlier poverty eradication programmes based on perceived needs.
- **Executive Discretion:** Accountability bodies often exercise discretion, leading to bias and conflict of interest.
  - **Example:** Grievance committees including members linked to accused officials.

Social Accountability: A More Effective Mechanism than Conventional Accountability

- **Empowers Citizens:** Social accountability gives citizens the power to hold government institutions and officials accountable, ensuring their rights are upheld. **Eg.,** In Kerala, the practice of 'Participatory Planning and Policy Formulation' empowers citizens by actively involving them in decision-making processes.
- **Raises Awareness:** It enhances public awareness of laws and encourages advocacy for legislation, thereby fostering greater civic engagement. **Eg.,** Participatory Budget Analysis' in Gujarat raises awareness about government initiatives and the allocation of budget resources.
- **Grievance Redressal:** A key component of social accountability is the efficient mechanism for addressing grievances, ensuring timely action against ineffective officials or policies. **Eg.,** Citizen Surveys and Citizen Report Cards, used in cities like Bangalore and Maharashtra.
- **Improved Governance**: By promoting citizen participation, social accountability improves governance, leading to more effective development outcomes and better service delivery. **Eg.,** The Participatory Expenditure Tracking System (in Delhi and Rajasthan) and Citizen Charters (in Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka).

Do you know?

- Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan (MKSS), a grassroots organisation founded in Rajasthan, used social audits to shatter the state's monopoly on official scrutiny and legitimize people participation in hitherto exclusive state issues.
- Kerala's People's Campaign for Decentralized Planning: Its success has been ascribed to significant financial and functional devolution, as well as institutional incentives for participation, which have resulted in increased representation of formerly marginalized voices such as SCs, STs, and women.

Challenges Associated with Social Accountability

- **Coercion from Vested Interests:** Communities hesitant to participate in social accountability due to **coercion** from influential entities.
- **Ineffective Grievance Redressal:** Lack of effective mechanisms to address grievances diminishes the impact of social accountability projects.

- **Resistance to Reform:** Entrenched interests obstruct transparency efforts by withholding critical information.
- **Citizens' Complacency:** Powerful individuals benefiting from corruption or wrongdoing undermine overall accountability efforts.

Strengthening Social Accountability in India

- **Draft Bill 2020 Provisions:** Ram Lubhaya committee submitted its draft bill in 2020, which included provisions aimed at ensuring greater social accountability. **Key Provisions of the Draft Bill are:**
  - **(a) Grievance Redressal Mechanism**: Starting from village panchayats and involving public hearings at the block level.
  - **(b) Transparency in Governance**: Incorporates provisions for transparency, citizens' participation, and public hearings.
  - **(c) Social Audit**: Ensures regular audits of governance and decision-making processes.
  - **(d) Information and Facilitation Centres**: Establishment of centers to facilitate access to information.
  - **(e) Decentralization of Processes**: Shifts power to local levels, ensuring more localized decision-making.
  - **(f) Independent Grievance Redressal Structure**: Ensures that grievances are addressed without undue influence.
- **World Bank's Recommendations (2004 Report)**
  - **(a) Long Route to Accountability**:
    - **(i)** Citizens need to use political processes to hold the state accountable.
    - **(ii)** This relationship, termed 'voice,' ensures citizens can express their demands to policymakers.
    - **(iii)** The 'compact' is the state's responsibility to ensure that these demands are communicated to service providers and that services are delivered effectively.
  - **(b) Short Route to Accountability**: This model is more applicable to private firms but can be extended to public institutions for day-to-day accountability.

WHISTLEBLOWERS PROTECTION ACT

Whistleblowing is the **act of exposing the alleged bribery, incompetence, corruption, fraud, or unethical behavior within public, private, or third-sector organizations** by an authority figure or the public.

Whistleblowing allegations have increased in the private sector in recent years, with reports of governance issues in **Adani Group by the Hindenburg.**

Types of Whistleblowers

- **Internal Whistleblowers:** These individuals report misconduct or unethical practices within the organization to higher authorities or internal management. The responsibility for investigation and resolution lies with the organization itself, without involving external entities.
- **External Whistleblowers:** These individuals report wrongdoing to external parties, such as regulatory bodies, the media, or government officials. This course of action is typically taken when internal mechanisms are ineffective or when the issue is of public concern.

Whistleblower Protection Framework in India

- **Public Interest Disclosure and Protection of Informers (PIDPI) Resolution, 2004**: The Central Vigilance Commission (CVC) administers the complaints and ensures anonymity for the whistleblower.
- **UN Convention Against Corruption (2005):** India became a signatory to this convention, which emphasizes the importance of reporting corruption in both public and private sectors while safeguarding whistleblowers from retaliation.
  - **Doha Declaration 2025 of UNCAC (COSP-11):** Calls for leveraging digital technologies, including AI, to strengthen international cooperation in combating cross-border corruption.
- **Companies Act, 2013:** Sections 206-229 focus on inspection and inquiry, with Section 208 authorizing an inspector to examine records for potential misconduct.
  - Section 210 allows the Union Government to investigate suspected illegal activities, based on reports from inspectors or company registrars.
- **Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI):** Requires all listed companies to establish a whistleblower policy and ensure employees are aware of it.
  - In December 2019, SEBI introduced a reward system for informants who report violations of insider trading laws.
- **Whistleblowers Protection Act, 2014:** Aims to protect individuals who expose corruption, misuse of power, or criminal activities by public servants.

Whistleblowers Protection Act 2014: Salient Features

Whistleblower Protections

- **Identity Protection:** The Act ensures the anonymity of whistleblowers. Only the Vigilance Commission can disclose their identity to the department head if absolutely necessary. Penalties are enforced for any unauthorized disclosure.
- **Protection from Victimization:** Individuals who file complaints in good faith are shielded from harassment or retaliation.

Complaint Procedures

- **Time Limit:** Anonymous complaints are prohibited. The complainant must disclose their identity for the investigation to proceed. Complaints can be lodged within a period of **seven years from the occurrence of the wrongdoing.**
- **False Complaints:** Intentionally or unknowingly making false accusations can result **in imprisonment (up to 3 years) and a fine (up to Rs 50,000).**
- **Dispute Resolution:** Individuals dissatisfied with a Competent Authority's decision have a window of **60 days** to appeal to the High Court.

Challenges with Whistleblower Protection Act, 2014 (UPSC 2015)

- **Lack of Anonymity:** The Act mandates disclosing the whistleblower's identity, posing a significant threat in cases where revealing oneself could be dangerous.
- **Ineffective Organizational Implementation:** Many organizations lack clear guidelines or training programs to educate employees about the whistleblower program. This creates confusion and discourages employees from utilizing the proper channels for reporting.
- **Limited Protection for Whistleblowers:** The Act offers minimal protection for whistleblowers, making them hesitant to submit evidence to authorities for fear of repercussions.
- **Rise in Whistleblower Complaints:** Despite limitations, whistleblower complaints are increasing in India. Companies listed on the National Stock Exchange received over 3,500 complaints in 2018.



Case Study: Prominent Whistleblowers in India

1. **Arvind Gupta, the activist in the ICICI loan fraud:** He exposed the alleged loan fraud and quid pro quo between Chanda Kochhar, who was then CEO, and her family. Following the accusations, Kochhar stepped down.
2. **Satyendra Dubey (2003):** A senior officer in the NHAI, Dubey blew the whistle on corruption in awarding contracts. Tragically, he was later murdered, highlighting the dangers faced by whistleblowers.
3. **Aruna Roy (2011):** Roy, a social activist associated with the Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan (MKSS), exposed irregularities in the implementation of the Right to Food Act.
4. **IFS Officer Sanjiv Chaturvedi (2009-Present):** Chaturvedi, an Indian Forest Service officer, tirelessly exposed corruption in forestry and environmental clearances. However, he continues to face bureaucratic hurdles and transfers.
5. In 2012, Indian Police Service (IPS) officer **Narendra Kumar Singh** uncovered a mining scam in Morena district of Madhya Pradesh.

Case Study: Global Whistleblowers and Prominent Leaks

- US government charged **Jack Teixeira**, a 21-year-old employee with the Massachusetts Air National Guard's intelligence wing, for allegedly leaking highly sensitive documents on to the internet.(2023)
- **Wikileaks (2006-Present):** Founded by Julian Assange, platform for anonymous leaks on war crimes, corruption, and malpractices.
- **Frances Haugen (2021):** Leaked Facebook documents revealing awareness of product harm and misinformation.
- **The Pegasus Project (2021):** Revealed governments using Pegasus spyware to target activists and journalists.
- **The Panama Papers leaks (2016):** Detailed offshore entities, exposing global tax evasion.

Satyam Scandal (2009) (UPSC 2015)

The **Satyam Scandal (2009)**, one of India's largest corporate frauds, saw chairman **Ramalinga Raju** admitting to inflating assets by **₹7,800 crores**. It exposed major **corporate governance failures, weak regulation,** and **lack of accountability**, prompting urgent reforms.

Key Corporate Governance Reforms Post-Satyam

- **Companies Act, 2013:** Replaced outdated laws, ensuring **greater accountability**. **Eg:** Introduced **independent directors**, whistleblower protection, and enhanced disclosures.
- **National Financial Reporting Authority (NFRA):** Regulates auditors to prevent fraud.
- **Increased Powers of the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO):** Given more authority to probe corporate fraud.

- **Whistleblower Protection Mechanism :** The **Companies Act, 2013** mandates a Vigil Mechanism for employees to report fraud.
- **Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR):** Made CSR spending mandatory for qualifying companies under **Section 135.**

The Satyam scandal prompted major **corporate governance reforms** under **SEBI, NFRA,** and the **Companies Act, 2013**. While improvements have been made, **technology, stricter penalties**, and **better financial monitoring** remain key to long-term transparency and investor trust.

Measures Needed for Whistleblower Protection

2nd ARC Recommended Following Measures

- Appropriate legislation must be enforced to protect innocent whistle blowers.
- Legislation should be enacted immediately to provide protection to whistleblowers on the following lines proposed by the **Law Commission:**
  - Whistleblowers exposing false claims, fraud or corruption should be protected by ensuring confidentiality and anonymity, protection from victimization in career, and other administrative measures to prevent bodily harm and harassment.
- The legislation should cover corporate whistleblowers unearthing fraud or serious damage to public interest by wilful acts of omission or commission.

Best International Practices

1. **Canada:** To receive reports and investigate matters that maintain a whistles' privacy, Canada has established a Commissioner for Integrity in the Public Sector.
2. **UK:** Likewise, the UK has a Civil Service Office to promote honesty, integrity and impartiality in the public sector.
3. **United States:** The United States adjudicates the decisions by the Bureau of Supervisory Counsel and the Merit System Protection Board (MSPB).

LOKPAL AND LOKAYUKTA ACT 2013

Lokpal and Lokayukta are established under the Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act, 2013, these are key anti-corruption bodies in India. Lokpal functions at the central level (including oversight of the Prime Minister and MPs), while Lokayuktas operate at the state level. They promote transparency and accountability by investigating corruption complaints against public officials, thereby strengthening governance and public trust.

Features of Lokpal and Lokayukta Act (2013)

The Lokpal and Lokayukta Bill	❖ Lokpal and Lokayukta Bill was Passed by the Parliament on 17th December 2013 ❖ Came into force on 16th January, 2014 and has been amended once in 2016 since its notification.
Composition	❖ Multi-Member body ❖ Chairperson with a maximum of 8 members (50% judicial members). ❖ A minimum of 50% of members shall be from SCs, STs, OBCs, Minorities and Women.
Qualification	❖ Judicial Member: Current or former judges of SC or CJ of HC. ❖ Non-Judicial Member: Eminent person min. 25 years expertise & special knowledge of Anti-Corruption Policy, Public Administration, Vigilance, Finance, Insurance Banking, Law & Management.
Jurisdiction	❖ Over Prime Minister, Ministers, Members of Parliament and Groups A, B, C and D officers and officials of the Central Government. ❖ Institutions which are financed fully or partly by Govt. are under the jurisdiction of Lokpal, but institutions aided by Govt. are excluded. ❖ It also covers any society or trust or body that receives foreign contribution above ₹10 lakh

Appointment	❖ For Lokpal: By President. ❖ For Lokayukta: By Governor. ❖ Selection Committee (3 Members): PM + Speaker + Leader of the Opposition (LS) + CJI or CJI Nominee from SC + an eminent jurist to be nominated by President on recommendations of first four members of the selection committee. ❖ Search Committee: To assist the Selection Committee (50% of the members shall be from SCs, STs, OBCs, Minorities and women).
Tenure/Salary	❖ Term: 5 Years or the age of 70 years. ❖ Salary/ Allowance: Chairperson equivalent to CJI and Member-Judge of SC.
Resignation	To the President.

Lokpal and Lokayukta (Amendment) Act, 2016

- ❖ The amendment modifies the **Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act, 2013,** particularly concerning the reporting of assets and liabilities by public officials.
- ❖ **It allows the leader of the largest opposition party** in the Lok Sabha to be included in the selection committee for appointing the Lokpal, in the absence of a formally recognized Leader of Opposition.

Challenges with Respect to Lokpal and Lokayukta Institution (UPSC 2013)

- ❖ **Selection Issues:** Delays due to ambiguity over LoP in selection panel; recommendation to include leader of largest opposition party.
- ❖ **State-Level Gaps:** Several states/UTs have not aligned Lokayukta laws with the 2013 Act; incomplete appointments.
- ❖ **Structural Corruption:** Deep-rooted corruption in political and bureaucratic systems limits effectiveness.
- ❖ **Limited Powers:** Lokpal can recommend action but cannot address systemic governance failures.
- ❖ **No Anonymous Complaints:** Restriction discourages whistleblowers from reporting corruption.
- ❖ **Time Limitation:** Seven-year limit for complaints may be inadequate in many cases.
- ❖ **Penalty for False Complaints:** Strict punishment may deter genuine complainants.
- ❖ **Reactive Approach:** Focuses on post-facto action rather than preventing corruption.
- ❖ **Low Public Awareness:** Weak civic engagement reduces accountability.
- ❖ **Transparency Issues:** Non-transparent processes (e.g., complaints against PM) and limited suo motu powers.

Way Forward for Working of Lokpal and Lokayukta

- ❖ **Strengthening functional autonomy:** The institutions need more independence to effectively combat corruption.
- ❖ **Financial and administrative independence**: Both Lokpal and Lokayukta must operate independently from the government entities they are tasked to investigate.
- ❖ **Transparency and leadership:** Greater transparency in operations, empowerment of citizens, and strong leadership willing to be held accountable are vital for the success of these institutions.
- ❖ **Timely Disposal of Cases:** Addressing the backlog of pending cases and expediting the resolution process.
- ❖ **Active Participation of Opposition:** Ensuring active involvement of opposition parties in the appointment process for impartiality and accountability.

2nd ARC recommendations

- ❖ PM should be kept out of the purview of Lokpal, any enquiry into a Prime Minister's official conduct by any authority other than the Parliament would severely undermine the Prime Minister's capacity to lead the government.
- ❖ Providing constitutional backing to the office, along with financial autonomy could enhance its functioning.

11th All India Lokayukta Conference (2012) suggested following reforms for enhancing effectiveness of Lokayukta

- ❖ Make Lokayukta the nodal agency for receiving all corruption complaints.
- ❖ Accord Lokayukta jurisdiction over State-level probe agencies.
- ❖ Bring bureaucrats under the ambit of the Lokayuktas.
- ❖ Accord powers of search and seizure, and powers to initiate contempt proceedings
- ❖ Provide administrative and financial autonomy to the Lokayukta for better functioning.
- ❖ Bring Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs), funded by the government, under the Lokayukta's jurisdiction

Supreme Court Split Verdict on Section 17A (PCA, 1988)

- **Context:** The Supreme Court delivered a **split verdict** on the constitutionality of Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988.
- **Status:** Due to divergent views, the matter has been **referred to a larger bench**.

Key Highlights

Justice B.V. Nagarathna (Anti-Shield View)

- **Equality Before Law:** Violates **Article 14** by creating a *privileged class* of public servants.
- **Bottleneck for Justice:** Government control over approval may lead to **protection of favourites** and institutionalised corruption.

Justice K.V. Viswanathan (Pro-Efficiency View)

- **Policy Paralysis:** Lack of protection may discourage **bold decision-making** by honest officers due to fear of harassment.
- **Reputation Protection:** False FIRs can damage an officer's career (*civil death*), hence a **filtering mechanism is necessary**.
- **Recommendation:** Approval should be given by an **independent body (Lokpal/Lokayukta)** instead of the government to avoid conflict of interest.

What is Section 17A?

- **Provision (2018 Amendment):** Requires **prior approval** before investigating a public servant's official actions.
- **Approval Authority:**
  - Centre → Union Government
  - State → State Government
  - Others → Authority competent to remove the officer
- **Exception:** No approval needed if caught **red-handed taking a bribe**.
- **Timeline:** Decision within **3 months (extendable by 1 month)**.

Significance of Section 17A

- **Prevents Policy Paralysis:** Encourages officials to take decisions without fear.
- **Filters False Cases:** Protects against malicious or politically motivated complaints.
- **Protects Reputation:** Avoids unnecessary damage to honest officers.
- **Administrative Stability:** Builds confidence in bureaucracy.
- **Procedural Fairness:** Ensures investigations are not arbitrary.

Challenges and Concerns

- **Conflict of Interest:** Approval by Executive → violates *Nemo judex in causa sua*.
- **Delay in Investigation:** 3–4 month delay may lead to **evidence destruction**.
- **Weaken Agencies:** Limits autonomy of **CBI and anti-corruption bodies**.
- **Equality Issue:** Creates **double standards** between citizens and public servants.
- **Moral Hazard:** May protect corrupt officials under the guise of protection.
- **Arbitrariness:** Difficult to judge intent (official duty vs corruption) without inquiry.

Section 17A attempts to balance **accountability and protection**, but risks **shielding corruption** if misused. Reform through **independent approval mechanism** is key to ensuring both **efficiency and integrity**.

CENTRAL BUREAU OF INVESTIGATION (CBI)

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) is India's premier investigative agency, primarily responsible for investigating high-profile corruption cases, economic offenses, and other serious crimes.

Legal Authority of CBI: The CBI is not a statutory body but derives its authority from the Delhi Special Police Establishment Act, 1946.

- It serves as the primary investigating agency of the Central Government and plays a crucial role in preventing corruption and ensuring administrative integrity.
- The CBI also provides assistance to the Central Vigilance Commission and Lokpal.

Administration of CBI

Appointment

- **Selection Committee:** The appointment of the CBI Director is made by a Selection Committee consisting of the following members:

- Prime Minister of India (Chairperson)
- Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha (member)
- Chief Justice of India or a Judge of the Supreme Court nominated by the Chief Justice (member)

- **Selection Process for the CBI Director:** The Selection Committee recommends a candidate for the CBI Director's post to the President of India.
  - On approval, the selected candidate becomes the CBI Director.
- **Removal**: The removal of the CBI Director is subject to certain conditions and is outlined in the CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation) Special Police Establishment Act, 1946:
  - **Terms of Service:** The Director of the CBI holds office for a fixed term, generally not exceeding two years. This term can be extended in exceptional cases with the approval of the Selection Committee.
  - **Resignation**: The Director can resign from the post by submitting a resignation letter to the President of India.

Challenges Faced by CBI

- **Political Interference:** Dubbed a "**caged parrot**" by the Supreme Court due to excessive **political meddling**.
  - Often used by administrations to suppress misdeeds and control opposition.
- **Operational Challenges:** Delayed investigations, exemplified by prolonged inquiries such as the Jain hawala diaries case.
  - Loss of credibility due to mishandling of high-profile cases like Bofors and Hawala scandals.
- **Accountability and Resources:** Exempted from **Right to Information Act**, lacking public accountability.
  - Acute shortage of personnel and limited financial resources hamper effectiveness.
- **Limited Powers and Access:** Investigative powers subject to state government agreement, restricting jurisdiction.
  - Need prior authorization from the Central Government to probe officials at high levels.

Measures Needed

- **Autonomy and Statutory Standing:** Separate CBI from government control to ensure independence.
  - Provide statutory standing similar to other institutions like Comptroller and Auditor General.
- **Enhanced Resources and Infrastructure:** Increase financial resources and administrative empowerment with accountability.
  - Invest in better infrastructure facilities to improve efficiency.
- **Legal Reforms:** Replace DSPE Act with a dedicated statute, enhancing operational clarity.
  - Introduce new legislation to regulate CBI's operations, as recommended by the Second Administrative Reforms Commission.

Do you know?

Withdrawal of General Consent by States: Understanding the Story

- **Legal Framework: Section 6** of the **Delhi Special Police Establishment Act, 1946**, mandates State consent for CBI investigations outside Union Territories.
  - **Entry 80** of the **Union List** allows extension of police powers with State permission.
- **Types of Consent:**
  - **General Consent:** Enables CBI to probe cases without seeking fresh permission for each investigation.
  - **Specific Consent:** Required when general consent is withdrawn, hindering seamless investigations.
- **State Actions: Mizoram** became the first state to withdraw general consent in **2015**, followed by **Maharashtra, Punjab, Rajasthan, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Kerala**, and **Mizoram**.
  - Allegations of the central government using CBI for **political targeting** prompted the withdrawals, primarily in **opposition-ruled states**.
- **Impact of Withdrawal:** CBI loses power to register fresh cases involving central government officials or private individuals without state consent.
  - Officers lose police powers upon entering the state, hindering investigations.
- **Legal Precedents:** The Supreme Court in a recent order held that the CBI does not require the sanction of a state government to register an FIR under a Central legislation against a Central government employee.
  - In **Kazi Lendhup Dorji v. CBI** (1994), withdrawal did not affect pending investigations.
  - Calcutta HC's ruling in **Vinay Mishra vs. CBI** emphasized equal treatment in corruption cases regardless of consent status.

ENFORCEMENT DIRECTORATE

Enforcement Directorate (ED) is a multi-disciplinary organization tasked with investigating economic crimes in India, particularly focusing on money laundering and violations of foreign exchange laws. It is responsible for enforcing economic laws and ensuring compliance with regulations to curb economic offenses. The ED operates under the **Department of Revenue**, Ministry of Finance, Government of India.

Primary Objective

- The ED's primary goal is to combat the generation and circulation of black money.
- It works to ensure compliance with foreign exchange laws and prevent money laundering.

Appointment Structure

- Director of Enforcement Directorate
  - The Director of ED is appointed under the provisions of the Central Vigilance Commission Act, 2003.
  - The appointment is made by a committee led by the Central Vigilance Commissioner, with members from the Finance, Home, and Personnel and Training Ministries.
- Tenure and Security
  - The Director's tenure is a minimum of two years, and any transfer requires approval from the appointing committee.

Statutory Functions of the Enforcement Directorate

- **The Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA):** The ED investigates crimes involving money laundering and traces assets derived from criminal activities. The ED also works toward the confiscation of illicit assets through Special Courts.
- **The Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999 (FEMA):** ED investigates violations related to foreign exchange and monetary transactions under FEMA, ensuring compliance with India's economic and trade policies.
- **The Fugitive Economic Offenders Act, 2018 (FEOA)**: Under FEOA, the ED is authorized to attach and confiscate the assets of fugitive economic offenders who have fled India to evade the law.
- **Sponsoring Agency under COFEPOSA**: Under the Conservation of Foreign Exchange and Prevention of Smuggling Activities Act (COFEPOSA), the ED sponsors preventive detention cases related to FEMA violations.

Difference between the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and Enforcement Directorate (ED)

Feature	Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI)	Enforcement Directorate (ED)
Establishment	Founded in 1941 as the Special Police Establishment	Established in 1956 as the Enforcement Directorate
Jurisdiction	Deals with corruption, economic offenses, etc.	Primarily handles economic crimes (money laundering, FEMA violations)
Parent Body	Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances, and Pensions	Department of Revenue, Ministry of Finance
Scope of Authority	Investigates cases based on the Prevention of Corruption Act	Enforces laws like PMLA, FEMA, and economic offenses
Investigative Powers	Conducts investigations, arrests, files chargesheets	Conducts inquiries, attaches properties, and makes arrests
Types of Cases Registered	Corruption, criminal cases, high-profile investigations	Money laundering, financial frauds, economic crimes

Issues in the Functioning of the Enforcement Directorate

- **Lack of Resources:** ED operates with a limited budget, restricting its capacity to thoroughly investigate and prosecute complex economic crimes.
- **Lack of Cooperation**: ED faces challenges in obtaining cooperation from other law enforcement agencies, such as the State Police and CBI.
- **Foreign Jurisdictions**: Cooperation with foreign jurisdictions for investigations is often difficult due to differing legal frameworks and privacy laws.
- **Political Interference:** There are concerns regarding political interference in ED's investigations, which can impact the agency's ability to work independently and impartially.
- **International Data Sharing:** Stringent privacy laws in several countries hinder ED's ability to access crucial financial and banking data from foreign institutions.

Knowledge Nuggets

The Supreme Court of India has declared the two tenure extensions granted to the Director of the Enforcement Directorate (ED), beyond the fixed cut-off date as "not valid in law."

Measures to Strengthen the Enforcement Directorate

- **Ensure Functional Autonomy:** ED should be granted functional independence and protection for officers from political influence to enhance its efficiency and impartiality.
- **Provide Statutory Backing**: Ensuring statutory status for the ED can help maintain its independence and effectiveness in enforcing laws.
- **Infrastructural Upgradation:** The ED should invest in modern infrastructure and technology to improve its investigative capabilities.
- **Increase Financial Resources:** Adequate financial resources should be allocated to the ED to enhance its operations without government interference.
- **Streamline Information Sharing**: Improved coordination with other law enforcement agencies and international bodies is essential for more effective enforcement of economic laws.

Key Words

Transparency, Right to Information (RTI), Social Audits, Whistleblowing, Accountability, Corruption, Public Participation, Democratic Principles, Information Commission, Judicial Accountability, Public Authorities, Citizen Empowerment, Grievance Redressal, Electoral Bonds, Legal Framework, Institutional Autonomy, Public Trust, Social Accountability.

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	Discuss the profound impact of recent amendments to the Right to Information Act on the autonomy and independence of the Information Commission.	2020
2.	Analyze the legal, political, economic, social, and cultural factors contributing to the decline of public morality in India, as reflected in Transparency International's integrity index.	2018
3.	Discuss the role of the Public Accounts Committee in establishing accountability of the government to the people.	2017
4.	In the integrity index of Transparency International, India stands very low. Discuss briefly the legal, political, social and cultural factors that have caused the decline of public morality in India.	2016
5.	Discuss the changes brought in corporate governance post the Satyam Scandal (2009) to ensure transparency and accountability.	2015
6.	"For achieving the desired objectives, it is necessary to ensure that the regulatory institutions remain independent and autonomous." Discuss in the light of the experiences in the recent past.	2015
7.	'A national Lokpal, however strong it may be, cannot resolve the problems of immorality in public affairs.' Discuss.	2013

9 Role of Civil Services in Democracy

Civil Services in India consist of government officials who form the permanent executive branch of the nation. These services have played a crucial role in transitioning from a colonial governance system to one focused on welfare. Often described as the steel frame of governance, the civil services have provided stability and facilitated seamless transitions between governments over the years.

CONSTITUTIONAL PROVISIONS RELATED TO CIVIL SERVICES

- The civil service is governed by Part XIV of the Constitution (**Article 308-323**).
- **Article 309:** It empowers the Parliament and the State legislature to regulate the recruitment, and conditions of service of persons appointed, to public services and posts in connection with the affairs of the Union or of any State respectively.
- **Article 310**: Anyone holding any post connected civil services holds office during the pleasure of the President or Governor of the State.
- **Article 311**: Dismissal, removal or reduction in rank of persons employed in civil capacities under the Union or a State.
- **Article 312:** All India Services.

Need of Civil Services in Democracy

Civil services are essential to the governance of a democracy, providing the administrative backbone that manages the nation's complex and diverse needs. Key functions include:

- **Stability and Continuity:** Civil services maintain governance stability and policy continuity across political changes, exemplified by the Indian Administrative Service's role in supporting governance through different political regimes.
- **Expertise and Specialization:** Recruitment through competitive exams, such as the UPSC Civil Services Exam in India or the Federal Reserve's staffing in the U.S., brings specialized knowledge into public administration, enhancing decision-making.
- **Impartiality and Non-partisanship:** Civil servants uphold neutrality, focusing on public welfare over political interests, a principle central to the trust and efficiency seen in Singapore's Civil Service.
- **Local Adaptation of Policies:** They bridge national intentions and local needs, adapting policies to regional specifics. This is crucial in programs like India's MGNREGA, which tailors employment solutions to rural demands.
- **Efficiency and Accountability:** Civil services ensure timely policy implementation and are accountable for their conduct, with systems in place for addressing misconduct, as seen in the UK's meritocratic and accountable civil service system.

Role Played by Civil Services

- **Advisory Role in Policy Making:** They assist the executive in defining policy-making areas. They formulate policy proposals, evaluate different options and solutions, develop a programme of action for current policies, as well as make necessary corrections.
- **Institutionalise Socio-economic change:** They play a critical role in development and act as an instrument of the welfare state and harbinger of modern ideas in society.
- **Agent of development:** The services perform a variety of developmental functions like promoting modern techniques in agriculture, promoting the industry, trade, banking functions, bridging the digital divide, etc.
- **Discharge Delegated Functions:** At various levels of government, power and accountability are delegated to civil servants.
- **Administer Law of the Land:** It governs the behavior of people in society by enforcing rules.

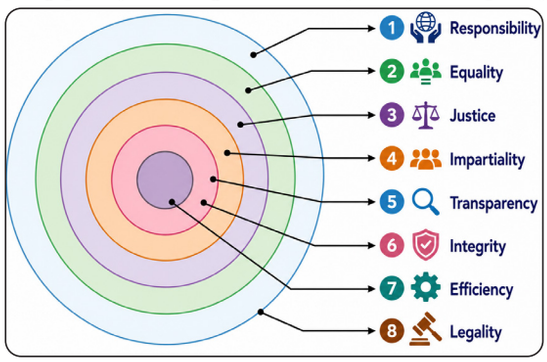


Fig. 9.1: 8 Spheres of Professional Public Servant

- **Watchdogs:** They act as protectors of public assets and safeguard public property. E.g. **Sanjiv Chaturvedi's IFS in Kurushetra** registered an FIR against contractors for illicit tree felling and poaching of hog deer.

Challenges in Indian Civil Services (UPSC 2014, 2016, 2017)

- **Generalist Service**: A generalist civil service is criticized for being unable to meet challenges thrown by a specialized socio-economic set up. Eg: a generalist civil servant may not be suited for the specialized role of the governor of RBI.
- **Inefficient Incentive Systems**: The meritorious and honest civil servants are not rewarded. **E.g** Ashok Khemka (IAS) transferred 56 times in his 30 years of service.
- **Outdated Rules and Procedures:** Prevent civil servants from exercising independent judgment and performing efficiently. **E.g.** Promotion is based on seniority and not based on performance and efficiency.
- **Lack of Adequate Transparency and Accountability Procedures**: Various committees and surveys have found that unethical practices have become common in the civil service and that public perceptions of their uprightness, neutrality, and fairness have deteriorated. **E.g.** Physical torture instead of scientific investigation by IPS officer Balvir Singh in Tamil Nadu.



Fig. 9.2: Effective Civil Servants

- **Arbitrary and Whimsical Transfers**: Frequent and arbitrary transfers of civil servants undermine administrative stability, reduce efficiency, and expose officers to political pressure. **E.g. Ashok Khemka**, an IAS officer from Haryana, who has been transferred 57 times in his career of 33 years, often after exposing irregularities or taking bold administrative decisions.
- **Issues Affecting Neutrality and Effectiveness of Civil Services in India (UPSC 2017)**
  - **Political Interference:** Frequent transfers and undue political influence hinder bureaucratic independence, affecting policy continuity. Eg: The 2013 Ashok Khemka case, marked by over 50 transfers, highlights excessive political interference in civil service.
  - **Bureaucratic Red Tapism:** Excessive procedures delay decision-making, reducing efficiency and responsiveness.
  - **Lack of Performance-Based Promotions:** Seniority-based promotions undermine meritocracy, reducing motivation for efficiency. Eg: The Second ARC (2008) proposed performance-linked promotions, is still not fully implemented.
  - **Resistance to Digital Reforms:** Slow adoption of e-governance oriented tools reduces efficiency and transparency.

Bureaucratic Culture Hampers Socio-Economic Development (UPSC 2016)

- **Lack of Accountability: Officers often escape responsibility** for failures in meeting development targets.
- **Resistance to Innovation:** Bureaucratic reluctance hampers the rollout of digital governance and reforms. **For instance: Initial resistance to the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT)** system delayed its effective rollout.
- **Cronyism and Corruption:** A bureaucratic-political nexus distorts priorities in favor of vested interests. **Eg: The Vyapam scam in Madhya Pradesh** revealed deep-rooted corruption involving both bureaucrats and politicians.

CIVIL SERVICES REFORMS

Recent Initiatives to Promote Efficiency and Accountability in Civil Services:

- **Mission Karmayogi –** National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building: Launched in 2020, Mission Karmayogi aims to transform the Indian civil services by enhancing their efficiency, effectiveness, and accountability.
- **Delayering and Delegation in Decision-Making:** In November 2024, the government directed all ministries and departments to review and streamline their decision-making processes, ensuring that the levels of disposal and channels of submission do not exceed four. This initiative aims to reduce bureaucratic delays and enhance efficiency.
- **360-Degree Feedback Mechanism:** To promote accountability and holistic evaluation, a 360-degree feedback mechanism has been introduced for the appraisal of senior civil servants. This system gathers feedback from peers, subordinates, and superiors, providing a comprehensive assessment of an officer's performance and behavior.

Do you know?

The Supreme Court said that successful civil services aspirants have no right to be allocated a cadre of their choice or their home state, and also noted that before selection they opt to serve anywhere in the country 'with eyes open' but later scramble for home cadre. The applicant as a candidate for the All-India Service with eyes wide open has opted to serve anywhere in the country.

- **Lateral Entry of Specialists:** Recognizing the need for specialized skills in the bureaucracy, the government has initiated lateral entry of domain experts into senior positions in the civil services. This move aims to bring in fresh perspectives and expertise, enhancing the overall efficiency and effectiveness of governance.
- **Good Governance Week:** "Prashasan Gaon Ki Ore": Celebrated annually in December, Good Governance Week is a nationwide campaign aimed at addressing public grievances and enhancing service delivery across India. The 2024 edition focused on taking administration to the grassroots level, ensuring transparency and accountability in governance.
- **AIS Rules Revision & Tenure Fixation:** The All India Services Rules were amended to include provisions for fixed tenure of postings.
- **State-Level Legislation:** Maharashtra enacted a law in 2005 mandating a 3-year tenure for IAS and state officials.

Doctrine of Democratic Governance: Enhancing Public Trust in Civil Servants' Integrity (UPSC 2024)

The Doctrine of Democratic governance relies heavily on the integrity and commitment of civil servants. Article 311 of the Indian Constitution ensures their protection, underscoring the significance of their role in upholding the trust and accountability necessary for effective administration.

- **Trust and Governance:** Public trust in civil servants strengthens democratic systems.
- **Compliance and Law Enforcement:** Trust in civil servants ensures adherence to laws, especially during crises. Eg: Compliance with COVID-19 guidelines was higher due to trust in the Ministry of Health.
- **Policy Implementation Cooperation:** Trust encourages public participation for effective policy execution. Eg: Swachh Bharat Abhiyan succeeded due to mass public cooperation driven by trusted civil servants.
- **Corruption Deterrence**: Integrity of civil servants promotes accountability and deters corruption. Eg: The 2nd ARC emphasized civil service reforms to enhance ethical governance.
- **Public Service Commitmen**t: Dedicated civil servants enhance public perception of governance. Eg: T.N. Seshan's electoral reforms and strict enforcement of rules restored public trust in democratic institutions.

MAJOR COMMITTEES AND COMMISSIONS ON CIVIL SERVICES REFORMS IN INDIA (UPSC 2020)

The Indian government has implemented several strategic measures to reform the civil services, aiming to enhance efficiency, transparency, and adaptability. Key initiatives include:

- **First ARC (1966):** Headed initially by Morarji Desai and later by K. Hanumanthaiah.
  - Recognized the need for specialisation in government functions, leading to the formulation of a selection method for senior management posts in both functional and non-functional areas. Focused on lateral entry to technical posts at the senior level, aiming to bring in expertise from various domains.
- **Second ARC (2005):** Constituted in 2005, it was chaired by Veerappa Moily. Its key recommendations included:
  - **Restructuring the Civil Services Examination:** Conducting Preliminary and Main Examinations together on consecutive days or shortlisting candidates based on Preliminary results.
    - Inducting officers of State Civil Services into IAS through a common examination.
- **Mandatory Training and Capacity Building:** Mandatory training at the induction stage and periodically throughout a government servant's career.
  - Implementation oversight of the National Training Policy (1996) through a monitoring mechanism.
- **Accountability and Anti-Corruption Measures:** Suggestions for a Code of Ethics for civil servants.
  - Establishment of Lok Pal and Lok Ayuktas for complaint redressal.
- **Performance Appraisal and Promotion:** Shift from Annual Confidential Report (ACR) to performance assessment.
  - Emphasis on objective assessment against agreed work plans for promotions.
- **Kothari Committee (1976):** The Committee recommended a sequential system for civil service examination.
  - This innovative approach led to a three-stage examination process: a Preliminary examination with an objective type format covering Optional and General Studies, a Main examination with 9 written papers, and a concluding Personality Test.
- **Satish Chandra Committee (1989):** In 1989, the Satish Chandra Committee was tasked with suggesting reforms to the existing Civil Services Examination pattern proposed by the Kothari Committee.

Do you know?

The **T. S. R. Subramanian & Ors. v. Union of India & Ors. The case** marked a significant ruling by the Supreme Court of India. In this case, the Court clarified that civil servants were not obligated to adhere to verbal instructions.

- An 'Essay' paper was introduced, and the marks allocated for the Interview were enhanced.

- **Y.K. Alagh Committee (2001):** With a vision for comprehensive re-shaping and re-structuring, the committee proposed significant changes to the Civil Services Examination.
- **Hota Commission (2004):** It made several recommendations which include:
  - Reforming the civil service examination to introduce domain specialization.
  - Reducing the weightage of the General Studies paper in the civil service examination and putting more emphasis on specialized subjects.
  - Raising the age limit for the civil service examination from 28 years to 30 years.
- **Khanna Committee (2010):** The Civil Services Aptitude Test (CSAT) was introduced after the recommendations of the Khanna Committee. However, this exam was reduced to the nature of just a qualifying exam after protests from Hindi medium students.
- **Baswan Committee (2016):** The Committee recommended the reduction of the upper age limit for general category candidates to be brought down to 26 years from 32 years at present.

CIVIL SERVICE-RELATED ISSUES IN NEWS

The Generalist vs Specialist Debate

Aspect	Generalist Bureaucracy	Specialist Bureaucracy
Roles and Responsibilities	Versatility in roles, adaptable across various administrative areas.	In-depth focus on specialized roles with deep domain expertise.
Leadership Positions	Assumes leadership positions at higher administrative levels.	Expert advisors in specific domains may; face challenges in leadership roles requiring diverse skills.
Decision-Making	Broad administrative perspective, contributing to holistic policy development.	Specialized knowledge for evidence-based decision-making in specific fields.
Training Programs	Comprehensive training programs, like those at LBSNAA, to develop a broad skill set.	Domain-specific training to excel in technical and specialized roles.
Adaptability Challenges	May face challenges in specialized technical roles requiring deep domain knowledge.	Necessitates adaptability to the rapidly evolving governance landscape.
Strategies for Balance	Rotational postings, inter-service collaboration, and flexible recruitment policies.	Emphasizes flexibility, collaboration, & opportunities for rotational roles to balance expertise.

LATERAL ENTRY ISSUE

Lateral entry refers to the direct recruitment of domain experts from the private sector, academia, or public organizations into mid- and senior-level positions in the government, bypassing the traditional UPSC examination route. This approach aims to infuse specialized skills and fresh perspectives into the bureaucracy.

Recommendations of Various Expert Groups/Committees Regarding Lateral Entry

- **1st Administrative Reforms Commission:**
  - It recognised the need for specialization as the functions of the government had become diversified.
  - ARC highlights that performance appraisals may be adopted from the armed forces, which could aid in weeding out non-performers.
  - Surinder Nath Committee in 2003 and Hota Committee in 2004 also recommended domain expertise in civil services.
- In 2005, the **second Administrative Reforms Commission (ARC) recommended** lateral entry at both the Central and state levels.
  - ARC highlights that performance appraisals may be adopted from the armed forces, which could aid in weeding out non-performers.
- **Earlier instances of lateral entrants:** Nandan Nilekani, Montek Singh Ahluwalia, Vijay Kelkar, Arvind Subramanian, and Raghuram Rajan have all been brought in from outside the services to lead various committees and organizations.

Need of Specialist or Domain Expert

- **Technical knowledge:** These domain experts can provide ground level insight and real challenges associated with policy formulation and its implementation.

- **Complex situations:** The functions related to administration are now becoming more and more complex, technical and subject specific, hence only a specialist can deal with them effectively.
- **Lack of field knowledge:** The generalist or traditional bureaucrats are not aware of reality in the field. **E.g.** IAS officers with Arts as education background cannot understand cyber security challenges.
- **Improvements in governance and performance:** NITI Aayog's Three-Year Action Agenda for 2017-2020, as this will "add competitiveness to the existing career bureaucracy."
- **Fill the officer vacancy gap**: the country is short of nearly 1,500 IAS officers (Ministry of Personnel Data) **E.g. Baswan Committee (2016)** also advocated lateral entry to fill these vacancies.
- **Entry and retention of talent in government**: According to the Sixth Central Pay Commission report (2006), lateral entry will "ensure entry and retention of talent in the government even for those positions that have a high demand and premium in the open sector.

Knowledge Nuggets

In the past, economists such as Montek Singh Ahluwalia, Bimal Jalan, Dr. Manmohan Singh, Arvind Virmani, and Sam Pitroda, among others were appointed to senior positions, which played a key role in attracting them back from high-paying international careers.

Arguments Against Lateral Entry

- **Lacking Field Experience:** External talent lacks the breadth and scope of field experience that the civil service provides. **E.g.** Wall-street bankers fail to understand the social impact of his economic policies.
- **Issue with execution**: Career civil servants are better at bridging the gap between policy making and ground level execution than external talent.
- **Instances of failure:** Even the domain experts at times have failed miserably. **E.g.** The Case of Air India.
- **Internal tussle:** A vote of no confidence in the government personnel management system will result from a large-scale lateral induction.
- **Undermines the role of civil servants:** Civil Servants are already institutionalized operating in the well-established scenarios with efficiency. Lateral entry will kill their morale.

Way Forward

- **Transparent Recruitment Process:** Establish clear guidelines and criteria for lateral entry appointments to ensure fairness and meritocracy.
  - In the UK, the Civil Service Fast Stream program recruits candidates with specialized skills and expertise directly into various levels of the civil service
- **Inclusion of Reservation Policies:** Consider integrating reservation provisions to uphold social justice and diversity in appointments.
- **Orientation and Training:** Provide comprehensive training to lateral entrants to familiarize them with governmental procedures and administrative nuances.
- **Performance Evaluation:** Implement robust performance appraisal systems to assess the effectiveness of lateral entrants and ensure accountability.
- **Balanced Approach:** Adopt a hybrid model that combines the strengths of career civil servants and domain experts to enhance governance outcomes.

Do you know?

- In August 2024, UPSC launched its largest lateral entry drive, advertising 45 senior posts across ministries. However, the advertisement was later withdrawn after criticism over the lack of reservation for SC/ST/OBC candidates.
- Lateral entry appointments are excluded from the reservation system due to the application of the **13-point roster policy.**
  - This policy allocates reserved posts (for SC, ST, OBC, and EWS) based on a rotational system across a batch of 13 vacancies. However, each lateral entry is treated as an individual or "single post", making it ineligible for reservation since no rotation can be applied to a solitary vacancy. As a result, these positions are filled without adhering to reservation norms.

MISSION KARMYOGI

Mission Karmayogi is a national program launched by the Government of India in September 2020 to reform the capacity and mindset of civil servants and make them more efficient, skilled, and citizen-centric.

Key Objectives

- Improve functional, behavioral, and domain competencies of civil servants.
- Make public service delivery more efficient, transparent, and accountable.
- Promote continuous learning through digital platforms like iGOT Karmayogi.

- Shift from a generalist to a specialist approach in public administration.

Salient Features

- **Change from a 'rules-based' to a 'Role based HR Management' approach**: Human Resource (HR) Management involves aligning civil servants' work assignments by matching their skills to the job requirements.
  - **To build a common training technology environment,** which includes learning materials, institutions, and staff.
  - To apply a Framework of Roles, Activities, and Competencies (FRACs) approach to all Civil Service positions.
  - Apart from domain awareness preparation, the scheme will also concentrate on "functional and behavioral competencies," as well as a performance assessment management process.
- **Programme module and institutional structure:** The Integrated Government Online Training (iGOT) Karmayogi Platform will be utilized to deliver the program.
  - In terms of capacity building, the platform will incorporate carefully curated digital e-learning content.
  - Additionally, it will integrate other service-related matters such as confirmation following a probationary period, deployment, job assignment, and vacancy notice.
- **Human Resources (HR) Council of the Prime Minister:** Under the Chairmanship of the Prime Minister, it will act as the apex body for providing strategic guidance to the mission.

Challenges Associated with the Programme

- **Conservative outlook of Indian bureaucracy:** The Indian bureaucracy remains essentially unchanged and conservative. It opposes reforms and new ideas.
  - Distance self-learning can help frontline workers gain complementary skills and refresh their experience, but it isn't always the best option for developing core knowledge.
- **Overcentralization of the system:** A decentralized training and learning framework is required for a dynamic public service workforce.

Intended Benefits of Mission Karmyogi

- **Enhancing Governance**: Accountability and Transparency in service delivery will enhance governance. Further, this will promote the responsiveness of civil servants toward the need at local level.
- **Citizen-Centered Approach:** "On-site learning" will help bridge the gap between the government and the people. Further, this will promote the responsiveness of civil servants toward the need at local level.
- **Reduce Training Gap:** The lack of mid-level training at all levels has created a disparity between generalization and specialization. Thus, it will reduce this gap.
- **Technology-Driven Learning:** Civil servants of India become more creative, competent, progressive, and technology-enabled as a result of technology-driven learning and standardization of training goals and pedagogy across institutes.

Knowledge Nuggets

Impactful Case Studies of Civil Servants

1. **Dr. Rajendra Bharud, IAS – Nandurbar (Maharashtra)**
   - **Initiatives:** Apart from COVID work, he improved tribal education by building hostels and motivating students to pursue competitive exams.
   - **Impact:** Rise in school enrollment, reduced dropout rates, and tribal youth pursuing higher education.
2. **Armstrong Pame, IAS – The 'Miracle Man' of Manipur**
   - **Initiative:** Mobilized funds via Facebook to build a 100-km road in a remote part of Manipur without government funds.
   - **Impact:** Connected 7000+ villagers; showcased community participation in development.
3. **Krishna Teja, IAS – Chittoor (Andhra Pradesh)**
   - **Initiative:** Launched "Disha app" awareness campaigns for women's safety and digitized grievance redressal through "Spandana" in rural areas.
   - **Impact:** Improved public trust in administration and women's access to safety mechanisms.
4. **Supriya Sahu, IAS – Tamil Nadu**
   - **Initiative:** Led Tamil Nadu's "Green Tamil Nadu Mission" for massive tree plantation and environmental restoration.
   - **Impact:** State-wide environmental awareness and local community engagement in afforestation.
5. **Rohini Sindhuri, IAS – Mysuru (Karnataka)**
   - **Initiative:** Land encroachment clearance drive, digital property records, and COVID hospital transparency.
   - **Impact:** Recovered 1,000+ acres of public land; improved public health response.

CIVIL SERVICES BOARD

A **Civil Services Board (CSB)** is a high-level body constituted by the government to manage postings and transfers of senior civil servants, particularly those from the **All India Services (IAS, IPS, IFoS)**. It aims to ensure **transparency, stability, and merit-based decisions** in bureaucratic appointments.

Significance of Civil Services Board

- **Insulate civil servants from political pressure:** It helps to protect the bureaucracy from political pressure and puts an end to unnecessary and frequent transfers of civil servants, which is a major cause of low civil servant morale and low administrative standards.
- **Promote sense of objectivity:** It will also facilitate civil servants in maintaining neutrality and objectivity in their work.
- **Promote sense of term security:** Officials would be able to have effective administration if they have a set tenure and it will ensure good governance in service delivery.

Limitations of Civil Service Board

- **Lack of Compliance:** To date, only 20 states have created a CSB, with Punjab being the most recent to do so in 2020. Madhya Pradesh and Tamil Nadu, for example, have not followed the mandatory rules for establishing the board.
- **Conflict of Interest:** The board would be led by bureaucrats who may have a vested interest in the outcome of the process. Neutrality is not ensured.
- **Interference of political class:** Governments have the authority to amend, change, or refuse the civil service board's recommendation for reasons that must be recorded in writing.
- **Insecurity among Political Executives:** Political executives often feel insecure, believing that their control has been weakened by the fixed tenure provision, as the Civil Services Board (CSB) holds exclusive authority to review transfer recommendations.

Knowledge Nuggets

Other Initiatives for Capacity Building

- **Capacity Building Commission (CBC):** Established in 2021 as an autonomous body under DoPT, CBC aims to streamline and standardize capacity building across civil services. It comprises three members from diverse sectors and is supported by a dedicated Secretariat.
- **National Standards for Civil Service Training Institutions (NSCSTI):** Developed by the Capacity Building Commission, these standards aim to assess and enhance the capabilities of Central Training Institutes (CTIs), ensuring uniformity and high quality in civil service training to address 21st-century governance challenges.
- **Aarambh (2019):** India's first-ever common foundation course for civil service trainees, promoting inter-service collaboration and a shared understanding of governance.
- **National Training Policy (1996, revised 2012):** Aims to build a professional, efficient, and citizen-centric civil service through structured and continuous training.

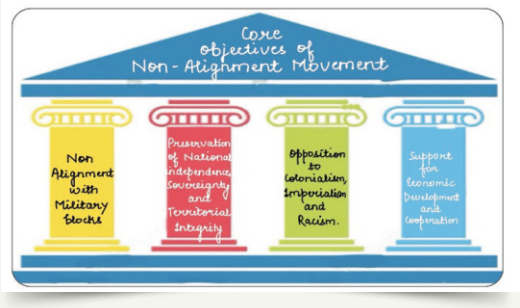
Key Words

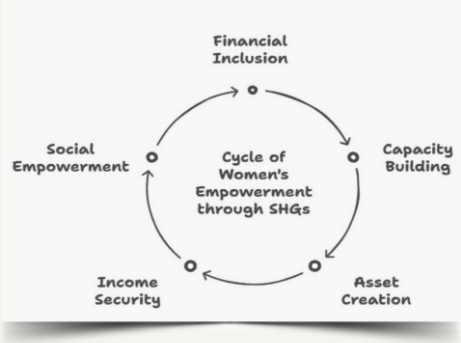
Civil Servants: Architects of a New India, Leading with Integrity, Delivering for All, Bridging the Gap Between Policy and People, From Red Tape to Red Carpet, Bold Reforms for a Bright Future, Empowering Efficiency, Citizen-Centric Governance, From Gatekeepers to Facilitators, Smart Governance, Red Tape Reduction, Smart Bureaucracy

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	The Doctrine of Democratic Governance makes it necessary that the public perception of the integrity and commitment of civil servants becomes absolutely positive. Discuss.	2024
2.	"Institutional quality is a crucial driver of economic performance". In this context suggest reforms in the Civil Service for strengthening democracy.	2020
3.	Initially Civil Services in India were designed to achieve the goals of neutrality and effectiveness, which seems to be lacking in the present context. Do you agree with the view that drastic reforms are required in Civil Services. Comment.	2017
4.	"Traditional bureaucratic structure and culture have hampered the process of socio-economic development in India." Comment.	2016
5.	Has the Cadre based Civil Services Organization been the cause of slow change in India? Critically examine.	2014

PILLAR DIAGRAM

- **Details:** A foundation (base) supporting multiple pillars, each representing a key element or factor contributing to the overall structure.
- **Used For:** Pillars of Good Governance, Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) etc.



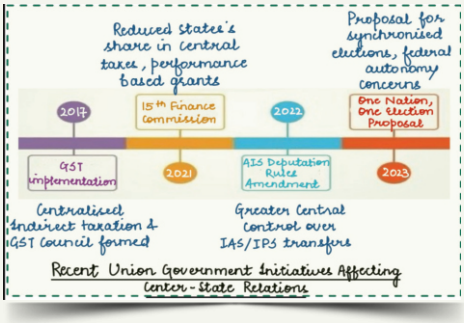


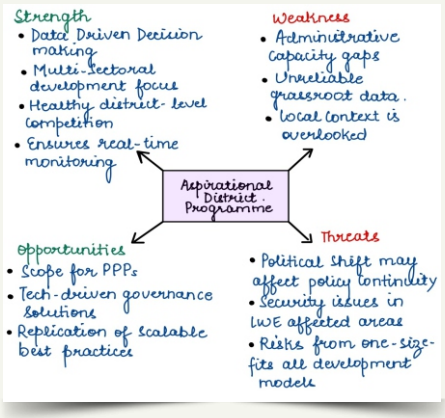
CIRCULAR FLOW DIAGRAM

- **Details:** A circle showing movement or recycling of elements.
- **Used For:** Women empowerment through SHG's, Circular economy, Consequences of gender injustice etc.

TIMELINE DIAGRAM

- **Details:** Linear flow of key events or reforms.
- **Used For:** Historical events, policy evolution etc.



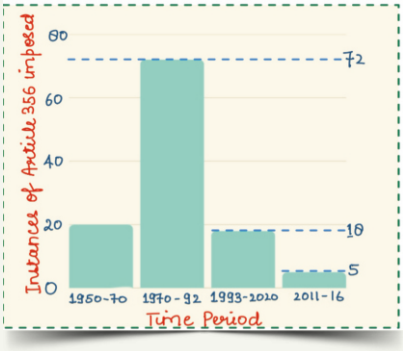


SWOT ANALYSIS

- **Details:** 2x2 matrix showing strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats.
- **Used For:** SWOT of Local Governance System etc.

BAR CHART

- **Details:** Comparative representation of data.
- **Used For:** Article 356 imposition, Total no of Women judges over the years, Crime rate over the years etc.



NOTE: *In Mains answer writing, diagrams are powerful tools. They simplify complex ideas, conserve space, and reflect structured thinking, making your answers stand out. To help you, we've created* ***10 easy-to-use diagram formats*** *tailored to different question types. However, always remember that diagrams cannot substitute content; they are meant to complement your answer. Hence, use them wisely.*

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